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Afrosurrealism Through Art: A Metaphysical Study of the Route to Higher Consciousness and Meaning Through Portrayals of Art and Entertainment Multimedia

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Abstract

AfroSurrealism is a concept that 'presupposes that beyond this visible world, there is an invisible world striving to manifest, and it is our job to uncover it recognizing that nature, including human nature, generates more surreal experiences than any other process could hope to produce.' This paper argues the key difference between AfroSurrealism and classical surrealism, and in parallel rhetoric, in African metaphysical philosophy and Western metaphysical philosophy, with a focus on meaning. This extends to the hierarchical understanding of life, experiential development of awareness due to prolonged historic subject to suffering, and communal understanding of existence. What is lacking in the Western framework of surrealist art and philosophy is a aforementioned communal understanding of life, rather an individualistic mindset of existence in addition to the effect of crimes against humanity and its influence on the collective spirit and inspire stagnated consciousness. This paper explores a 'route' to higher consciousness through the application and subjective analysis of art in literary and visual media, abiding by personal moral appeals as opposed to a rigorous philosophical framework.

Introduction

Metaphysics grapple with questions that transcend the physical realm, endeavoring to explore the fundamental nature of reality and existence. Seeking to understand the fabric of being, exploring phenomena such as identity, time, space, causality, and the potential existence of a higher order or ultimate reality that defies empirical scrutiny. Philosophers in this arena debate the ontological status of abstract concepts like numbers and universals, whilst also pondering the metaphysical underpinnings of mind and consciousness. The discipline serves as a bridge between the empirical world accessible to science and the abstract domains navigable only through reason, inviting provocative inquiries into the essence of entities and the principles that govern them, thus forming an indispensable foundation for the broader philosophical enterprise. Metaphysical philosophy, with its expansive purview, offers a rigorous framework for examining abstract realms of reality like spirituality and the subconscious, domains that often resist empirical measurement or direct observation. This is pivotal to its necessary inclusion in AfroSurrealist studies. In exploring spirituality, metaphysicians contemplate the possibility of an immaterial dimension of existence, considering the nature and ontological status of the soul, divine entities, or a universal spirit. This metaphysical inquiry into spirituality seeks not only to probe the reality of such phenomena but also to understand their relationship to the physical world and human experience. When delving into the subconscious, metaphysical philosophy interrogates the nature of the mind and its faculties, distinguishing between conscious awareness and the obscure undercurrents that influence thought and behavior. For good reason, this study will draw from this segment of philosophy to explore different branches of Surrealism by art through the analysis of multimedia.

Justification of Study

In increasingly multicultural societies, understanding the historical and sociological influences shaping varying racial and ethnic groups can go far to foster empathy and promote unity. This study, therefore, stands in a critical position not only from a historical and sociological standpoint but also by means of exploring the link between art, philosophy, neuroscience, and consciousness. Engaging with experts of philosophical thought, African art and neuroscience, this research taps into a deeply understudied area of academia and calls for increased inquiry within this space, creating potential for illuminating findings. Furthermore, the interdisciplinary nature of the study mirrors the interconnectedness of our societies, ultimately attempting to foster a broader understanding of our shared humanity. Through highlighting patterns of higher consciousness that emerge from shared experiences and cultural histories, this study may offer a valuable contribution to developing a culturally nuanced approach to consciousness studies and the perception of reality. This potential research strives to bridge the chasm between art, cultural diversity, and higher consciousness.

Beyond its immediate academic relevance, this research could potentially revolutionize how academics and researchers perceive and interpret cultural differences in higher consciousness, shedding light on the intersection of cultural history, subconscious realities, and conscious understanding. Its findings will not only broaden the dialogue around cultural studies, but also promote a more inclusive and nuanced narrative in understanding individual and collective realities. This is necessary as humanity has impressively maintained itself in a state of grave danger for centuries, continuously unable to avoid moral degradation and the self sabotaging of its divinity. This paper most dually serves as a call to consciousness for any passing reader. It's hard to ignore the realities of living in an increasingly unconscious society. Outside of the glaring global signs of Earthly unrest, the ever current dehumanization of black and brown peoples. There exist national, state, neighborhood, familial, and interpersonal effects in a wound of this nature. There is a hierarchy to the effects of imbalance just as there are hierarchies to the cause. The effects of hopelessness in each of these factorial affected spaces is telling of the problem itself. The environment encourages the death of dreaming, possibility, education, and

imagination. How might current reality be designed to restrain and strengthen certain collectives? What of the concept of predestined fate, organized suffering? This can only be processed under the framework of a larger scope.

Technically, this paper is ultimately an analysis of the varying effects of time and space. It will study how isolated factors in space and time develop fractional individual consciousness that can be generalized into a collective consciousness. Then how that consciousness has come to represent itself in the space of entertainment and art across time, as one thing about the truth, it will out. And oftentimes through the form of expressive art Collective consciousness is not exclusive to any race group category. In this paper I will focus on highlighting the afro surrealist collective consciousness. While this paper intends to highlight the surrealist nature within the african conscious, it too serves to heed warning that any collective has the power to co-create a misshaped consciousness for the collective Isolating two groups and exposing them to different environments give them a unified conscious polarized to the verse grouping. How it takes an effect in this world. This paper will regard all life as equal, bound to equal weight and importance.

Research Question(s)

This paper will argue the key difference between AfroSurrealism and classical surrealism in context of African metaphysical philosophy and Western metaphysical philosophy, with a focus on understanding Intentionality, Effect, and cumulatively, Meaning. The following research questions have been designed to explore these narratives in an attempt to prove or disprove this argumentative thesis.

(1) Where do the true origins of surrealist thought lie?
(2) What are the glaring symmetries and/or polarizations between afro and classic surrealism? What do these findings tell about the underlying collective consciousness of each party and following individual likelihood?
(3) Do the manifestations of art and entertainment media reflect a truth of hightented collective and individual consciousness? Is this directly related to a history of suffering and its influence on faith?
    (a) How do these manifestations wharp current concepts on suffering relationship to morphing space and time, identity, and portrayal of art subjective truth?
    (b) What is the trigger that results in inter community dissociation? How can that be avoided? What is the trigger that can be leveraged for inter-community healing?

Literature Review and Theoretical Framework

In this philosophical research paper, literature review serves as a foundational element that both contextualizes the research within the wider philosophical discourse and provides a critical overview of the scholarly work that precedes it. It will act as a positional conversation in which this research situates itself, acknowledging the contributions of past academics and philosophers while carving out a unique space for the current inquiry. As it exists that AfroSurrealism is a very lucrative concept that is, while deeply metaphysical in nature, the core of metaphysical thought in regards to academic philosophy is rooted in Western thinkers. This review attempts to tie African branches of metaphysics to the reality of metaphysical presence in the art that is surrealist, while comparing to Western Metaphysics and classical surrealism.

African Philosophy and Metaphysics

African philosophy has long been debated for holding value or having existence at all. Much like other African concepts, like Igbo spirituality and Swahili Eshe, many of the core parts of African spirituality have been subjected to erasure. This however, creates an important link between this framework of thought and AfroSurrealist Art, as the latter is likely to have been born from the strategic erasure, denial, and suppression of the former. Thus a detailed look at African philosophy, here focused on African Metaphysics, will be drawn. Not only to understand where the framework differs from Western Metaphysical thinkers, but to provide it further academic legitimacy. African philosophy presupposes African metaphysics. It is that aspect of African philosophy that specifically studies the African distinctive notion of reality and existence. It does not necessarily suggest a contradictory notion of reality as conceived in Western metaphysical thought, but a peculiar way in which the African understands issues of existence and reality. Reality is one and universal but conceived differently by individuals based on their conceptions of life which makes everything around them meaningful. Metaphysics attempts a comprehensive view of reality by investigating whether there are principles that apply to everything that is real and if there is something which is ultimately real. Within this understanding, the African mind thinks in hierarchical categories and modes as against thinking in a single, isolated and individualistic manner. It understands reality as a dynamic and fluid relationship of things and therefore analyzes phenomena in terms of cause and effect, balance and conflict. Any metaphysical study worthy brings under its focus of study both transcendental and particulars of individual existence. This enables the study to investigate how particulars are related within the universal. Consequently, it aims at providing a comprehensive view of reality while not neglecting individual phenomena in the holism of reality. The basis of African metaphysics is 'Being'. These include personality, substance, causality, soul.

African philosophy strongly asserts the existence of a distinctly African metaphysics, which reflects African weltanschauung, universe of experience, and African reality of existence. This contrasts with the Western perspective, which has its own unique characteristics. Onyenwenyi (1985) argues that while the themes addressed in philosophy are universal, the treatment of these themes is relative to a people and shaped by their conceptions of life, rendering everything around them meaningful. Metaphysics, consequently, is a philosophical outlook that seeks a comprehensive, holistic view of reality while acknowledging the unique place of individual entities within this reality (Ozumba, 2004). As Africans navigate daily survival and grapple with fundamental questions about the purpose and meaning of existence, they naturally pose and seek answers to these existential questions. The questions they raise and the solutions they offer form the basis of "African Metaphysics." G. Ozumba notes that the process and methodology in African metaphysics may not be as rigorous and analytic as in contemporary Western philosophy. However, this does not diminish its academic or practical value. Just as the early Greek philosophers, such as the Ionians and pre–Socratics, were philosophically rigorous despite differing methods, African philosophy also possesses its own rigorousness. Esen (1982) and Anyanwu (1967) have both analyzed aspects of African thought that demonstrate its analytical and scientific nature. Esen, for instance, asserts that "the mind that thinks in hierarchical modes and categories, perceives relationships between things, and analyzes situations in terms of cause and effect, balance and conflict, must be scientific, logical, and analytic" (Esen, 94). However, the rigor, scientificness, and analyticity in African philosophy should not be directly equated with contemporary Western standards. Lack of documentation could not be "a minus to African philosophical strive as the ideas were stored in folk wisdom, mythologies, traditional proverbs, religion, world view, etc" (Ozumba, 2004). This is especially true once the means of erasure and condemnation of African thought, schooling, and forms of documentation are considered. G. Ozumba further contends that African metaphysics is pragmatic, with the acceptability of ideas, explanations, beliefs, or folk wisdom based on their practical efficacy, regardless of whether they fulfill certain objective criteria or realities. It is important to note that African pragmatism is not disconnected from the foundational ontology that underpins African understanding of reality. Divination is sometimes employed to uncover the ontological basis of phenomena, illustrating that in African metaphysics, empiricism and rationalism merge based on an operational ontology of "duality" or "complementarity of reality," which is anchored in the dualistic yet integrative cosmology of the African worldview. In this context, epistemology and metaphysics are inseparable, further enriching the complexity and depth of African philosophical thought.

The Meaning of Life

The Western idea of metaphysics dominates philosophy and references African metaphysics is seen far less within academia Regardless, the space is a fertile ground of studies within contemporary society and academics. Ozumba defines African metaphysics as "The African way of perceiving, interpreting and making meaning out of interactions, among beings, and reality in general. It is the totality of the Africans perception of reality. African metaphysics will therefore include systematization of African perspective as it relates to being and existence." This is to say Africans have a unique understanding of physical manifestation of spiritual truths in regards to the Meaning of Life.

But ambiguous are the phrases *meaning* and *meaningfulness.* The concept of meaning is about what all competing ideas about meaning are about. In the literature, meaning is thought of in terms of purpose, received or determined teleological ends that are worth pursuing for their own sake). Transcendence, things beyond our animal nature, Normative reasons for actions, and so forth. These singular or monistic views, while interesting, also have their flaws. They are short of capturing the intersectional and competing intuitions about meaning. Thaddeus Metz proposed a pluralistic account of meaning, telling that meaning consists of: roughly, a cluster of ideas that overlap with one another. "To ask about meaning [...] is to pose questions such as: which ends, besides one's own pleasure as such are most worth pursuing for their own sake; how to transcend one's animal nature; and what in life merits great esteem or admiration"(Metz, 2013, p. 34). Metz's family semblance theory is highly agreeable since the pluralism he employs allows one to accommodate most conceptions of meaning while rejecting peripheral ideas, pleasure or happiness, that do not, on their own, possess the quality of a final value needed in the usual understanding of what meaning entails. However, ideas about subjective accounts of meaning are lacking in Metz's concept. In addition, what about the meaning *of* life as opposed to meaning *in* life itself? These questions have led Attoe(2021), author of *African Philosophical Perspectives on the Meaning of Life*, to add two extra variables to Metz's family of values. The first, a subjective pursuit for those ends that an individual finds worth pursuing, insofar as the individual considers those values as ends in and of themselves. A glance at Metz's approach shows that although it is tenable, it is more objectivist than it is all–encompassing. By inserting subjectivity into his approach, subjectivist views about meaning are immediately accommodated, which are often found to be instrumentality incompatible with ideas about meaning (See Nagel, 1979, p. 16). The second variable proposed by Attoe (2021) being coherence. Coherence refers to the identification of a narrative that ties together an individual's life – perhaps those moments of meaningfulness or those actions that dot said life – such that the individual can adjudge her whole life as meaningful. This feature bears more on ideas about the meaning of life.

With this in mind, it is crucial to make further distinctions about the meaning *in* life versus the meaning *of* life as these concepts are different in origin and shall be used in accordance with that truth. Meaning *in* life referencing those instances of meaning that may dot an individual's life. Thus, a potent love partnership or the successful completion of a life accolade may subsist as a meaningful act or a moment of meaningfulness. With regards to the meaning *of life*, there are some, like Richard Taylor, who describes it as involving the meaning of *existence*, highly with regards to cosmic life, biological life, or human life/existence specifically. One can also use the term 'meaning of' in a narrower sense, where 'meaning of' delineates a judgment on what makes the life of a human person, considered as a whole (especially within the confines of an individual's lifetime), meaningful (Attoe, 2021). This understanding is similar to Nagel's understanding of the meaning *of* life. This distinction is notable because instances of meaning do not always pre-judge the meaning of the entire life of an individual. So, the individual obtaining an accolade can be a moment of meaningfulness (meaning in), but it would be hard to consider that individual's life as a whole to be ultimately meaningful (meaning of) if that individual spent his time killing others for no reason, despite gaining a degree or marrying a loved one.

The question of life's meaning is a perennial one and it's arguable that all other questions, philosophical, scientific, or religious, are attempts to offer some glimpse into the meaning—in this sense, purpose—of human existence. In philosophical circles, the question of life's meaning has been given some intense attention, from the works of Qoholeth, the supposed writer of the Biblical book, Ecclesiastics, to the works of pessimists such as Schopenhauer, and to twenty-first century thinkers on the topic such as Thaddeus Metz, African scholars are not left out. The following section provides a brief overview of some of the major theories of meaning that African scholars have proposed. This is done by tying together ideas from African philosophical literature in a bid to present a brief systematic summary of African views about meaningfulness. From these ideas, one can identify several theories of meaning in African philosophical literature. Examining these theories begins by understanding ontologically, Africans, as aforementioned, noted by Esen (1982) think in hierarchical categories. Beings do exist but in hierarchical structure. At the apex is the creator, Supreme Being known as AbasiIbom among the Ibibio/Efik, Odudumare by the Yorubas, Chineke or Chukwu in Igbo and Allah among the Hausa. AbasiIbom , unlike other beings in the hierarchy of beings, is transcendental in nature and pure spirit, therefore distant from the people. To depict its transcendental nature, the Ibibio at times refers to God as *Abasi asana enyong*, meaning "the God of the clearest sky". Everything, however, exists according to his plan and purpose. The ancestors are dear forefathers who were revered while alive because of their good standing in the society. At death they become an unfettered spirit, therefore, can interfere in the affairs of the living, and can also be approached by the living through rituals and sacrifices. It is the unfettered nature of the ancestors that provide the ontological basis for the African's idea of re-incarnation since, the ancestors through projection could naturally be re-born while still existing in the spirit World. Their ambivalent nature makes them susceptible to manipulations by men, analogous to the Greek gods and goddesses that were repudiated by ancient philosophers like Plato, who despised them as too anthropomorphic to be regarded as gods.

The Igbo believe that humans consist of three components: ahu (body), mkporu obi (soul), and mmuo (spirit), viewing humans as both physical and psychical entities (Ozumba, 2004). The Akan, as per Kwame Gyekye, see humans dualistically as okra (body) and nipadua (soul). The Ibibio believe humans have a composite nature of body (idem) and a dual soul (ukpong), with one soul uniting with the body and the other residing in plants and animals, known as ukpongikot or "bush soul" (Talbot, 1962; Ekong, 1985). This relationship is metaphysically complex, with the belief that harm to the "bush soul" negatively impacts the associated body, underpinning the Ibibio belief in transmigration of the soul and metempsychosis. Ekong (1985) notes that metempsychosis reflects the depth of the Ibibio worldview, which seeks to describe the essence of human experience. Ojong (1996) highlights the philosophical issue of the body-soul dichotomy, comparing it to Gilbert Ryle's "ghost in the machine," suggesting that the soul has its own characterization and can exist independently of the body.

Humans play a vital role in the community of beings, either as an intermediary cause, who exploits and manipulates the gods and nature to his advantage, or as the receiver of the causal effect. Although bound by space and time, humans can overcome these limits by acquiring some mysterious and esoteric knowledge of nature and of the gods. This is what Africans believed of the witches, wizards, sorcerers and traditional medicine men. Plants and animals, which constitute the terrestrial plane also, have a place in the hierarchical conception of beings. Understanding the relationship among beings involves recognizing force as the fundamental unifying factor.It is the permeation of force or spirit in all things that is responsible for whatever exist. Every being exists due to this force, with varying degrees of life force. Force is here understood as life, energy, power, dynamism, strength or what P. Temple's technically referred to in his *Bantu Philosophy* as vital force. Whatever exist, from the lowest to the highest being has a force. Every existence then exists in virtue of force, hence, different kinds of existence is a fraction (or function) of the degree of the life force in different beings. There is a supreme Spirit or Force, who is God, the force in the deities and the force of the ancestors, then the embodied force in man. There is also the force in animals, animate beings as well as inanimate beings. To get to the Supreme Being, man must go through the intermediacy of ancestors and minor duties. This dynamism of spirits and forces in nature is animate in the

means Africans invoke and talk to trees, rivers, mountains, stores, wood, etc. In this way, the Africans believe the spirit/force, which is the fundamental substance in reality, can be harnessed and manipulated to their personal benefits.

In the hierarchical structure of beings, humans are the dominant spirits among visible entities. God is the ultimate vital force, followed by divinities and ancestors, or the living dead, in the invisible realm. This African conception of reality prioritizes the spirit, though not in the exclusive manner of Descartes' dualism or the absolute spiritualism of Western thought. The Africans also give room to the physical but only as a secondary consequence. No being, however, exist in isolation but ontologically in connection and interaction with other beings, both animate and inanimate. An African therefore realizes himself only in the midst of hierarchy of beings, some acting above and others below, outside of which human beings have no existence (Unah, 1992). This interaction is called "communal spiritualism" by Momoh (2000), which is the culture of harnessing the spirit of the whole community for the benefit of the individual. This interaction, termed "communal spiritualism" by Momoh (2000), involves harnessing the spirit of the community for individual benefit. The visible grouping reflects the ontological order and harmony in the universe, animated by the dynamic power of the spirit, which is an aspect of reality rather than identified with God or something mysterious. Reality is dynamic, not static, singular, or dual (Idjakpo, 1995). Africans believe in a dualistic, cyclic, but regulated cosmology where any upset is an intrusion. The world and nature function optimally only with a proper balance of all elements in any situation. Extremes are avoided to maintain this balance. Despite the desire for harmony, conflicts and contradictions exist and play significant roles in African metaphysical thought by preventing monopoly in nature and revealing the mysterious nature of existence. These contradictions can highlight the uncertainty inherent in existence, making life dynamic and meaningful by considering unfulfilled expectations and disappointments. In the African worldview, events do not occur by chance; each has a cause that must be identified to restore or maintain harmony. Rituals and sacrifices are often employed to this end. In alignment with the theocratic nature of African cosmology, the Supreme Being is the ultimate cause, with ancestors and localized deities as intermediate causes, alongside witches, wizards, sorcerers, and traditional medicine men. Since the cosmos integrates spiritual and physical forces, every material event must also have a spiritual dimension. Treating an event solely as physical yields incomplete or transient results. Every event is traceable to a cause, which has to be identified if the harmony is to be restored or the event is to be properly understood and handled successfully. Rituals and sacrifices are often employed as veritable means of maintaining, and sometimes restoring the much cherished and needed harmony. To treat any event in isolation, only as physical, is to achieve no result or only transient one.

It is difficult to talk of freedom of man within this ontological hierarchy of being. Man acts and lives in accordance with his nature as a creation of the Supreme Being. Other beings and forces, the ancestors, witches, nature, etc., also play a determining role in man's existence. The African, however, do not rule out freedom of man. They believe that man is free and can take his destiny in his hands as the Igbo adage says; "if a man says yes, his Chi also affirms", after placating the gods through rituals and sacrifices. If there is any doubt, the diviner can be consulted for advice and direction. However, the Africans seem to abhor the idea of the absolute freedom of man. Man's freedom is in his free capacity to choose to work with nature or not. The former leads to man's successful living, while the later leads to man's peril. Evil or unsuccessful living is not caused by the gods but by man through the negative manipulation of the forces in nature and the ambivalent nature of the gods.

The Nature and Contents of African Metaphysics

Delving into what could be considered African conceptions of the meaning of life to fully understand the ideas that shall be put forth, a short detour is necessary to describe the metaphysics underlying African thought as this would offer proper lenses with which to see the African viewpoints. Anselm Jimoh highlights in *Metaphysics in African Philosophy*, African metaphysics is grounded in an interesting version of empiricism that allows a monistic growing harmonious relationship between material and spiritual aspects of reality. It is empirical because most African thinkers are willing to grant the possibility of material and spiritual manifestations in everyday life. Harmonious as one can point to certain acts as manifestations of these spiritual acts. Metaphysicians of this type pronounce the existence of spiritual realities and recognise said acts as spiritual. Thus, knowledge of the spiritual develops from certain manifestations that are verifiable by the senses. It assumes humans exist in physical manifestations of spiritual or immaterial truth, alignment, or in cases, misalignment. What is talked about as spiritual, does not diminish its empirical worth, since empiricism agrees that knowledge of whichever kind is attained from experience. Unlike much of Western metaphysics, which, as Innocent Asouzu states, is "inundated with all sorts of bifurcations, disjunctions and essentialization", African metaphysics considers the fragmentations we see in reality as evidence of a harmonious complementary relationship between and among realities. There is a tacit acknowledgment of the interplay between matter and spirit or between realities from all and any spectrum, such that each facet of reality is seen as equally important and the supposedly artificial divide between material and spiritual objects, non-existent. Ifeanyi Menkiti highlights this writing, "[T]he looseness or ambiguity regarding what constitutes the domain of the physical, and what the domain of the mental, does not necessarily stem from a kind of an ingrown limitation of the village mind, a crudeness or ignorance, unschooled, regarding the necessity of properly differentiating things, one from the other, but is rather an attitude that is well

considered given the ambiguous nature of the physical universe, especially that part of it which is the domain of sentient biological organisms, within which include persons described as constituted by their bodies, their minds, and whatever else the post-Cartesian elucidators believe persons are made of or can ultimately be reduced to. My view on the matter is that the looseness or ambiguity in question is not necessarily a sign of indifference to applicable distinctions demanded by an epistemology, but is itself an epistemic stance, namely: do not make distinctions when the situation does not call for the distinctions that you make." (Menkiti, 2004b, pp. 124-125) This messaging trickles down into the African socio-ethical space where achieving the common good or attaining one's humanity generally involves communal living or a innate and deep form of mutual coexistence – one that has a metaphysical backing. It is no wonder then that Africa is known for, and has provided the world with, series of philosophies that reflect harmonious coexistence – from Ubuntu (Ramose, 1999; Metz, 2017) to Ukama (Murove, 2007) to Ibuanyidanda philosophy (Asouzu, 2004; Asouzu, 2007) to Harmonious monism (Ijiomah, 2014), to Integrative humanism (Ozumba & Chimakonam, 2014), etc. Further it's something seen within culture, throughout many distinct and nonlocal African countries, time and culture has encouraged a development of tribal existence. What this slight but important detour seeks to show is that within the traditional African metaphysical space, most thinkers are inclined to believe that spiritual entities are, indeed, existent realities. It is also speculated that these spiritual realities can and do relate with other aspects of reality and that spiritual realities are not removed from our everyday reality – at least not in the way Descartes divided mind from matter – but are an integral part of our understanding of reality as a whole.

African metaphysics is holistic to the degree that its logic underlies the basis for the standards and expectations of the African in the sense that the metaphysical worldview of the African defines his/her attitude to situations and issues in everyday living. With the multiplex of cultures in Africa, it's inarguable that all African communities uphold the same standards nor share the same expectations, but the basis and underlying principles of their cultural values ultimately parallel. Therefore, this discourse is an abstraction that cuts across African communities and fairly represents the general orientation of the African perception of certain aspects of reality without prejudice to any particular culture or view. African metaphysics is pragmatic, thus meeting the standard of objective reality is not an obstacle for the African. As Ozumba clarifies, Africans have far-reaching thoughts about the phenomena, be it physical or transcendental, with which they are acquainted. That an idea works does not prevent the African mind from digging into why it works. The African seeks to understand, at times through mystical means, the basis for the things around. Allowing nature, elders, and ancestral powers to be the first and foremost teachers. The African, more importantly, is aware of the danger of superficiality. As much as theoretical and experiential apparatus could take them, they seek to understand the "why" and "how" of the reality around them. The lack of documentation in terms of storage of ideas in writing poses a danger in the field of African philosophy generally. It hinders critical after-thought reflection that written experiences afford the human intellect. Besides, as Lovemore Mbigi avers, "a mere mental acquaintance with reality cannot guarantee tenacity and longevity of ideas". (Mbigi, 6) In the process of reconstructing our undocumented experiences some aspects of past experiences are never remembered. Nonetheless, as Joseph Omoregbe writes, "the African store their ideas in form of folklores, folk wisdom, mythologies, traditional proverb, religious worldviews, etc."(Omoregbe, 7). Although not comparable to documentation in writing, this form of orally and culturally preserving ideas afford the traditional African the opportunity to reflect further and more critically on past experiences and shared beliefs. African metaphysics merges empiricism and rationalism as the African mind combines the experiential with reflection to validate beliefs. Jimoh emphasizes "The African test experiences in order to ascertain their veracity, accepting only that which agrees to reason and has evidence to support it. This background knowledge of the nature of African metaphysics positions us to understand how certain concepts feature in African metaphysics."(Jimoh, 2)

The African God-Purpose Theory of Meaning

What constitutes African conceptions of the meaning of life? To start, first is the African God-purpose theory. Although the God-purpose theory is not a new or a uniquely African view, the arguments contained in the view possess salient features that are African. Certain philosophers argue that belief in God's existence is unnecessary when discussing the God-purpose theory. This perspective, as Metz (2013) notes, is not about God's existence but rather the conditions required for the God-purpose theory to serve as a viable theory of meaning (p. 80). While this argument is appreciated, it is difficult to accept its logic. If the concept of God is inconceivable, then any theory of meaning based on such an inconceivable God would also be inconceivable and likely akin to wishful thinking. For instance, creating logical arguments for the meaningfulness of a seven-legged leopard—a non-existent entity—would render the theory implausible, as seven-legged leopards do not exist. Similar reasoning applies to the God-purpose theory: there must be some rational basis for believing in a conceivable God before using the God-purpose theory as a meaningful framework. For most traditional Africans, belief in the Supreme Being is fundamental. The African God-purpose theory starts with an all-encompassing belief in God or the Supreme Being, which is integral to the daily life of traditional Africans. Pantaleon Iroegbu emphasizes this pervasive belief, highlighting its importance in the African worldview.

In African traditional societies, it is widely accepted that there were no atheists. The belief in God's existence is not taught to children because it is considered innate and self-evident. God is deeply woven into the daily lives and practices of the people (Iroegbu, 1995, p. 359). This belief is not far-fetched; its foundations are plausible enough to render the African God conceivable. From African philosophical literature, it is clear that nothingness is seen as impossible for most traditional Africans. Instead, the concept of being-alone (analogous to nothingness) and being-with-others represents the full expression of reality, reflecting communal metaphysics.

The African rejection of nothingness in favor of being-alone stems from their understanding of God as necessarily eternal and the progenitor of the universe. Being-alone implies a necessarily eternal God that existed without the universe, highlighting an unattractive mode of existence compared to the more attractive communal ontology. This notion suggests that the universe's existence represents a supreme rejection of God's being-alone, favoring a communal relationship with other entities in the universe. Thus, the primary purpose of the universe is seen through the legitimisation of God's existence by way of a communal relationship with the universe and created reality. Given that God existed before all other forms of existence, being-alone must have been a reality at some point. In the African view, the Cartesian cogito, acknowledging one's existence, is not enough. Existence ought to be expressed via a relationship with one another. It is in this way that other realities, which emerge from God, legitimize God's existence as a *being-with-others*. With this in mind deciphering God's purpose for man, and how that translates to meaningfulness, becomes a much easier affair. With the ultimate goal of sustaining the harmony which preserves the universe and in turn legitimizes the existence of God, living a meaningful life would involve living a life that ensures harmony, another possible reason why complementarity is widespread in most communities in traditional Africa. Thus, existence gains meaning through relationships with others. The realities that emerge from God validate God's existence as a being-with-others. Understanding God's purpose for humanity, then, becomes clearer: sustaining the harmony that preserves the universe and legitimizes God's existence. Living a meaningful life involves ensuring harmony, which is why complementarity is prevalent in many African communities. Traditional African thinkers agree that living meaningfully by doing God's will involves two key methods: fulfilling one's destiny and obeying divine law.In regards to destiny, it is clear that the Supreme Being is responsible for its creation, as Segun Gbadegesin explains. Whether an individual chooses their destiny or it is imposed upon them remains unclear; nonetheless, the important point is that destiny originates from God. It is crucial to distinguish destiny from what might be termed "fate." Receiving one's destiny from God does not imply a rigid, predetermined life path devoid of free will or the ability to influence one's life's direction. Individuals retain the freedom to pursue, alter, or ignore their destiny. Destiny is understood as a unique end for each individual, and it is up to the individual to decide whether to pursue it.

Normative progression suggests that personhood is attained over time through the accumulation of moral experience. Thus, the older and more morally experienced an individual becomes, the closer they are to achieving moral excellence and full personhood. It is plausible to assume that destinies are assigned by God, given the African view of normative progression, which implies that an undeveloped human or an "it" lacks the rational capacity to choose something as intricate as destiny. While Gbadegesin notes that both good and bad destinies exist and that destinies can be altered—since one can choose to ignore a bad destiny and do good (Gbadegesin, 2004, p. 316)—choosing to ignore a destiny, whether good or bad, signifies neglect rather than alteration. Such neglect may indicate a failure to understand how one's destiny aligns with God's overarching purpose or a willingness to live a meaningless life. Interestingly, the pursuit of a bad destiny assigned by God can still lead to meaningfulness, much like how Judas Iscariot's betrayal in the Christian gospel contributes to salvation. Hence, in the African God-purpose view, meaningfulness involves pursuing and fulfilling one's God-assigned destiny. This pursuit garners admiration and esteem both from the individual and their society, while failing to pursue one's destiny renders life meaningless. Another way the God-purpose theory confers meaning is through adherence to divine laws. These laws are communicated to individuals through various representatives or messengers of the supreme being—such as lesser gods, spirits, ancestors, or priests (Idowu, 2005, pp. 186-187). Although the specific laws vary across cultures, the general principle is to avoid taboos or actions that cause community discord and to engage in rites, customs, or rituals that promote individual flourishing and meaning. As Mbiti highlights, failing to adhere to divine law leads not only to meaninglessness but also disrupts the grand purpose of sustaining the universe's harmony. While these laws vary from culture to culture, the general idea is that one must avoid certain taboos or acts that allow discord in the community, and that one must engage in certain rites, customs, or rituals to flourish as an individual and obtain meaning. Mbiti reminds, failing to adhere to divine law not only ensures meaninglessness, it also affects the grand purpose of sustaining the harmony that holds the universe to him. This is why acts of reparation – commiserate with the crime – are often advised once such discord is noticed. It can be immediately noticed that the African God-purpose theory bears on both aspects of meaningfulness, meaning in life and the meaning of life. In the first instance, insofar as the individual performs those actions that are directly tied to their destiny, then those acts constitute for him/her a moment of meaningfulness. With regards to the latter, the narrative that ties the individual's actions together and gives it its coherence is their destiny – or at least the pursuit of it. It is this narrative that allows one to sit back and judge a whole life as meaningful or meaningless. The African God-purpose theory addresses both aspects of meaningfulness: meaning in life and the meaning of life. On

a daily level, individuals perform actions directly tied to their destiny, experiencing moments of meaningfulness. On a broader scale, the narrative of pursuing one's destiny provides coherence to life, enabling one to judge a whole life as meaningful or meaningless. Despite its intriguing approach, the African God–purpose theory faces two major criticisms: its instrumental view of God's purpose and its narrow focus. These criticisms apply to many God–purpose theories, particularly extreme versions. By locating meaning in fulfilling what God wants, the theory reduces individuals to functional roles within a divine scheme, thereby undermining autonomy. Meaning, especially in extreme versions of the theory, resides solely in doing God's will. Additionally, the theory fails to account for instances of meaningfulness that do not stem from one's destiny or divine law. For example, an individual striving to become a musical virtuoso might not achieve meaningfulness if that pursuit does not align with their assigned destiny. However, such pursuits can still be intuitively understood as moments of meaningfulness.

The Vital Force Theory of Meaning

The second theory of meaning that emerges from African philosophical literature is the vital force theory of meaning. To understand this theory, it's essential first to grasp the concept of "vital force", or life force, which is perceived as some sort of ethereal/spiritual force emanating from God and present in all created realities. Wilfred Lajul, in explaining Maduabuchi Dukor's views, expresses these claims quite succinctly: Africans believe that behind every human being or object there is a vital power or soul (1989: 369). Africans personify nature because they believe that there is a spiritual force residing in every object of nature. (2017, p. 28) This is why African religious practices, feasts, and ceremonies cannot in any way be equated to magical and idolatrous practices or fetishism.Within the hierarchy of being, the vital force manifests differently as it animates humans and ancestors with a rational character, unlike plants, which are considered inanimate and irrational, or animals, which possess animation without human–like rationality. Deogratia Bikopo and Louis–Jacques van Bogaert opine that, "All beings are endowed with varying levels of energy. The highest levels characterize the Supreme Being (God), the 'Strong One'; the *muntu* (person, intelligent being), participates in God's force, and so do the non–human animals but to a lesser degree[...]Life has its origin in *Ashé*, power, the creative source of all that is. This power gives vitality to life and dynamism to being. *Ashé* is the creative word, the logos; it is: 'A rational and spiritual principle that confers identity and destiny to humans.'[...]What subsists after death is the 'self' that was hidden behind the body during life. The process of dying is not static; it goes through progressive stages of energy loss. To be dead means to have a diminished life because of a reduced level of energy. When the level of energy falls to zero, one is completely dead." (Bikopo & van Bogaert, 2010, pp. 44–45)

Taking the idea of a vital force seriously means acknowledging its significance to the individual, capable of being either diminished or augmented in several ways. To diminish one's vital force, one must look to illness, suffering, depression, fatigue, disappointment, injustice, failure, or any negative occurrence as contributors to the diminution of vital force. Coherently, one can posit conversely that good health, certain rituals, justice, happiness, engaging positively with others, and so forth, contribute to the augmentation and fortification of vital force. This understanding forms the basis of vitalism as a theory of meaning. Augmenting one's vital force becomes paramount, achieved through rituals, prayers, morally uplifting actions, and harmonious community relations. Continuous augmentation of one's vital force and others' is key to meaningfulness, as highlighted by Tempels, who notes that ultimate happiness in Bantu thought is possessing the greatest vital force, while the greatest misfortune is its diminution (Tempels, 1959, p. 22). Thus, meaninglessness and even death are associated with failing to augment one's life force or actively diminishing it. This theory of meaning focuses on a transcendental goal whose mode of achievement usually involves acts that garner much esteem and admiration. By enhancing vital force, the individual engages in something that is inherently meaningful and valuable.

Beyond this traditional view, some African philosophers propose a naturalistic account of meaning, avoiding issues related to proving spiritual entities' existence. Scholars like Dzobo (1992), Kasenene (1994), Mkhize (2008), and Metz (2012) redefine vital force as wellbeing and creative power, rather than a spiritual force. In this view, meaningfulness involves improving one's wellbeing and freely expressing creative power. Criticisms of the vital force theory include the denial of spiritual essences within the human body, as modern understanding attributes animation and cognitive ability to the brain and nervous system (Chimakonam et al., 2019). Another criticism argues that concepts of wellbeing and creative power need not be labeled as vitalism to be valid. Pursuing wellbeing or expressing creative genius can be seen as separate, non–vitalist paths to meaningfulness.

The Communal Normative Theory of Meaning

This African theory of meaning has been coined "the communal normative function theory"(Attoe, 2020). Based on one of the most widespread views in African philosophy, communalism, this idea has been discussed by various African philosophers in various guises and with reference to the several branches of African philosophy ranging from African metaphysics, African logic, African ethics and even down to African socio–political philosophy. An understanding of communalism is necessary to see how this view speaks to conceptions. Communalism is founded on a metaphysics that seeks to understands various realities as missing links of an interconnected complementary whole (Asouzu, 2004). This ontology then flows down to human communities and social

relationships, where in attainment of the common good and the attainment of personhood one is invariably tied to how one best expresses herself as that missing link. Thus, within this framework, interconnectedness as encapsulated in ideas such as harmony, solidarity, inclusivity, welfarism, familyhood, and so forth, play a prominent role. This is why dicta like Mbiti's famous dictum "I am because we are and since we are, therefore I am" (Mbiti, 1990, p. 106) or the Ubuntu mantra "A person is a person through other persons" or expressions like "one finger cannot pick up a grain." (Khoza, 1994, p. 3) are commonplace in explaining communalism. Scholars, like Menkiti have therefore gone on to even tie individual personhood to how well the individual tries to live communally and engage with the community.

From this understanding, a theory of meaning emerges where meaning involves engaging harmoniously with others. Through positive engagement with others, the individual seeks to acquire humanity in its most potent form, and it is by acquiring and enhancing this humanity or this personhood that the individual also acquires meaning. Likewise, by engaging harmoniously with others, the individual sheds petty animal desires, especially those that spring from selfishness, and instead focuses on moral/normative goals that transcend the individual and center on communal flourishing. While the meaningfulness is gained by performing one's communal normative function, meaninglessness would then subsist in either *not engaging* positively with others or performing those acts that ensure disharmony or discord – which, in turn, leads to the loss of one's humanity. Major shortcoming of the communal normative function theory is that it has no accommodations for other meaningful acts that are not designed for, or may not contribute to, communal upliftment. Thus, if an artist were to engage in her pursuit of achieving virtuoso status and did so without seeking to engage with others with her music, that achievement would not count as a meaningful act.

The Love Theory of Meaning

Love, similar to the Greek concept of Agape according to Mawere, is understood in this context as the "unconditional affection to do and promote goodness for oneself and others, even to strangers".1 In Mawere's paper titled "On Pursuit of the Purpose of Life: The Shona Metaphysical Perspective", few things can be noted. Firstly, that love is an emotion from which the desire to do good emanates. If emotion, at root, is the being of energy in motion, love would be its highest frequency. One can speculate that love is an emotional feature available to all human beings in the same way that rationality, anger, and happiness are emotions that are also available to every human being. This point is countered by various heinous acts that individual and collective human beings have perpetrated throughout history; genocides of all kinds portraying a hateful instinct rather than a loving one. However, the rebuttal to this point would be that love is not the only emotion that the human being is born with, hence the expression of other unpleasant emotions. The second response would be that love is a capacity that is and must be nurtured. Mawere points to this fact: "However, one may wonder why some human beings do not love if love is a natural gift and the sole purpose of life. It is the contention of this paper that the virtuous quality of love though natural is nurtured by free will." (Mawere, 2010, p. 281) Mawere is somewhat vague regarding his definition of "free will," allowing speculation. A more precise approach to describing how love, or agape, is nurtured involves seeing it as the deliberate cultivation and expression of love. Actively striving to promote goodness for oneself and others nurtures a habit that leverages our presumably innate capacity to love, therein nurturing it. By removing obstacles to unconditional love—such as self-interest, nepotism, and unforgiveness—individuals begin to express love as Mawere envisions: unconditional affection aimed at promoting goodness for oneself and others, including strangers (Mawere, 2010, p. 280). Yolanda Mlungwana (2020) builds on this framework, contrasting Mawere's notion of *Rudo*, love, with Susan Wolf's theory. Mlungwana points out that Mawere's definition of love is anthropocentric, focusing solely on people, while Wolf's account is broader. Wolf believes it is logically possible to love not only people but also activities, things, nature, or ideals. For instance, one can express love by advocating for environmental conservation, caring for abandoned animals, or protecting endangered species. This distinction highlights the narrowness of the traditional African love theory of meaning, which focuses exclusively on human beings. While this is a valid critique, it underscores the anthropocentric nature of the African love view.

It is agreed by the African love theorists that the purpose of existence is love, and it remains the sole purpose of human existence. While this might seem a strange claim to make as certain acts that are prima facie meaningful – like becoming an artistic virtuoso – without necessarily being an act of love. First, one must have an understanding of the claim's meaning before settling for conclusions. According to Mawere, love permeates all aspects of human relations with others and society. The Shona consider Agape as the basis of all good relations in society, and therefore as the purpose of everyone's life. In fact, for the Shonas, all other duties of man on earth – reproducing, sharing, promoting peace, respecting others inclusive of the ancestors and God, etc – have their roots in love. Had it not been love which is the basis of all relationships, it was impossible to promote peace, respect others. In fact, meaningful life on earth would have been impossible. (Mawere, 2010, p. 280) This point immediately demonstrates that the idea of love is far from one-dimensional – doing good to others and one's self. In our everyday lives and our everyday practices, insofar as we relate with others in some way, such a relation can be rooted in love. Love, in this sense, is not solely thought of in terms of a direct show of some sort of altruistic behavior towards a person, community, or thing, it is manifested in many differing things/activities including

judgments and reparation, business dealings, governance/leadership, teaching/learning, sportsmanship, self-improvement, and so forth. In this way, our artist, who aims to become a virtuoso regardless if he plays for an audience, does so because he wishes to improve himself- a manifestation of self-love. When human beings fail to nurture love and begin to manifest hate, problems begin to arise. Mlungwana alludes to this point when she states "In the absence of love, which is the foundation of all relationships, there is no encouragement of peace, respect, etc." Since love is the purpose of human existence, an existence that shows an absence of love is one that is simply meaningless and riddled with illness. This meaninglessness further degenerates into anti-meaning when the individual not only fails to show love but actively seeks to pursue hate.

It is hard to fault the love view but one point stands out. Suppose one's attempt at love causes harm to some other person, could such an act be judged as meaningful? Suppose a person trains to become a brilliant Special Forces Soldier (self-love) to serve their country (love towards their society). Let us further suppose that in service to his country, this individual is responsible for the death and destruction of other communities. While their dedicated service can be seen as an act of love, the destruction of lives and communities constitutes an act of hate from the viewpoint of the communities has been negatively affected. This problem is compounded by the fact that for Mawere, this love must be *unconditional*. One response to this problem would be that meaningfulness is not as objective a value as one might like to think. By extension, since meaningfulness is subjective and love/hate is context-dependent, the individual's life is both meaningful and meaningless, depending on the context involved. While this point might seem problematic within a two-valued logical system, such a view is well captured in the dominant trivalent logical systems in African philosophy, such as Chimakonam's Ezumezu logic. However, it is important to note that universality in love suggests a hierarchical effort towards love on all parties. If this person trains to be a soldier on behalf of a country rooted towards violence, hate, and death to solve political world problems as opposed to discussion and cultivation of understanding rather than resources and good, the soldier is offering their self love to a hateful entity. And somewhere in that transition his love turns meaningless, into anti-love.

The Yoruba Cluster Theory of Meaning

The "Yoruba Cluster View" (YCV) is so-called because the cultural values which cluster to form this particular view emanate from the dominant views that are found in traditional Yoruba thought. This view was first systematically articulated by Oladele Balogun (2020) and, to some extent, Benjamin Olujohungbe (2020). The Yoruba conception of meaningfulness is anchored on what Balogun refers to as holism. What this holism represents is a theory of meaningfulness that is not based on single isolated paths to meaningfulness, monism, but instead on a conglomeration of different complementary "interwoven and harmonious accounts of a meaningful life considered as a whole and not in isolation" (Balogun, 2020, p. 171). Metz had made a similar move when defining the concept "meaning" but Balogun's pluralism or holism, as he prefers, is different in two main ways. These paths to meaningfulness are, for Balogun, necessarily dependent on each other, since he is quick to conclude that "isolating one condition from the other alters the constitutive whole" (Balogun, 2020, p. 171). These interwoven paths to meaningfulness are drawn from a series of normative values that are referred to as "life goods". These life goods encompass certain normative values that reflect the spiritual, social, ethical, and epistemological experiences.

To Balogun, the term "life goods" refers to material comfort symbolized with monetary possession, a long healthy life, children, a peaceful spouse and victory over the vicissitudes of existence. The fulfillment of such "life goods" at any stage of human existence is accompanied by remarks. "Life goods", though materialistic and humanistic, are factual goals providing reasons for how the Yorùbá ought to act in daily life. To the extent that such "life goods" ground and guide human actions, and humans are urged to strive towards them in deeds and acts; they are normative prescriptions in the Yorùbá cultural milieu. (Balogun, 2020, p. 171)These life goods represent positive values, and in seeking to attain this group of values, an individual inherently seeks meaningfulness. This implies that achieving meaningfulness involves the subjective pursuit of these seemingly objective normative values. However, according to this perspective, obtaining just one of these values does not equate to living a meaningful life. These values are considered means (not ends) to an end (meaningfulness), and it is the collective acquisition of all values in the cluster that imparts meaning to life. Drawing from William Bascom, Balogun identifies this cluster of values to include the following: long life or avoidance of death (aiku), money (aje, owo), marriage or spouses (aya, iyawo), children (omo), and victory (isegun) over life's challenges. These values provide a standard by which one can assess whether their life is meaningful. Furthermore, the determination of a meaningful life is not solely based on subjective valuation; it is also influenced by external judgment. Thus, even after death, an individual's life can still be deemed meaningful by others. Consequently, the notion that death inherently diminishes life's meaningfulness does not apply to proponents of the Yoruba cluster view. This is because death is seen as merely a transition to another existence, either as an ancestor or through reincarnation. Additionally, those still living can continue to evaluate the meaningfulness of the deceased's life.

The firm belief in life after death also provides ancestors with the opportunity to seek meaningfulness, as they are considered very much alive in a different realm. However, the cluster view does not apply entirely to the ancestors, as goals such as wealth (aje), marriage (aya/iyawo), and children (omo) are not achievable for them. It is expected that ancestors intervene in the lives of the living by "[protecting] the clan and sanctioning of moral norms among the living" (Balogun 2020, 172). The cluster view fully unfolds as a theory of meaning when one recognizes that the values within the cluster are interconnected and mutually reinforcing. At its foundation lies Aiku (long life or avoidance of death), which is essential for the pursuit of a meaningful life. A short-lived life limits the opportunity to pursue the means that constitute meaningfulness. Menkiti's notion that children cannot fully attain personhood is relevant here, as it underscores the importance of longevity. Maintaining good health and living a long life provides the time necessary to achieve other values believed to contribute to a meaningful existence. Wealth (aje/owo) provides the material comfort needed to live comfortably and support others. It is through financial stability that one can marry (iyawo) and raise children (omo). A life devoid of marital relationships and children is culturally perceived by the Yorùbá as meaningless. The pro-communitarian stance of the Yoruba emphasizes the importance of procreation within a peaceful marital network to expand the family lineage and clan. Victory (isegun) over life's challenges further contributes to a meaningful life. Together, these interwoven values form a life that can be recognized as meaningful.

Balogun extends the concept of cluster values by integrating morality into what constitutes a meaningful life. For the Yorùbá, he argues, "a meaningful life is a moral life. Within the Yorùbá cultural milieu, there is no clear demarcation between living a meaningful life and a moral life, for both are associated with each other" (Balogun 2020, 173). Olujohungbe supports this view, suggesting that a life rich in quality—which can be understood as fulfilling the cluster values highlighted by Balogun—must also be a morally good life. He posits that virtuous character supersedes other values such as longevity, health, wealth, and children. In this context, a distinction is made between the quantity and quality of life. A person who lives to old age but is morally corrupt, even if they leave behind children and material wealth, is often discreetly dismissed by society, which might say "akutunku e l'ona orun"—literally meaning "may you die several times on your way to heaven" and implying "good riddance to bad rubbish" (Olujohungbe, 2020, p. 225). When one aligns cluster values with positive engagement with others, they are living a meaningful life. For instance, using one's wealth (aje) to alleviate the poverty of others reflects a meaningful existence. Similarly, procreating, raising children, and guiding them to become good members of society also embody a meaningful life. This principle applies across all cluster values when they are used together in a cohesive, morally sound manner.

Personhood and a Meaningful Life

The idea that attaining personhood can invariably lead to a meaningful life flows from the views of scholars like Ifeanyi Menkiti and Kwame Gyekye and systematized into a theory of meaningfulness by Motsamai Molefe. Here, personhood extends beyond mere existence. Simply being a living human is not a sufficient condition for personhood; one must demonstrate personhood through meaningful relationships and actions. This concept has been debated, notably by philosophers like Menkiti and Gyekye, on the status of babies and young children concerning personhood. Menkiti takes a radical stance, asserting that children do not possess personhood and thus cannot be considered persons. Conversely, Gyekye proposes that children are born with a nascent form of personhood, which can be developed and augmented through normative function. Despite their differing views, both agree that personhood is an achievable status, attainable through positive interactions within one's community and culture. Building on this framework, Motsamai Molefe offers a systematic account of meaning based on the African notion of personhood. He posits that meaningfulness begins when an individual develops the capacities and virtues necessary to become their best self. Life gains meaning through the acquisition and cultivation of these virtues, transforming raw abilities into moral excellence (Molefe, 2020, p. 202). According to Molefe, moral excellence is the pinnacle of a meaningful life, achieved not instantaneously but through a prolonged period of moral development, echoing Menkiti's assertion that moral genius is attained over time. Time, therefore, enhances moral experience. Molefe also associates his concept of personhood and meaningfulness with dignity. Aligning with Gyekye's ideas, Molefe asserts that every individual has the inherent capacity to be virtuous and should endeavor to cultivate this capacity to a reasonable level. He states, "Remember, on the ethics of personhood, we have status or intrinsic dignity because we possess the capacity for moral virtue. The agent's development of the capacity for virtue translates to moral perfection, which we can also think of in terms of a dignified existence. This kind of dignity is the one that we achieve relative to our efforts to attain moral perfection – achievement dignity. As such, a meaningful life is a function of a dignified human existence qua the development of the distinctive human capacity for virtue. I also emphasize that the agent is not required to live the best possible human life. The requirement is that the agent ought to reach satisfactory levels of moral excellence for her life to count as meaningful." (2020, p. 202). The requirement for satisfactory levels of moral excellence does not preclude striving for the best possible life. Thus, achieving satisfactory moral excellence is the minimum standard for a meaningful life, allowing for varying degrees of meaningfulness. For instance, living a life with sufficient moral virtues is meaningful, but perhaps not to the same extraordinary degree as a figure like Nelson Mandela.

Notion of the human person or personhood is increasingly central to African metaphysics. Generally, the concept of personality consists in what makes an individual a distinct person. Within the hierarchical order of "Being", the human person comes after the spiritual entities. Quoting Kwasi Wiredu, Godfrey Onah writes that there are two approaches to the concept of a person in African metaphysics: the descriptive approach and the normative approach.

Descriptive Approach involves analyzing the constituent parts of the human person, including both physical and non-physical elements, their functions, and their significance in the broader scheme of things. This approach reveals the ontological status of the human person. Although different African cultures may vary slightly in identifying these constituent parts, there is a general consensus on what comprises the human person. According to Kwasi Wiredu, the Akan culture identifies five constituent parts: okra (the life principle and source of human dignity and destiny), sunsum (the spirit or charisma principle), moyga (character inherited from the mother), ntoro (character inherited from the father), and nipadua (the physical body). Contrary to Wiredu's view, Kwame Gyekye argues that there are only two constituent parts in Akan culture: okra (soul) and nipadua (body). Wiredu, however, is hesitant to translate okra as "soul" because, unlike the purely immaterial soul, he views okra as a quasi-material substance believed to be perceptible by certain native doctors. Apart from these dualistic and pentachotomistic views, Kwame Appiah offers a tripartite analysis, describing a body (nipadua) made from the mother's blood (mogya), an individual spirit (sunsum) derived from the father, and a life force (okra) that departs the body at death. In Yoruba culture, there is a*l*so a tripartite notion, consisting of ara (the body, including components like the opolo—brain, okan—heart, and ifun—intestine, with the opolo being the most critical), emi (the vital principle), and ori (the element that controls life and activities, connecting the person to the Supreme Being – Olodumare). The Igbo share a similar classification: aru (the physical body), chi (destiny, which can change based on various factors including divine intervention), and mmuo (the immortal spirit that ensures the individual's continuing self-identity). These classifications from different African cultures, rather than contradicting each other, complement one another and highlight the diverse nuances within and across cultures. As Ozumba suggests, the varying views—whether Wiredu's pentachotomistic, Gyekye's dualistic, Appiah's tripartite, or the Yoruba and Igbo trichotomistic perspectives—all collectively contribute to a holistic understanding of the human person. Ozumba further discusses a "three-fold categorical objectification" to understand personhood better. First, the residual categorical objectification simplifies the person into two broad categories: material body and immaterial spirit. Second, the tripartite conception attempts to demarcate spiritual elements into their functional roles, illustrating that spirit and soul, though both immaterial, are functionally distinct. Lastly, the bloated categorical objectification emphasizes the African interpretation of individual personality, considering an individual as a product of both earthly (body) and biological (maternal and paternal contributions) lineages. Thus, while there may appear to be disagreements, particularly among scholars of Akan cultural classifications, these differences are more apparent than real. Each perspective adds depth and richness to the understanding of personhood in African metaphysics. This merely simplifies and reduces the conception of the person to two broad categorizations, the material body and the immaterial spirit. The tripartite conception of Appiah and the Yoruba and Igbo, which constitutes the second categorical objectification is an attempt to demarcate the spiritual elements into their functional cleavages, for instance, the fact that the spirit is functionally different from the soul even though they are both immaterial. The spirit gets information from the creator directly and transmits the same to the soul that in turn affects the body. In reverse manner, the body affects the soul and then the spirit. The third, which is the bloated categorical objectification, instantiates the African basis for interpreting the individual personality. Every individual is seen as an earthly (body) and biological (imputes from father and mother) being. The individual is a product of both maternal and paternal lineages.

Narrative Approach considers the social status of the human person. For the African, personhood is not granted at birth but is attained by becoming a responsible member of the community. David Lutz notes that "one of the most striking features of the cultures of sub-Saharan Africa is their non-individualistic character"(Lutz, 17).The community is the cornerstone in African thought and life. Therefore, African metaphysics conceives the human person as a communal being. "People are not just individuals, living in a state of independence, but part of a community, living in relationships and interdependence".(Lutz, 20) John Mbiti supports this by arguing that individuals become conscious of their being only in relation to others, recognizing their responsibilities, duties, and privileges towards themselves and others. Experiences of pain and joy are shared within a corporate group of relatives, neighbors, and kinsmen, both living and dead (ancestors), encapsulated by the phrase, "I am because we are; and since we are, therefore I am." In the narrative approach, one becomes a person when they reach adulthood, able to fend for themselves, reason judiciously, and support a family through a conjugal relationship. Alongside these are numerous obligations to kin and community that define personhood, thereby excluding infants and social misfits. This perspective illustrates that in African traditional thought, a person exists not merely as an individual but as a member of a group and community. The person is inherently communitarian, engaging in constant interaction with others. Oyeshile concurs, noting that besides being communitarian, a person also exhibits attributes like rationality, the capacity for virtue, moral judgment, and the ability to make choices. These attributes are developed by the individual and nurtured within the community. The communitarian status of the individual has multiple implications, as Gyekye explains. Communal values like mutual

aid, care, interdependence, solidarity, reciprocal obligation, and social harmony are highly esteemed in African metaphysical thought, fostering a sense of community that structures social relations. This communal character is an enduring feature of African social life, and individuals become who they are by internalizing these communal values, which help develop essential qualities like reasoned judgment, success in family life, and balancing personal interests with community obligations. In African metaphysics, personhood cannot be achieved outside the community. Communal values are central, yet they do not infringe on individual values. Lutz clarifies this by stating, "The communal character of African cultures does not mean that the good of the individual person is subordinated to that of the group, as is the case with Marxist collectivism. In a true community, the individual does not pursue the common good instead of his or her own good, but rather pursues his or her good *through* pursuing the common good" (Lutz, 24). Hence, individuals are encouraged to recognize that their true good is attainable by promoting the good of others. This sentiment is echoed by Obiora Ike and Ndidi Edozien in their description of the Igbo social structure, where community consciousness coexists with individual rights, guaranteed by systems of checks and balances that ensure free speech, movement, and action. Kwame Gyekye argues that although the African ontological worldview is communalistic, it does not compromise individuality. Referencing the Akan proverb that compares the clan to a cluster of trees that "when seen from afar, appear huddled together, but when closely approached, stand individually," Gyekye posits that this proverb "stresses the social reality of the individual… [as one with] a separate identity… separately rooted and not completely absorbed by the cluster." Thus, community does not obliterate individuality. Consequently, self-realization is achieved only through interpersonal relationships, a concept encapsulated by Ubuntu in South African cultures.

Ubuntu Theory

The African concept of personhood, *Ubuntu*, emphasizes that human beings do not exist in isolation, rather are interconnected and not separate from one another, meaning that individual actions affect the entire world. *Ubuntu*, a South African concept deeply rooted in the Nguni group of languages, captures the communitarian dimension of African personhood. Desmond Tutu describes it as "very difficult to render into a Western language. It speaks of the very essence of being human" (Tutu, 30). Most African scholars agree that Ubuntu translates to "humanness" or "being human," highlighting the essence of our humanity. Mogobe Ramose describes Ubuntu as "simultaneously the foundation and the edifice of African philosophy" (Tutu, 32). Beyond just positive qualities, M. Muyandu describes it as "the very human essence itself, which lures and enables human beings to become abantu—or humanized beings, living in daily self-expressive works of love and efforts to create harmonious relationships in the community of the world beyond" (Tutu, 33). *Ubuntu* is an African concept that embodies a universal principle, describing the intrinsic connection between humanity and the ecosystem, where communal responsibility sustains life. In a comprehensive ontological understanding, *Ubuntu* signifies that the being of an African person is embedded not only in the community but in the universe as a whole. This is expressed in the prefix of the word – "ubu", referring to the enfolded universe containing everything, and the stem – "ntu," which means the unfolding of the universe in various forms and modes of being. Ubuntu implies that our humanness lies in affirming our humanity by recognizing the humanity of others. It highlights that we cannot separate our humanity from those around us. "Under Ubuntu, there is an individual existence of the self and a simultaneous existence for others" (Tutu, 35), making it imperative to establish respectful human relations. This promotes the common good of society and includes humanness as essential to human growth (Tutu, 37). This philosophy is epitomized by the Xhosa expression: "Umntu ngumntu ngabanye abantu," which translates to "People are people through other people" or "I am human because I belong to the human community and I view and treat others accordingly." Onyebuchi Eze explains that this embodies an affirmation of one's humanity through the recognition of another's uniqueness and difference. It demands a creative intersubjective formation where others become a mirror for our subjectivity. This idealism suggests that humanity is not solely embedded within an individual; rather, humanity is co-substantively bestowed on others and oneself. We create and sustain each other's humanity, and our sense of self is dynamically constituted through these relationships: "we are because you are, and since you are, definitely I am." Ubuntu is a distinctive conception of human communitarianism, which defines our identities, values, rights, and responsibilities towards one another. It conceives the individual as rooted in the community, wherein one's identity is defined by contributions to the community. As Augustine Shutte articulates, "our full humanity is realized to the extent that we are included in relationships with others" (Shutte, 40). It's arguable that this is an aspect of human nature cultivated through experience of nurturing culture and skills rather than the counterfactual western view. This notion of collective responsibility should not be misconstrued as absolute subordination of individual good to the community's good, akin to Western communitarian socialism. Instead, Ubuntu promotes a community's well-being through unconditional recognition and appreciation of individual uniqueness and difference. Ubuntu rejects the Western minimalist notion of personhood, which equates being human with having a soul, rationality, or will. Instead, it embraces a maximal notion of personhood that includes these and other criteria. As a philosophical concept, Ubuntu implies a belief in a universal bond connecting all humanity. It describes the oneness of humanity, integral to the African notion of personhood, and the awareness that one belongs to a greater whole. This consciousness asserts that one is diminished when others are humiliated, tortured, or oppressed. Ubuntu involves being open and available to others, affirming their humanity while being unthreatened by others due to a strong sense of belonging to a larger community. This idealism suggests to

us that humanity is not embedded in my person solely as an individual; my humanity is co-substantively bestowed upon the other and me. Ultimately, humanity is a quality we owe to each other.

Ibuanyidanda Theory, Asouzu's New Complementary Ontology

Innocent Asouzu has advanced a new philosophy called ibuanyidanda, which encompasses, among other ideological issues, a metaphysics of integration. This ontology, championed by Asouzu, expounds upon the African notion of personhood as being deeply rooted in communal relationships, which he aptly describes as complementary. Essentially, ibuanyidanda is a philosophy of mutual complementary relationships that define our being. According to Asouzu, "for anything to claim existence, it has to fulfill a minimum condition, which subsists in its commitment to a mutually complementary relationship between it and other units with which it shares a common framework" (Asouzu, 3). Complementarity provides the framework through which an individual can fully grasp the meaning of being. The personal identity of an individual is understood within the context of the intrinsic interrelatedness of all existents. This implies that no individual exists in isolation; rather, individuals exist in relation to other entities. "To be" is to exist in a mutual and complementary relationship with all things that are, and its negation is to be alone and not in Nothingness. Ibuanyidanda is an Igbo compound concept derived from three words: ibu (load or task), anyi (not insurmountable for), and danda (a species of ants). The concept draws from the traditional Igbo system of thought that examines the ants' (danda) ability to perform tasks seemingly bigger than themselves by relying on mutual dependence and interdependence. Asouzu employs it to mean that "no tasks are insurmountable for human beings when they complement their potentialities." As an ontology, it "attempts to penetrate and grasp being, and with it ultimate reality through mediation or via the instrumentality of mutual relations" (Asouzu, 47). The fundamental idea of ibuanyidanda is that no one realizes personhood alone. Asouzu argues that the traditional African worldview reveals "strong moments of the transcendent ontological categories of unity, totality, universality, comprehensiveness, wholeness, and future referentiality as authentic dimensions of thoroughgoing complementarity." For him, reality is all-embracing in such a way that all missing links of reality exist in complementarity. The actualization of our being is found in the mutual complementarity of our potentialities, and within this framework, our individual personal identities are defined. This suggests a form of existentialist ontology in which being is defined as "that which is insofar as it serves a missing link." The notion of a "missing link," as employed by Asouzu, emphasizes the significance of the individual, suggesting that no one is lost in the 'crowd of existents,' but that everyone has a place in the 'chain of reality.' The absence of anyone constitutes a missing link in the holism of reality. Therefore, "I am" insofar as I mutually compliment others, and others are, insofar as they mutually compliment me. The concept of personality is central to African metaphysics and has garnered more discussion than many other issues within the field. This analysis indicates that the African metaphysical conception of the person embraces and transcends the Western notion of personhood, serving as a pivotal point for other African metaphysical worldviews.

The Conversational Theory

According to Chimakonam (2021), Conversationalism is a theory of meaning-making that seeks to enhance two primary significists—the nwa-nsa (the listener) and the nwa-nju (the questioner)—through a process of intellectual and creative struggle known as "arumaristics." This process involves the construction, deconstruction, and reconstruction of seemingly opposing viewpoints. While Conversationalism primarily focuses on conceptual forms of meaning-making, its implications for life are evident as well. Meaning-making occurs through conversations within oneself and between oneself and the objective values encountered in various life contexts.

Within oneself, meaning is found through self-improvement. This is achieved by interrogating one's okwu (values, viewpoints, prejudices, and so forth), as Chimakonam (2019) terms it. It is not only about improving one's okwu, which make up the content of an individual's life, but also about enhancing the ability to ask new questions throughout a lifelong dialogue. By continually questioning and answering, an individual refines their okwu to higher levels of sophistication. This positive augmentation of one's okwu is what makes life meaningful for conversationalists, at least from a subjective perspective. However, an individual also exists within a community, and for conversationalists, ideas often labeled as objective are primarily the intellectual contributions of subjective individuals within a particular communal context. So, what constitutes objective meaning in Conversationalism? Objective meaning involves the individual's ability to either adopt (nwa-nsa) or question (nwa-nju) the ideas, actions, or values deemed worthwhile by their communal context. By accepting these values or engaging in actions that the community considers valuable, the individual pursues ends that are esteemed for their own sake, earns admiration, and transcends their animal nature—aligning with goals beyond themselves. Alternatively, by taking on the role of nwa-nju (the questioner), an individual makes their life meaningful by allowing the improvement of the very values upon which the communal context relies for meaningfulness. In this manner, the individual's life gains meaning by becoming either a meaning-maker or a meaning-curator.

Being Theory

African metaphysics conceptualizes being as a generic term encompassing all existing entities. In this worldview, nothing that exists is trivial; everything serves a purpose and exists for a reason. Being encompasses the full spectrum of existent things and is hierarchically structured, with God at the apex. Following God are the ancestors, totems (emblems of hereditary relationships), spirits involved in witchcraft, sorcery, or magic (often represented as charms and amulets), humans, animals, and plants. The hierarchy is not rigid; certain events can elevate an otherwise insignificant divinity to a position of central reverence within a community, potentially displacing the ancestors. This suggests that, for valid reasons, the hierarchical order of beings can be rearranged. Ancestors are highly revered because they are perceived as better disposed towards the living, unlike other divinities who are seen as unpredictable and capricious. Plants and animals can also hold significant places in the spiritual hierarchy of certain communities if they are believed to be inhabited by powerful spiritual forces. This is why in some African communities, entities like pythons, fish in specific rivers and streams, and other animals and plants are revered and protected from harm or consumption. The concept of being as a collection of forces is widespread in African metaphysics. Scholars like aforementioned Tempels and Henri Maurier have described being in terms of 'life force' or 'vital force,' emphasizing the interrelationship between these forces. While the malleability and activity of forces within the hierarchy might suggest potential strife and disorder, African metaphysics posits that an unseen, omnipotent creator oversees and regulates these interactions, ensuring an ordered unity rather than chaotic conflict. This creator, identified as God, maintains control and harmony within the universe. The supreme position of God is underscored by the various names different African cultures have for the divine, such as the Igbo's Okaka, amasi–amasi, and Chukwu okike (the creator of the universe), the Yoruba's Olodumare (the almighty God), and the Akan of Ghana's Onyame (the Supreme Being). These names emphasize that God is infinite and the fullness of actuality, while all other beings are finite and limited. Although beings are numerous, they form an intricate nexus of reality. African metaphysics perceives reality as both particular and universal, underpinned by an underlying unity due to the interconnectedness of all things. The African mind, therefore, views reality as a continuum. Molefi Asante refers to this as the practicality of holism when describing the African perspective on cognition. Asante identifies several elements that shape the African conception of reality: the practicality of wholism, the prevalence of poly–consciousness, the idea of inclusiveness, the unity of worlds, and the value of personal relationships. These elements frame the African understanding of reality, where the oneness of everything is central. This holistic perspective, believed by the ancient Egyptians, enabled them to uncover many secrets of the world and establish the interconnectedness of all creation, a concept early Western philosophy termed unity in diversity.

Substance Theory

The concepts of personality and being in African metaphysics already presuppose the concept of substance because substance is closely related to both concepts. Substance is the quality of beingness. It could be seen, felt or divined through oracular means. The evidence that a thing exists, whether it is seen or not by the physical eyes, as long as it is conceived with the totality of its qualities in the mind, is what constitutes substance for the African metaphysician. Therefore, the spirits are part and parcel of being in African metaphysics. Africans uphold the existence and being of spirits even though they are not visible to the physical eyes of the individual. They are not visible because they are immaterial. But their presence is felt and Africans have ample evidence of how their activities affect them, either favorably or adversely. This fosters the belief in spirits.

Causality Theory

Africans are deeply concerned with understanding why events occur, when they occur, and to whom they occur, rather than to someone else. This perspective underscores the concept of causality in African metaphysics. Africans believe that there is always a cause for everything that happens and do not generally entertain the notion of chance occurrences. Chance is considered the product of our ignorance concerning the series of actions and reactions leading to a specific event. This might suggest that the African worldview is deterministic; however, this perspective also allows for the exercise of free will. According to Ozumba, "when a man is faced with alternative options, he is free to choose to carry out one or the other" (Ozumba, 62). He further elaborates on the relationship between chance, determinism, and free will by suggesting that these concepts are different sides of the same coin. What is labeled as chance is actually an event that occurs accidentally but is still traceable to a cause and reason. A determined event is the result of a freely made decision that leads to a specific cause and effect. In this view, free will initiates actions, which are then followed by determinism. Therefore, individuals possess freedom to some extent but are also limited by their community's constraints. In the communitarian and individualistic reality scheme of African thought, a person can go against the community's wishes but must be prepared to face potential sanctions from the community. However, with right reasoning and personal initiative, an individual can exercise freedom within the community without conflicting with its collective will. African metaphysics recognizes the distinct natures of the body and spirit while also believing that these two interact. The issues of necessary connection, continuity in space and time, constant conjunction, and priority in time that characterize the Western discussion of causality are not concerns in African metaphysics. Instead, Africans consider cause and effect across a range of possibilities and often resort to divination or oracles for final verdicts.

Immortality Theory or The Soul/Reincarnation

The concept of an immortal soul is intricately connected with the notion of reincarnation in African metaphysics. The belief in the immortality of the soul is strongly held and largely uncontroversial among Africans. It is believed that the individual's soul continues to exist after the physical body dies. If the individual has led a good life, the soul departs to a place of peaceful abode. Conversely, if the individual has lived poorly, the soul is denied entry to this place of rest and instead roams the earth restlessly. Africans hold that all spirits maintain direct contact with the physical world and influence human activities. This belief underlies the common practice of offering sacrifices to ancestors, who are thought to partake in these offerings. While this belief may echo the Christian notion of heaven, it is not equivalent. The idea of a peaceful resting place for the soul does not fully align with the Christian concept of heaven, and there is no equivalent notion of hell in this context. The immortality of the soul in African metaphysics is closely linked with the belief in reincarnation, the doctrine of a second birth to earthly life. Reincarnation is seen as a phenomenon where the spirit, understood as the life force or soul, returns to earth in another form after an individual's physical death. Both good and bad spirits are believed to reincarnate. While the return of good spirits is welcomed, the reincarnation of bad spirits is dreaded and efforts are made to exorcize them. Reincarnated good spirits are often identified with names like Babatunde or Iyabo, whereas bad spirits are referred to as Abiku, Ogbanje, or Ndem. Through divination, Africans claim the ability to identify which spirit has reincarnated.

Western Considerations

African metaphysics is unlike Western, which has not faced external gentrification, erasure, or denial, this exploration aims to examine the primary thinkers who have shaped the course of Western thought. By evaluating their contributions to the field, and how these have influenced the development of modern science and philosophy, classic surrealism can be better understood. The critical question is whether these Western thinkers introduced original, primary concepts to the public, or whether they merely recycled and reinterpreted African philosophical understandings within a more analytical and logic–based framework. Were Western philosophers truly the first to derive these concepts, or did they adapt ideas that were already present in African philosophy?

Collective Consciousness & Personal Identity

The philosophy of collective consciousness refers to the concept that a set of shared beliefs, ideas, attitudes, and knowledge exists within a society or culture that transcends individual consciousness. This idea suggests that members of a group or society share an overarching 'mind' that shapes their perceptions, actions, and experiences, which, in turn, perpetuates these shared mental contents. One of the earliest and most influential proponents of this concept was French sociologist Émile Durkheim, who introduced the term "collective consciousness" in his sociological theory. According to Durkheim, the collective consciousness is the combination of all the beliefs and sentiments common to the average members of the same society, forming a system with a life of its own. It unites individuals and creates social cohesion by providing a framework within which they act, interact, and understand their social reality. This philosophy implies that collective consciousness is greater and more complex than the sum of individual thoughts. It operates on a level that can influence norms, customs, rituals, and even languages, shaping a society's values and providing the moral foundation for its legal and political institutions. Collective consciousness is not static but evolves over time as societies undergo changes—whether through internal development, external influences, or revolutionary ideas. A closely related concept is that of collective memory, a term coined by Maurice Halbwachs, which refers to how groups remember their past and use these memories to construct their identity. Both collective consciousness and collective memory contribute significantly to the formation of group identities and are crucial in understanding the functioning of societies and the individuals within them. In a broader scope, contemporary thinkers often consider the implications of collective consciousness in the context of globalization, the internet, and rapid information exchange. Many contemporary movements and phenomena, such as social media trends, mass mobilization, and cultural globalization, reflect how collective consciousness can now form and shift rapidly across traditional geographic and cultural boundaries. Ultimately, the philosophy of collective consciousness invites us to consider how our individual lives are interwoven with the larger fabric of our communities and societies, and how this shared social mind can empower or constrain us within the larger human narrative. It can also explore the possibility of familial networks of consciousness, passing trauma or positivity generationally.

Charles Larmore, The Problems of Personal Identity & Gitas, Narrative Consciousness

Charles Larmore is remembered for his dual commentary on discontinuity and the succession of the state of selves. Lamore proposed that the continuity of self depends on "the relations between its successive states and themselves", arguing continuity does not result from the continuity of the body, rather consists in the way its own states are related to oneself. This abides by the theory that consciousness has several qualities, here an exemplar of narrative. Defined as "the act of coordinating successive states into a sequence with design that gives purpose and enhances social coordination between individuals", the Gita's concept of narration is heavily drawn upon in Larmorian philosophy. The cohesion of the self comes to be understood the more we make out the reason in virtue of which a person's beliefs and desires work together to render his conduct. This sort of cohesion does not only obtain at some moment

in his life, rather it equally characterizes the way that successive moments are bound together into a single existence. The very structure of these states makes them states of a self, and the way in which they succeed one another, linked together by the reasons they dispose form the flow of the self from one moment to the next. This line of reasoning plays interestingly with Bhagavad Gita's Second Teaching of Philosophy and Discipline. Krishna explores unraveling the eternal nature of the self *atman* and the transient facade of the material world. He elucidates the concept of performing one's duty *dharma* with impartiality, introducing Arjuna to Karma Yoga, the path of selfless action devoid of attachment to outcomes. Through this narrative, Krishna guides Arjuna towards equanimity and wisdom, illuminating the journey from confusion to clarity, and from despair to enlightenment. This calls into question the problems of personal identity. Gita claims, "Diffuse and pointless are the ways irresolute people understand" and "Obsessed with powers and delights, their reason lost in words, they do not find in meditation this understanding of inner resolve." In these phrases, Gita illustrates two persons: the resolute and irresolute. The former obtains free reign over their mind and action through meditation, understanding the self and inner resolve by means of self-reflection. The latter, unable to due to their obsessions—power, greed, or gluttony—effectively clouding the results, and possibly even existence, of reflection in favor of otherworldly goods and quests. What marks the difference between these two persons is their objective. As Larmore suggests, it is reason that disposes the self and their states to flow in synchrony. And it is will that can change its course.

In "The Problems of Personal Identity" Charles Larmore ventures into the intricate philosophical conundrum of personal identity, offering a nuanced perspective that intertwines continuous consciousness with the construction of personal narratives. Larmore posits that identity transcends mere temporal continuity of conscious experiences; it is profoundly influenced by the narratives individuals construct about their lives. These self-narratives, integral in shaping one's identity, gain further significance through the faculty of memory, which not only sustains the continuity of consciousness but also bridges past experiences with present identity. Larmore astutely acknowledges the vital role of social context, arguing that personal narratives are invariably molded by interpersonal relationships and cultural milieus, thus positing identity formation as a non-isolated phenomenon. Moreover, he elucidates the fluid and dynamic nature of identity, contending that it continually evolves as new experiences are assimilated into one's narrative framework. To enrich this discourse, Larmore employs the metaphor of a rope to illustrate the concept of narrative consciousness. Just as a rope consists of numerous intertwined strands, each contributing to its overall strength and continuity, so too is an individual's identity woven from myriad experiences and evolving stories. These strands, or narrative threads, may fray or change direction, yet they collectively form a robust and coherent sense of self. However, Larmore does not shy away from addressing the unsettling nature of discontinuity within these narrative structures. He delves into the disjunctions that can occur when experiences violently disrupt or fragment the narrative flow. Such disruptions can threaten the integrity of the 'rope,' leading to a fracturing of identity. These moments of discontinuity impact the state of consciousness by creating gaps or inconsistencies in the narrative, which can manifest as crises of identity or profound existential doubt. The will, too, is affected, as the coherence needed for decisive action might wane, leaving individuals in a state of uncertainty or even disarray. Through this elevated and multifaceted discourse, bolstered by the evocative rope metaphor and a keen analysis of discontinuity, Larmore provides an enriched understanding of personal identity as a synthesis of enduring consciousness and the perpetually developing, yet sometimes disrupted, stories individuals weave within their social tapestry. Larmore references Paul Ricoeur in his text, pointing out that the permanence of one's character is something like the permanence over time that a thing can display: enduring habits are like so many features and properties by which an individual can be re-identified as being the same. However, he admits the "sameness" of a person can never be reproduced to the sameness of a thing, since it is by very essence the "selfhood" of a person. That is, it rests upon the relation to oneself that makes the person a self. The place that any character trait occupies in the life of an individual is defined by the way in which it shows that person what reason there is to think or do something. However ingrained and involuntary it may be, a habit represents a kind of standing commitment and in this way ties together, as moments in a life that is mine, the various occasions on which it operates. In taking up a position, one projects themself into the future, making the 'me' tomorrow the continuant of 'me' today. Personal identity is not what matters. Selfhood is what's essential and it's the reason why one cannot help but to be interested in one's personal identity. Because of this, Ricoeours culminating argument can be accepted: personal identity possesses a narrative structure. However, if the states of a single self are such that they are linked together by implicit or formal commitments running through them, can they fail to lend themselves naturally to being put in narrative form? Each segment on life resembles a short story, but it must be recognized that these stories extend only as far as the experiences that from them are animated by some common goal. For the continuity of self, rejecting all its versions, the substrate concept of the self, takes shape in an essentially localized and fragmented way. What allows the self to persist from one moment to the next? Basically, it is following the reasons its current state illustrates for doing one thing to another. It's a thread that stops when one no longer feels compelled to continue in a given direction, their will altering their course. This thus defines our existence. Adopting an open, improvisational attitude towards oneself, however, changes what being human means and even what acting ethically entails in ways that both challenge and resolve what has been discovered about the functions of consciousness thus far.

Faith, Suffering, and How It Manipulates Space, Time, and Identity

The philosophy of suffering involves a multifaceted inquiry into the nature, meaning, and role of suffering in the human experience. Philosophers have long grappled with why suffering occurs, how it affects individuals and societies, and what its significance is within the larger context of existence. Suffering is often discussed in relation to the "problem of evil," which questions how to reconcile the existence of suffering with the idea of a benevolent, omnipotent deity—a central concern in theodicy. It is clear that African metaphysics acknowledges 'evil' or bad energy as an extension of humanity or spiritual energy, gone wrong. In Western thought it seems to be a stem of its own, demonized and not derived from source. A dissociation that may have historical significance with the way Westerners have interacted and influenced the world. Existentialist thinkers, such as Søren Kierkegaard and Friedrich Nietzsche, examine suffering as an inevitable aspect of human life that can potentially lead to personal growth, self-awareness, and an authentic existence. Nietzsche's concept of "amor fati" encourages embracing suffering as part of life's fabric to be affirmed rather than denied. In Buddhist philosophy, suffering *dukkha* is a central concept representing the unsatisfactory nature and the inescapable pain of the cycle of rebirth *samsara*. The Four Noble Truths provide a framework for understanding suffering, its origin, cessation, and the path leading to its end, thus guiding individuals towards enlightenment.When considering the impact of suffering on the perception of space and time, it becomes a unique lens through which individuals encounter their reality. Temporally, suffering can distort the passage of time; intense pain or psychological distress often creates a subjective feeling that time is dragging or that one is stuck in a moment, whereas periods devoid of suffering might be recalled as passing by swiftly. Metaphorically, suffering can act as a black hole—compressing time around it, making every second loom large with pain or sorrow. Spatially, suffering can also alter one's relation to their immediate environment. In states of anguish, the world may seem smaller, constricted around one's pain, or conversely, it may feel vast and overwhelming, amplifying a sense of isolation. A person's lived space, or the phenomenological space in which life is experienced, can be sharply transformed by suffering—as comforting places turn hostile or unfamiliar, or one's sense of place within the world shifts. Through the existential manipulation of time and space, suffering has the potential to redefine an individual's perspective on life, their priorities, and even their understanding of their own identity and the nature of their existence. Philosophically, suffering thus not only poses complex questions about its own essence and origins but deeply influences the subjective construction of reality experienced by those who endure it.

In metaphysics, space and time are scrutinized not just as physical dimensions or entities, but as fundamental aspects of reality that raise profound questions regarding their nature, interrelation, and existence. Metaphysical contemplation of space and time often intersect with, yet remain distinct from, the scientific perspectives provided by physics and cosmology. Metaphysically, space is often considered in relation to questions of whether it is absolute—existing as a container in which objects reside—or relative—only meaningful as a system of relations between objects. Metaphysicians thus explore these concepts not only in abstract but within the context of our physical understanding of the universe, incorporating and often questioning findings of empirical sciences, aiming to discern the true essence and implications of space and time for our broader understanding of reality.

Richard Taylor(1955), Spatial and Temporal Analogies and the Concept of Identity

Diving into more complex analysis of temporal and spatial analysis, Taylor discusses the philosophical concepts of identity in relation to both spatial and temporal frameworks. Richard Taylor's paper is ultimately a philosophical inquiry that seeks to explore the concepts of identity, space, and time, and their interrelations. Taylor writes

"Unlike space, which has generally seemed above all simple and obvious, time has always been regarded by a great many philosophers and theologians as a dark subject of speculation, fundamentally enigmatic, even incomprehensible. It is also something concerning which men can become bewitched over statements which, on the slightest analysis, turn out to express the most trivial truisms – such as "the past cannot be changed", "the future (or the past) is nothing", "time cannot be reversed", and so on. I want to remove some of this mysteriousness by showing that temporal and spatial relations, contrary to much traditional thought, are radically alike; or, more precisely, that (1) terms ordinarily used in a peculiarly temporal sense have spatial counterparts and vice versa, and that accordingly (2) many propositions involving temporal concepts which seem obviously and necessarily true, are just as necessarily but not so obviously true when reformulated in terms of spatial relations; or, if false in terms of spatial concepts, then false in terms of temporal ones too. Such a project is sometimes rejected as a "spatializing of time," but what I have in mind is no more a spatialization of time than a temporalization of space; if it is either, it is the other as well. Of course I am not the first to press the analogies between space and time, but I believe they can be carried much farther than has been thought possible heretofore." (Spatial and Temporal Analogies, 1)

As Taylor suggests, he uses analogies between space and time to examine how objects are identified and continue to exist despite changes. His focal points are Basic Concepts, which his contemplative exploration of metaphysics, Richard Taylor delves into the profound interconnectedness of spatial and temporal dimensions, as they relate to the concept of identity. His analysis presents a

fundamental notion of 'place,' delineating it into two distinct categories: spatial places, designated by physical locations such as "At Boston, Mass.," and temporal places, defined by points in time such as "On May 1, 1955." Taylor brings to light the concept of 'distance' in both spatial and temporal contexts. Cities such as New York and Boston exemplify spatial distance, whereas historical figures like Plato and Kant represent temporal distance. The explication extends to the idea of 'presence,' commonly used to signify 'here' spatially or 'now' temporally, sometimes connoting both simultaneously. Further drawing analogies, Taylor discusses 'length' or 'extension' as a property not solely confined to the spatial realm but also applicable to the temporal through the duration of occurrences. Hence, not only can physical objects possess length, but events too, embodying temporal extension. The notions of 'length' and 'extension' naturally progress to the idea of 'parts,' where Taylor elucidates that both spatial and temporal entities can consist of parts—segments that contribute to the whole. Moving along this line of thought, Taylor addresses 'direction' within both spatial and temporal relations, illustrating that directions such as past to future or north to south are equally valid and intrinsic. This line of reasoning supports the view that the aspects of space and time are not mutually exclusive but are intertwined in physical reality. A pivotal aspect of Taylor's analysis is the fusion of the concepts of 'objects' and 'events,' challenging the traditional separation where objects are seen as spatial and events as temporal. Counter to this dichotomy, Taylor postulates that any physical object inherently constitutes an event, possessing both spatial and temporal properties. He references Nelson Goodman's quotation, which fluidly merges the two, implying that an object can merely be a static event, and an event, a dynamic object. In an effort to clarify terminology, Taylor designates a spatial place as a "place" (abbreviated 'L') and a temporal one as a "time" (abbreviated 'T'). "Spatial part" and "temporal part" are discerned as "S–part" and "T–part," respectively, with other abbreviations anticipated to be self–evident within the context they are set. In sum, Richard Taylor's philosophical excursion crafts a nuanced framework wherein spatial and temporal aspects are not seen as distinct or separate, but rather as a relational continuum, with implications for understanding the nature of identity and existence. The prestated ambiguities present in terms traditionally reserved for spatial discussions are reinterpreted within a temporal landscape, providing a rich tapestry of thought that bridges the divide between space and time, objects and events, constancy and flux.

The additional focal points are Spatial and Temporal Analogies. Through a series of objections and replies, Taylor challenges the conventional wisdom that space and time are fundamentally different. His argument revolves around dissecting propositions that claim to express clear distinctions between space and time and showing that under similar interpretations, the distinctions do not hold true. The discourse involves complex analogies and semantic interpretations of spatial and temporal terms. (1) The first objection presents the notion that an object cannot occupy different spatial places at a single point in time in the same way that it can occupy different temporal moments at the same place. Taylor refutes this claim by suggesting that if an object is seen as extending across the time between two moments – or spatially between two points – then it can indeed be in two places at one time or persist in one place across two times. (2) Addressing the second objection, Taylor faces the argument that time, unlike space, is an essential aspect of motion and change. Taylor argues that spatial change is possible and that the terms of motion and change, commonly temporally defined, do not preclude analogous spatial ones. (3) The third objection addresses the supposed irreversibility of time versus the mutability of spatial relations. Taylor's reply is that both space and time exhibit similar types of fluidity or fixedness and that the analogy between shifts in spatial and temporal position is complete, despite first impressions to the contrary. (4) In response to the fourth objection, which depicts time as a flowing river and space as static, Taylor argues that time does not move, as such movement would imply temporal parts coinciding, an absurdity. The perception of the present's movement is similarly dissected as a semantic confusion around the word "now." (5) The fifth objection introduces the inevitability of temporal movement, where everything moves from the future to the past. Taylor dismantles this notion by equating it to the basic attribute of temporal extension and utilizing analogies between spatial and temporal rest. (6) Addressing the sixth objection, which claims that objects can move closer or further apart spatially but not temporally, Taylor provides examples that demonstrate how temporal proximity can vary in different spatial locations, such as the different intervals between thunder rolls in various towns. (7) Finally, the seventh objection posits that objects can move back and forth in space but not in time. Taylor overcomes this by detailing scenarios of objects that have temporal parts in various locations and illustrating that movement in time is analogous to spatial movement, completing his rebuttal of the dichotomy between space and time.
In each counterargument, Taylor meticulously constructs a symmetry between spatial and temporal concepts, showcasing their analogous nature. His essay serves as a philosophical challenge to the bifurcation between space and time, arguing for a unified treatment in understanding the identity and extension of objects and events.

Lara Buchak, "When is Faith Rational?"
In her seminal paper, "When is Faith Rational?", Lara Buchak confronts the perennial question of the relationship between faith and reason, challenging the preconceived notions that commonly cast faith as inherently irrational or at odds with reason. Buchak, deftly navigates the intricate layers of this philosophical conundrum, positing that faith can indeed be rational under specific circumstances. This review will explore the core arguments presented in Buchak's paper, the strengths of her analysis, and the potential implications

this work has for philosophical and theological discourses. At the crux of Buchak's inquiry is the reconceptualization of faith not as mere belief without evidence but as a commitment to an action or belief based on reasons that go beyond purely evidential considerations. She distinguishes between faith and mere belief, underscoring that faith involves a steadfast commitment often accompanied by a personal, existential stake in the truth of the belief. Buchak argues that faith is rational when it is congruent with an individual's long-term goals and values, especially in the face of uncertainty. Rational faith, according to Buchak, manifests when an individual has good reasons for taking a risk—reasons that align with the individual's aspirations, hopes, and concerns that transcend evidential probabilities. For instance, she explores scenarios in which a person might rationally have faith in a friend's loyalty, despite limited evidence, or in more metaphysical entities, such as God, provided that these beliefs cohere with the individual's overall conception of a meaningful life. The strength of Buchak's paper lies in its incisive critique of evidentialism, the view that one is justified in holding a belief only if one has sufficient evidence for it. Buchak's nuanced approach cedes space to other forms of rationality while maintaining intellectual rigor, effectively expanding the landscape for legitimate rational beliefs.
Moreover, Buchak introduces the concept of 'resolute choice,' which encapsulates the idea that rational agents sometimes ought to commit to a certain course of action, even when faced with new evidence that does not decisively contradict their initial commitment. This notion challenges the prevalent assumption that changing one's beliefs in light of new evidence is always the hallmark of rationality. Buchak's thesis embarks on an interdisciplinary journey, offering implications for topics ranging from religion to decision theory. Theologically, it provides a framework for defending the rationality of faith in a secular age, potentially reassuring believers that their faith commitments are not antithetical to reason. From a decision-theoretic perspective, her argument highlights a need to reassess how rational agents are modeled, especially in situations involving trust and uncertainty. Despite its compelling arguments, Buchak's paper might elicit critiques on various fronts. Some might argue that her definition of faith is too broad, encompassing cases that would traditionally be considered as mere hope rather than faith. Others may challenge the seeming subjectivity of her criterion for rational faith, pondering the potential for relativism and the difficulty of establishing a common framework for assessing the rationality of faith. Buchak boldly reframes the dialogue between faith and reason, providing a novel perspective that respects the nuances of human cognition and the complexities of commitment, offering a refreshing defense of the rationality of faith that doesn't dismiss the importance of evidence but recognizes the richness of the human condition and the diversity of rational experiences. It serves as a thought-provoking touchstone.

Hegel (1807) Fannon (1952–1961)
Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel (1770 – 1831) and Frantz Fanon (1925 – 1961) are prominent figures in philosophy and critical theory, respectively, each exploring complex ideas including those related to faith and suffering, albeit from vastly different perspectives and historical contexts. Hegel's primary work where he explores the development of consciousness and the nature of reality is the "Phenomenology of Spirit" (1807), while Fanon's body of work that most critically examines suffering, particularly the suffering caused by colonialism and racism, is spread across writings like "Black Skin, White Masks" (1952) and "The Wretched of the Earth" (1961). They do not explicitly frame their discussions within the concept of 'faith' as commonly understood in religious terms, but both discuss systems of belief and their implications on human experience and suffering. It's important to note, Hagel was quite the pronoun racist which will be countered with the activist Fanon.

Hegel's Philosophy in Relation to Faith and Suffering:
In Hegelian philosophy, faith *glauben* is often discussed in conjunction with reason as part of the evolution of consciousness and self-awareness. Hegel views history as a dialectical progression where each stage of development *thesis* is confronted by contradictions *antithesis* and these are eventually resolved in a higher level of understanding *synthesis*. Within this framework, faith is seen as a stage in the development of the absolute spirit—a kind of immediate, unreflective consciousness of the divine or the absolute. Suffering, in Hegel's thought, is a necessary component of the dialectical process. It's a part of the struggle within consciousness that leads to self-realization. Phenomenology can essentially be read as a journey through different forms of consciousness and self-consciousness, where suffering is often the catalyst for the movement from one stage to the next. Hegel sees human history as marked by conflicts that, although painful, are instrumental in bringing about higher forms of organization and understanding.

Fanon's analysis in relation to Hagel's Faith and Suffering are seen in many Fanon writings, which while not typically concerned with 'faith' in the religious sense, do address belief systems—particularly the internalization of racist ideology by the oppressed and the liberatory potential of nationalist movements in the colonies. Fanon details the psychological suffering of black individuals living under the oppressive structures of colonial rule and racism. Deeply influenced by existentialist philosophy, Fanon explores the loss of identity and self-conception in the context of racial oppression. In "Black Skin, White Masks," Fanon addresses the way in which Black people are conditioned to perceive themselves through the eyes of the white colonizers, resulting in a fractured self-image that causes immense psychological suffering. In "The Wretched of the Earth," Fanon discusses faith in the context of belief in colonial nationalism and its role in the struggle for liberation. This kind of faith is not theistic but rather a deep conviction in the righteousness

and inevitability of the anti-colonial struggle. Fanon sees violence as an unfortunate but necessary part of the decolonization process, a way for the colonized to reclaim their identity and humanity. The suffering endured by the colonized people is both a result of colonial violence and a transformative force that galvanizes the oppressed towards liberation and self-determination.

Hegelian dialectics can, in a sense, be seen as a framework to understand Fanon's analysis of colonial struggle. Fanon's observations about the colonial condition and the violence and suffering it inflicts can be framed as the antithesis to the thesis of colonial ideology. The synthesis might then be seen as the emergence of a post-colonial identity and social order. Both philosophers, in their respective ways, argue that suffering is not meaningless but transformative—capable of leading individuals and societies to higher states of consciousness or to liberation. Yet, it's crucial to note that Fanon's work is not merely an application of Hegelian philosophy. Fanon incorporates a variety of philosophical and psychological principles to articulate the specific and lived experiences of colonized people, and his work significantly transcends any single philosophical framework. Hegel and Fanon both address the dynamics of the slave-master relationship, but from different contexts and for different purposes. Hegel's treatment is more abstract and philosophical, while Fanon's is concrete, psychological, and rooted in the historical context of colonialism and racism. In Hegel's "Phenomenology of Spirit," he presents the famous "master-slave dialectic" (often referred to as the "lordship and bondage" dialectic) as a metaphor for the process of self-consciousness's development. This dialectic is not primarily about historical slavery but is a theoretical construct depicting the struggle for recognition between two conscious. Hegel posits that in the encounter, both individuals seek to assert their consciousness by being recognized by the other. Yet, for Hegel, true self-consciousness arises not just from being recognized but from the process of working on and transforming the world, which he refers to as "labor." In the dialectic, the master achieves recognition through the subjugation of the slave but remains *dependent* on the slave for that recognition and does not engage in labor, ultimately stunting his own potential for self-realization. Conversely, the slave, through work and the transformation of nature, attains a degree of self-consciousness and self-realization that the master cannot. For Hegel, this process eventually leads to the slave's overcoming of his bondage, asserting his freedom, and negotiating a new form of relationship with the master, thus moving the dialectic forward towards mutual recognition and freedom. While Fanon was undoubtedly influenced by Hegel's dialectic, his writings in "Black Skin, White Masks" and "The Wretched of the Earth" provide a concrete analysis of the colonizer-colonized relationships, heavily implicating the role of violence and deeply entrenched systems of racism. Fanon's interest is in the psychological and socio-political repercussions of colonization and racial subjugation. For Fanon, the relationship between the colonizer *master* and the colonized *slave* is a dehumanizing one that traps colonized individuals in an inferior position and denies them their agency and humanity. In a sense, it is spiritually preserving to be the receiver of suffering than to be the do-er. Doing renders the master dependent on the slave for identity by their own force of will, whereas it is external forces bounding the slaves identity offering a more fulling release of limiting narratives and self assumption when the time comes. Fanon's work expands upon the master-slave dynamic by including the racial dimensions that Hegel's abstract treatment does not explicitly address. He sees the liberation of the colonized not simply as a theoretical endeavor but as a violent struggle against colonial powers—necessary to regain humanity, self-respect, and independence. Moreover, Fanon uniquely emphasizes the psychological damage done by this relationship, including the internalization of inferiority among the colonized and the adoption of the colonizer's culture and values as a means of seeking recognition. Through struggle and revolution, both physically and mentally, Fanon envisions the breaking of colonial chains and the establishment of a new humanism that would be free from the master-slave dynamic inherent in colonial relationships. In synthesizing both thinkers, one can view Fanon's reflection on the colonizer's struggle as an extension of the Hegelian master-slave dynamic into the concrete realm of imperialism and racial oppression. Fanon acknowledges the dialectical progression but insists on the necessity of violence as a means for the colonized to achieve self-recognition and liberation. Where Hegel's slave gradually achieves self-consciousness through labor, Fanon's colonists achieve it through revolutionary action and the reclamation of their own history and identity.

The Manifestos

The AfroSurrealist Manifesto, D. Scott Miller

The renowned Afro-Surreal Manifesto, written by D. Scot Miller in 2009, contains the famous line: "Afro-Surrealism sees that all 'others' who create from their actual, lived experience are surrealists". and "Afro-Surrealists restore the cult of the past" and the idea that "Afro-Surreal presupposes that beyond this visible world, there is an invisible world striving to manifest, and it is our job to uncover it." Afro-surrealism is a part of the black arts movement that takes our world and creates a different scenescape that is still somewhat connected to this one, giving Black artists the space to be as free as they'd like to express energetic motions of worry, liberty, and injustice. The entire movement of Black abstract arts is referred to as the Black Speculative Arts Movement, or BSAM. Afro-surrealism was given recognition by BSAM.

Miller introduces his manifesto by referencing Ralph Ellison's "Invisible Man" and the character of Rinehart to introduce the concept of Afro-Surrealism. In navigating a world filled with complex identities and societal contradictions, Ellison leads Amiri Baraka to term this emerging aesthetic *Afro-Surreal Expressionism*. Miller makes crucial distinctions in the nature of surrealism, claiming that while european surrealism is characterized as empirical, African Surrealism is mystical and metaphorical. Afro-Surrealism explores the "otherness" inherent in lived experiences, focusing on present realities and shared historical experiences rather than speculative futures, as seen in Afro-Futurism, which prioritizes science and technology. Afro-Surrealism critiques the socio-political landscape, using art to challenge and reinterpret historical narratives. It acts as a defiant response to a society that marginalizes and erases the experiences of Black artists and communities. Engagement with nature posits that the natural world generates inherently surreal experiences. Afro-Surrealism's manifesto seeks to reshape how art and culture are perceived and experienced, advocating for an art movement that acknowledges and celebrates the surreal aspects of Black lived experiences.

The European Surrealist Manifesto

In *Surrealist Manifesto*, André Breton uncovers the philosophy behind the surrealist movement, advocating for an art form that breaks from the constraints of the rational mind. Saying adieu to conventional logic, he encourages the exploration of the subconscious, viewing it as an untapped source of untamed creativity and wild imagination. For him, true reality, or "surreality," lies in the amalgamation of dreams and reality, where the mind roams unrestricted. Further, Breton emphasizes poetry as the key to unlocking this surreality. He suggests that creative minds should tap into the process of drawing subconscious thoughts and emotions – much like in dreaming – to create art and literature without preconditions or censorship, thereby mimicking the process of dreaming while awake. He sees the potential in all human beings to connect with their subconscious and, through this revolution of thought, to elevate their imagination and creativity. He highlights the concept of "automatic writing," a practice in which one writes without conscious thought, also takes the central stage in Breton's discourse. Practical in nature, he proposes it as a tool for sidestepping our critical mind to access the untamed mental landscape of thoughts, ideas, and feelings that we might otherwise censor consciously. According to Breton, this technique stimulates surrealism, forming a bridge between the conscious and subconscious realms. Yet, his vision of surrealism was not confined to literature and art alone. He envisioned it as a radical revolution that could transform society. This extended vision, underpinned by ideals of political and social change, imagined a world where human behavior is not governed by reason and normality, disrupting the status quo. He also highlights embracing the irrational. Throughout the *Surrealist Manifesto*, Breton argues against rationality as the only means of understanding the world. Rather, he underscores the importance of the unpredictable, irrational, and absurd, viewing these elements as just as integral in our understanding of life. In his surreal world, images need not be logically connected, thoughts need not follow a rational thread, and dreams have equal standing with our wakeful experiences. A pivotal moment in the book witnesses Breton illustrating this theory with a trickle of poetic images unleashed from his subconscious. They sum up his vision of surrealism: a stream of absurd, illogical, and disconnected images that reflect the mind unrestrained by reason. These examples, revealing Breton's own practice of automatic writing, demonstrate surrealism in action, painting a dramatic image of untethered creativity. As the manifesto culminates, Breton lays stress on the omnipresent possibility of surrealist thought. He suggests that surrealism is not an exclusive realm of artists or poets but is accessible to anyone who dares to explore their subconscious freely. He frankly admits that while surrealism may seem shocking and chaotic at first, it is the path to true liberation of the mind from societal and intellectual restrictions. Breton's *Surrealist Manifesto* ignites a radical shift in understanding and experiencing reality.

Methodology, An Artistic Review

As art is a subjective representation of life, in this method analysis, the paper will take care not to attempt to convey numeric quantitative value onto the pieces of literary and visual works that will be brought to the forefront of analysis. Rather encouraging the reader to simply observe the content within the various case studies. While offering commentaries to guide the viewer and highlight key factors in the work, this section will take a step back from analyzing the art qualitatively. This will be saved for the Analysis portion of the paper where the meaning behind the piece as well as effect, and impact will be studied to suggest surrealist value within the piece and how it interacts with reality. However, due to the subjective nature of art, any reader can offer a different perspective of the piece at hand, so once more, it is encouraged for the reader to enter with an open mind before consumption.. The goal being to offer a friendly and explorative understanding of surrealist art, how it has come to be, and further, how it has shaped its affiliated culture, comparing it to european forms of surrealism.

Methods Case Studies

Literary Art MediaCase Study

These case studies should offer a deep dive into the unique characteristics of surrealist literature, exploring the radical and often disruptive techniques employed by surrealist writers to evoke the unconscious mind, challenge rational thought, and subvert traditional narrative structures. Engage with seminal Surrealist texts, examining how authors utilized semantics to rupture the

boundary between reality and imagination or to highlight absurdities in inhumane or seemingly unreal existence. Prioritizing critical thinking and creative experimentation, this section highlights authors who push the boundaries of literary expression. Here the paper presents written work that varies from literature, fiction, poetry and proverbs.

Writing Cases: Afro Surrealism

Case 1: *Darkwater: Voices from Within the Veil*, W.E.B. Du Bois

W.E.B. Du Bois's "Darkwater: Voices from Within the Veil" is an all-encompassing text that seamlessly blends autobiography, history, poetry, and political and economic theory. It dissects critical questions of race, class, gender, art, language, and pedagogy from Du Bois's unique perspective as a Black American man who has, as he puts it, "been in the world, but not of it." The text, through a series of essays, stories, and poems, lays bare the complex web of American culture and democracy by exposing the intersecting oppressive systems that shape it. In the essay "The Souls of White Folk," Du Bois delves deeply into the metaphor of the Veil, elaborating on his unique vantage point into Whiteness from his position as a Black man in the so-called ivory tower. This surreal perspective allows him to perceive the stark realities that imperialism has wrought on both the white and Black collective consciousness. Particularly poignant is his critique of the faux benevolence that masks the "vindictive joy" (Du Bois, 19) white Americans feel at the oppression of Black people. Du Bois also highlights a central problem within white America as a refusal to acknowledge "human frailty" and "shortcomings." (Du Bois, 20-21). This arrogance, he argues, hinders the greater project of "infinite development," suggesting that maximum human advancement will only come if white men abandon dreams of "future kingdoms of greed built on black and brown and yellow slavery."(Du Bois, 34) Du Bois's theory echoes the revolutionary sentiments of natural rights theorists, positing that humankind is inherently connected in the pursuit of collective advancement. When any faction hinders this through oppression or disenfranchisement, it is justifiable to counter it in order to move humanity forward. He calls for aggressive action from the oppressed, advocating for the organization of people of color to "organize [their] world for war against Europe" if racist attitudes persist. The Veil is one of Du Bois's most significant concepts and symbols within the book, representing a psychological manifestation of the color line. While the color line physically defines access to opportunities and institutions, the Veil exists in people's minds, compelling white people to structure society along a racist logic. It prevents white people from seeing Black individuals as fully human and integral Americans, while simultaneously distorting how Black people perceive themselves, filtering their self-view through a lens of negativity created by racism. Du Bois argues that the Veil is a constant presence, albeit one not always consciously felt. It dawns gradually upon young Black children, with Du Bois poignantly noting a sense of perverse relief that his son died before growing old enough to perceive the Veil. This innocent ignorance sometimes extends beyond childhood, as exemplified by John Jones, who only feels the Veil's weight after leaving rural Georgia. This suggests that the Veil is felt less severely by those within segregated Black communities, or where racial inequality is assumed as a fundamental and permanent aspect of life. Through this surreal metaphor, Du Bois captures the profound psychological and societal impact of racism, shaping identities and perpetuating a divided consciousness that hinders true unity and progress.

Key Du Bois Quotes-

"Beneath the Veil lay right and wrong, vengeance and love, and sometimes throwing aside the veil, a soul of sweet Beauty and Truth stood revealed."

"Herein lies the tragedy of the age: not that men are poor,— all men know something of poverty; not that men are wicked, — who is good? not that men are ignorant,— what is Truth? Nay, but that men know so little of men."

"One ever feels his twoness,- an American, a Negro; two souls, two thoughts, two unreconciled strivings; two warring ideals in one dark body, whose strength alone keeps it from being torn asunder."

"The South believed an educated Negro to be a dangerous Negro. And the South was not wholly wrong; for education among all kinds of men always has had, and always will have, an element of danger and revolution, of dissatisfaction and discontent. Nevertheless, men strive to know."

"Honest and earnest criticism from those whose interests are most nearly touched,- criticism of writers by readers, of government by those governed, of leaders by those led, - this is the soul of democracy and the safeguard of modern society"

"To the real question, How does it feel to be a problem? I answer seldom a word."

Case 2: Dark Days James Baldwin

In his 1980 essay "Dark Days," James Baldwin posed the penetrating question, "What happens [...] when a reality finds itself on a collision course with a fantasy?" He observed that white people in America had largely turned into sleepwalkers, suggesting a disconnection from the harsh realities around them. This dissonance resonates even more powerfully in today's globalized world, where the collision of reality and fantasy profoundly affects identity, Black consciousness, and white guilt. Communicating Black

issues through the language of fantasy— a realm Baldwin suggests is intimately familiar to white people, even though the ultimate goal of Black art is not solely to speak to them. When reality and fantasy collide, the surreal nature of this encounter forces a examination of deeply held beliefs and identities. For Black Americans, this collision brings to the forefront the cognitive dissonance between the lived reality of systemic oppression and the fantastical narratives of equality and progress often perpetuated by mainstream society. This gap creates a unique space for Black consciousness to grapple with dual identities—one rooted in the harshness of lived experiences and another shaped by the elusive promises of an equitable society. This duality often results in a heightened awareness of self and an acute sense of the underlying societal contradictions. On the other hand, white Americans' consciousness is often cushioned by the fantasy of a post-racial society, which allows for the perpetuation of white guilt and a selective engagement with reality. Baldwin describes white Americans as sleepwalkers who inhabit a dreamlike state, oblivious to the systemic inequalities that sustain their privilege. This denial inhibits genuine engagement with the painful historical and present realities faced by Black communities and perpetuates a cycle of superficial acknowledgment and deep-seated inaction. The collision of reality with this fantasy can be jarring, confronting white individuals with the uncomfortable truths that undermine their perceived moral high ground and forcing a reckoning with their own identity. Baldwin's exploration in "Dark Days" ventures into the dark tunnel of consciousness required to understand what it means to be a white American complicit in these systemic disparities. He articulates the "relentless conundrum" of racial division, a chasm deepened by age, race, time, place, and economics, and protected by the institutions and authorities people trust. As reality intrudes upon carefully constructed fantasies, it lays bare the truths that have been conveniently ignored, urging both Black and white individuals to confront and reconfigure their identities within this fractured landscape. Thus, the collision of reality and fantasy creates a surreal space where identities are challenged and reshaped. For Black consciousness, it means navigating the tension between lived experiences and aspirational fantasies. For white consciousness, it entails waking from a dreamlike state to confront uncomfortable realities and the guilt that accompanies them. Baldwin's insights compel us to face these collisions head-on, acknowledging the profound effects on identity and the potential pathways to a more truthful and just coexistence.

Key Baldwin Quotes-
"No curtain under heaven is heavier than that curtain of guilt and lies behind which white Americans hide."
"The romance of treason never occurred to us for the brutally simple reason that you can't betray a country you don't have. (Think about it)."

"A mob is not autonomous: it executes the real will of the people who rule the State. The slaughter in Birmingham, Alabama, for example, was not merely the action of a mob[collective conscious]."

"It is an extraordinary achievement to be trapped in the dungeon of color and to dare to shake down its walls and to step out of it, leaving the jailhouse keeper in the rubble"

"I know very well that my ancestors had no desire to come to this place: but neither did the ancestors of the people who became white and who require my captivity song; They require of me a song less to celebrate my captivity than to justify their own."

"The question of color was but another detail, somewhere between being six feet tall and being six feet under."

Case 3: "Black Skin, White Masks" France Fannon
Frantz Fanon's "Black Skin, White Masks" resurfaces in this paper as Case 3, presenting an in-depth analysis of the psychological pathologies produced by colonialism, particularly in the French Antilles. Fanon's main thesis is that colonialism and racism corrupt the psyche of both Blacks and whites, albeit in different ways: "the Negro enslaved by his inferiority [and] the white man enslaved by his superiority alike behave in accordance with a neurotic orientation" (p. 60). Although Fanon's work was first published in 1952, its language and concepts resonate with modern progressive thought. Critical theorists' definition of 'white supremacy' captures the ingrained psychological and cultural dominance that Fanon identified as products of colonialism. Fanon astutely observes that racism survives and can be perpetuated not merely by individual prejudices or institutions but by culture and deeply ingrained patterns of thought. He argues that changing laws and behavior alone is insufficient to eliminate racism; it must be recognized and uprooted at the level of our worldview. Though Fanon suggests that racialized thinking is embedded in our "collective unconscious," he rejects Jung's idea that this unconscious is a kind of "ancestral memory" (which he finds dubious). Instead, he identifies it as our inherited culture, not located in "the inherited cerebral matter" but in "the sum of prejudices, myths, and collective attitudes of a given group" (p. 188). Throughout the book, Fanon provides only one quantitative piece of data to support his conclusion. In a section on the "phobia of Negroes" (p. 165), he asks 500 patients to free associate using the word "Negro." He reports that "almost 60 percent of the replies··· brought forth biology, penis, strong, athletic, potent, boxer, Joe Lewis, Jesse Owens, Senegalese troops, savage, animal, devil, sin" (p. 166). Yet, this category is unbelievably broad and lacks detailed breakdown, making it difficult to draw reliable conclusions from the data. Fanon's heavy reliance on Freudian psychoanalysis, with its frequent invocation of sex to explain various

phenomena, is also questionable. He asserts, "In relation to the Negro, everything takes place on the genital level" (p. 157) and suggests that white men's hatred of Black men stems from feelings of impotence or sexual inferiority (p. 159). He writes that the Negro "is viewed as a penis symbol" and "is turned into a penis. He is a penis" (p. 170). The most surprising aspect of Fanon's work appears in his final chapter. Here, Fanon unexpectedly disavows attempts to live in the past, stoke anger, or demand restitution for past offenses as remedies for racial ills—language that modern progressives might find decidedly un-progressive. He states, "In no way should I derive my basic purpose from the past of the peoples of color. In no way should I dedicate myself to the revival of an unjustly unrecognized Negro civilization… I as a man of color do not have the right to seek ways of stamping down the pride of my former master. I have neither the right nor the duty to claim reparation for the domestication of my ancestors… I have one right alone: That of demanding human behavior from the other. One duty along: That of not renouncing my freedom through my choices…" (p. 228-229). This existential, individualistic approach to racial reconciliation stands in stark contrast to the modern antiracist movement. Fanon's work is valuable as a piece of testimony and offers profound insights into the deep psychological embedding of racism. However, his methods are highly suspect, and some of his claims about female sexuality may strike contemporary readers as incredibly distasteful. His concluding thoughts, though surprising, are consistent with his existentialist philosophy and provide a unique contrast to modern progressive ideology.

Key Quotes-
"When people like me, they like me "in spite of my color." When they dislike me; they point out that it isn't because of my color. Either way, I am locked in to the infernal circle."

"To speak a language is to take on a world, a culture."

"It would create a feeling that is extremely uncomfortable, called cognitive dissonance. And because it is so important to protect the core belief, they will rationalize, ignore and even deny anything that doesn't fit in with the core belief."

"In the World through which I travel, I am endlessly creating myself."

"I am black, not because of a curse, but because my skin has been able to capture all the cosmic effluvia. I am truly a drop of sun under the earth."

"Negrophobes exist. It is not hatred of the Negro, however, that motivates them; they lack the courage for that, or they have lost it. Hate is not inborn; it has to be constantly cultivated, to be brought into being, in conflict with more or less recognized guilt complexes. "

Case 4: Cole Arthur Riley, Black Literacies & This Here Flesh: Spirituality, Liberation, and the Stories That Make Us
In the summer of 2020, Cole Arthur Riley was desperate for a spirituality she could trust. Amidst ongoing national racial violence, the isolation of the pandemic, and a surge of anti-Black rhetoric in many Christian spaces, she began dreaming of a harbor for a more human, more liberating expression of faith. She went on to create Black Liturgies, a digital project that connects spiritual practice with Black emotion, memory, and the Black body. She offers literature that resonates with the pained African conscious. "This Here Flesh" is a profound and evocative work by Riley that explores themes of spirituality, liberation, and the power of storytelling within the context of Black experience. Through personal narrative and reflective prose, Riley delves into the intricate tapestry of her family's history and her own journey towards understanding identity, faith, and freedom. The book blends memoir, theology, and cultural critique, inviting readers to contemplate the ways in which stories—both personal and communal—shape our understanding of the world and our place in it. Riley's writing is deeply introspective, often drawing on spiritual traditions and practices to illuminate the paths to healing and liberation. "This Here Flesh" engages with the concept of Black Literacies by foregrounding the rich oral and written traditions that have sustained Black communities through generations. It acknowledges the resilience and resourcefulness inherent in these literacies, highlighting how they serve as tools for resistance, resilience, and reclamation of identity amidst ongoing struggles for justice and equality. In essence, Riley's work is a testament to the transformative power of storytelling and an invitation to reclaim the narratives that define us. It speaks to the soul, urging readers to embrace their own stories and the collective stories of their communities as a means of spiritual and social liberation.

Key Riley Quotes-
"To be human in an aching world is to know our dignity and become people who safeguard the dignity of everything around us."

"Seeing a person or piece of creation trampled should always disrupt something in us. It should always do something to the soul. And when you trace that trampling back across generations and systems and powers, a quiet sorrow is born in you."

"The chasm between the spiritual and the physical is no greater than that between a thought and a word. They cannot be disconnected. And it is difficult to tell where one ends and the other begins, perhaps because there is no such place."

"Audre Lorde said, "I cannot hide my anger to spare you guilt, nor hurt feelings…. Guilt is not a response to anger; it is a response to one's own actions or lack of action. If it leads to change then it can be useful, since it is then no longer guilt but the beginning of knowledge."

"I've accepted that the whole of my life will be a pilgrimage toward the sound of the genuine in me. This may sound troubling to those who've been conditioned to believe that our journey is to God and God alone, but I say the two paths are one. My journey to the truth of God cannot be parsed from my journey to the truth of who I am. A fidelity to the true self is a fidelity to truth. I won't apologize for this."

"It takes time to undo the whiteness of God. When I speak of whiteness, I am referring not to the mere existence of a person in a particular body; I am referring to the historic, systemic, and sociological patterns that have oppressed, killed, abducted, abused, and discredited those who do not exist in a particular body. Whiteness is a force."

"And as a Black woman, I am disinterested in any call to spirituality that divorces my mind from my body, voice, or people."
"I have to believe that if we didn't need to protect ourselves, we wouldn't be so prone to avoiding rest. When fear enters the story, something changes."

"These are spiritual afflictions in and of themselves, but in religious communities, when whiteness becomes inseparable from the character of God, you'll find customs such as evangelism equated with conquering, but admissible under the guise of "love." You'll find guilt-driven spirituality, which is obsessed with alleviating guilt and becoming "clean"—for whiteness always carries the memory of what it has done to those in bodies of color, and guilt is its primary tormentor. The irony, of course, is that this guilt cannot be relieved save by a rending of whiteness from the image of God (which the force of whiteness will never do). In order to rend whiteness from the face of God, we must do more than make new images."

"Wonder then is a force of liberation, it makes sense of what our souls inherently know we were meant for. Every mundane glimpse is salve on a wound, instructions for how to set the bone right again. If you really want to get free, find God on the subway, find God in the soap bubble. Me, I meet God in the taste of my grandmas chicken, I hear God in the raspy leather of Nina Simones voice, I see the face of God in the boney teenager bagging my groceries and why shouldn't I? My faith is held together by wonder, by ever defined commitment to presence and paying attention."

Case 5: Akwaeke Emezi, The Death of Vivek Oji *African Fiction*

The Death of Vivek Oji is a novel by Nigerian author Akwaeke Emezi telling a poignant and intricate story about identity, family, grief, and the search for self-acceptance in a society riddled with expectations and norms. The narrative begins with the startling event of the discovery of Vivek Oji's lifeless body on his family's doorstep in southeastern Nigeria. This opening immediately plunges the reader into a mystery, prompting questions about how Vivek died and the circumstances leading up to this tragic moment. The story unfolds through multiple perspectives, primarily those of Vivek's mother, Kavita Oji, and his close cousin, Osita. Through their eyes and the fragmented, nonlinear structure of the narrative, the reader pieces together Vivek's life and the complexities surrounding it. Vivek Oji is a character marked by his striking physical beauty and enigmatic nature. From a young age, Vivek feels different and struggles with a profound sense of not fitting in. This alienation is exacerbated by the societal and cultural expectations placed on him, especially concerning gender norms and identity. As Vivek grows older, his struggle with identity becomes more pronounced. He experiences blackout spells and episodes of dissociation, which are distressing both for him and his family. Despite their love for him, Vivek's parents, Kavita and Chika, fail to fully understand his internal turmoil. Vivek finds solace and a semblance of understanding in his cousin Osita and a group of friends who support him through his journey of self-discovery. The novel delicately explores Vivek's process of coming to terms with his gender identity. He begins cross-dressing and eventually identifies more with a feminine presentation. These acts of self-expression are central to his sense of self but also put him at odds with the conservative society around him. Tragedy strikes when an act of violence, fueled by societal intolerance and misunderstanding, leads to Vivek's untimely death. The novel portrays this event with sensitivity and does not sensationalize the violence. Instead, it sheds light on the consequences of societal rejection and the impact of losing a loved one to such circumstances. The central theme of the novel is Vivek's journey toward self-acceptance and understanding his true identity, despite societal pressures and expectations. The book explores how Vivek's family copes with his death and their struggle to understand and accept who Vivek was. Kavita's quest to uncover the truth about her child's final days is both heartbreaking and liberating. Vivek's friends play a crucial role in his life, providing the acceptance and love he desperately needs. Their relationships highlight the importance of chosen family and community support. The narrative critiques rigid gender norms, societal intolerance, and the violence that these can inflict on individuals who do not conform to traditional expectations. Akwaeke Emezi's writing is lyrical and evocative, capturing the emotional depth of the characters and the lush setting of Nigeria. The use of multiple viewpoints and the nonlinear structure adds layers to the storytelling, making the reader work to piece together the mystery of Vivek's life and death. Emezi's prose is both haunting and beautiful, reflecting the complexity of the themes addressed in the novel.

Key Emezi Quotes–
"Some people can't see softness without wanting to hurt it"

"The first step to seeing is seeing that there are things you do not see."

"If nobody sees you, are you still there?"

"The truth does not change whether it is seen or unseen."

'It was the clearest terror and pleasure I had ever known."

"Love and guilt sometimes taste the same, you know."

"Alone is a feeling you can get used to, and it's hard to believe in a better alternative."

"Fresh starts were good: that separateness was where you could feel yourself, where you could learn who you were apart from everyone else."

"His grief was chasing him from room to room, begging him to spend some time alone with it."

"I often wonder if I died in the best possible way – in the arms of the one who loved me the most, wearing a skin that was true."

Case 6: Idioms, Euphemisms, and Proverbs
These proverbs, idioms, and euphemisms offer profound insights into different aspects of life, knowledge, wisdom, and love. They encapsulate universal truths and lessons acquired through generations of human experience. African proverbs are a powerful element within African cultures, serving as reservoirs of wisdom, morals, and communal values. They encapsulate the philosophies and lived experiences of African peoples, passed down orally through generations as tools for teaching, advising, and guiding behavior. In essence, African proverbs are more than mere sayings, they are foundational elements of cultural expression and intellectual heritage. They serve as bridges between generations, linking the past, present, and future through the enduring power of language and storytelling.

In Relation to Life:
"A bird that flies off the Earth and lands on an anthill is still on the ground."
This means that achievements or escapes that seem significant may still be relatively minor in the grand scheme. It indicates that humility and perspective are important, as perceived progress might be minimal in a broader context.

"Only a fool tests the depth of a river with no feet."
It's foolish to undertake a task or danger without proper preparation. It stresses that adequate preparation and caution are essential before taking risks.

"A roaring lion kills no game."
Making noise or boasting doesn't achieve results. It underscores that actions speak louder than words; effectiveness lies in deeds, not in boasting.

"Restless feet might walk you into a snake pit."
Wandering aimlessly or being overly adventurous can lead to danger. It emphasizes that thoughtful planning and caution are important to avoid potential pitfalls.

"When two elephants fight, it is the grass that gets hurt."
When powerful entities clash, it's the weaker ones who suffer. It highlights that the consequences of conflicts among the powerful often impact the vulnerable.

"He who digs a grave for his enemy might as well be digging one for himself."
Vengeance or malice can backfire on the perpetrator. It illustrates that harbored ill intentions towards others often end up harming oneself.

"However long the night, the dawn will break."
Difficult times will eventually pass. It encourages perseverance through hardships, for they are temporary, and relief will come.
"

The axe forgets but the tree remembers."
Oppressors may forget the harm done, but the victim remembers. It shows that actions can have long-lasting impacts on others, even if they are forgotten by the doer.

"Once you carry your own water, you'll remember every drop."
Personal effort brings awareness and appreciation. It indicates that responsibility and self-reliance cultivate appreciation for resources and labor.

"Seeing is different than being told."
Personal experience is more impactful than hearsay. It suggests that direct experience enriches understanding more deeply than second-hand information.

"Wood already touched by fire is not hard to set alight."
Previous experiences or trauma make one more susceptible to similar situations. It implies that past experiences can heighten sensitivity to future events.

"He who refuses to obey cannot command."
Effective leaders must understand and follow the rules themselves. It stresses that obedience to principles is a prerequisite for leadership.

"One falsehood spoils a thousand truths."
A single lie can undermine many truths. It underlines that integrity is crucial as dishonesty can erode trust and credibility.

"The earth is a beehive, we all enter by the same door."
Despite differences, we share commonalities. It emphasizes that human experiences are fundamentally similar, regardless of outward disparities.

"Rain does not fall on one roof alone."
Misfortune or fortune affects more than one, often impacting a broader community. It suggests that external events often have widespread effects, impacting many lives.

"If you think you're too small to make a difference, try spending the night with a mosquito."
Even small entities can have a significant impact. It conveys that one should never underestimate the power of an individual's actions, no matter how small.

"If there is no enemy within, the enemy outside can do no harm."
Inner peace and integrity protect against external threats. It indicates that internal strength and self-awareness are crucial defenses against external adversities.

In Relation to Knowledge and Wisdom:

"Examine what is said, not who is speaking."
Value lies in the content of a message over the speaker's identity. It suggests that one should seek wisdom in the message itself, regardless of its source.

"If you want to know the end, look at the beginning."
Understanding origins can provide insights into outcomes. It indicates that past actions and origins often shape future results and understanding them is key.

"Knowledge is a garden. If it isn't cultivated, you can't harvest it."
Knowledge must be tended and nurtured to be useful. It highlights that active effort and maintenance are essential for personal growth and knowledge retention.

"However far a stream flows, it doesn't forget its origin."
One's background and beginnings remain important regardless of how far one progresses. It suggests that acknowledging and remembering one's roots is essential for a grounded perspective.

"The eye never forgets what the heart has seen."
Emotional experiences leave lasting impressions. It indicates that deep, emotional experiences are indelibly etched in memory, influencing one's worldview.

"If you are filled with pride, then you will have no room for wisdom."
Pride obstructs the acquisition of wisdom. It implies that humility is necessary for acquiring and appreciating wisdom.

"A wise person will always find a way."
Wisdom enables one to navigate and overcome challenges. It emphasizes that true wisdom is adaptable and resourceful, finding solutions in diverse situations.

In Relation to Love:
"When one is in love, a cliff becomes a meadow."
Love transforms one's perception, making challenges seem manageable. It suggests that the power of love can drastically alter one's view of reality.

"He who loves, loves you with your dirt."
True love embraces imperfections. It highlights that authentic love accepts and cherishes the beloved despite flaws and shortcomings.

"If love is a sickness, patience is the remedy."
Patience is essential in dealing with the challenges of love. It indicates that enduring love requires patience and perseverance through difficulties.

"To love someone who doesn't love you is like shaking a tree to make the dew drops fall."
Unrequited love is futile and exhausting. It suggests that love should be mutual for it to be fulfilling and meaningful.

"Love, like rain, does not choose the grass on which it falls."
Love is indiscriminate, touching all it encounters. It indicates that love's outreach is universal and nondiscriminatory.

"Love doesn't listen to rumors."
True love is unaffected by outside talk or slander. It highlights that genuine love withstands external noise and judgments.

"One who loves the vase, loves also what is inside."
Loving the exterior means loving the interior as well. It suggests that true affection extends beyond appearance to encompass inner qualities.

"Love for something makes a man blind and deaf."
Intense affection can cloud judgment. It indicates that love has the potential to overshadow reason and objectivity.

"Let your love be like the misty rain, coming softly but flooding the river."
Love should grow gently but profoundly. It suggests that love's impact is most profound when it develops delicately yet deeply.

"Every kind of love is love, but self-love is supreme among them."
All forms of love are valuable, but self-love is paramount. It highlights that loving oneself is the foundation for all other forms of love.

"He may say that he loves you, wait and see what he does for you."
Actions validate professed love. It indicates that true love is demonstrated through actions, not just words.

"Lovers do not hide their nakedness."
True lovers are fully open and vulnerable to each other. It emphasizes that genuine love involves complete honesty and exposure.

"When one is in love, a mountain top becomes a flat field."
Love simplifies and reduces the perceived difficulty of challenges. It suggests that love transforms obstacles into surmountable or even trivial challenges.

These proverbs and idioms encapsulate essential truths and wisdom, offering guidance on navigating life's various dimensions. They stress the importance of experience, humility, perseverance, and authentic emotions, providing timeless principles that can enrich understanding and relationships.

Writings Counter Cases, European Surrealism
Counter Case 1: Freedom in Love, André Breton
This Surrealist Manifesto author's poem presents the speaker's wife as a collection of disparate and enigmatic images, each evoking a different aspect of her beauty, sensuality, and mystery. The fragmentary style and unexpected juxtapositions create a dreamlike atmosphere that defies rational interpretation. Compared to the author's other works, this poem exhibits a similar fascination with the irrational and the erotic, but its focus on the female body is more pronounced.

My wife with the hair of a wood fire
With the thoughts of heat lightning
With the waist of an hourglass
With the waist of an otter in the teeth of a tiger
My wife with the lips of a cockade and of a bunch of stars of the last magnitude
With the teeth of tracks of white mice on the white earth
With the tongue of rubbed amber and glass
My wife with the tongue of a stabbed host
With the tongue of a doll that opens and closes its eyes
With the tongue of an unbelievable stone
My wife with the eyelashes of strokes of a child's writing
With brows of the edge of a swallow's nest
My wife with the brow of slates of a hothouse roof
And of steam on the panes
My wife with shoulders of champagne
And of a fountain with dolphin-heads beneath the ice
My wife with wrists of matches
My wife with fingers of luck and ace of hearts
With fingers of mown hay
My wife with armpits of marten and of beechnut
And of Midsummer Night
Of privet and of an angelfish nest
With arms of seafoam and of riverlocks
And of a mingling of the wheat and the mill
My wife with legs of flares
With the movements of clockwork and despair
My wife with calves of eldertree pith
My wife with feet of initials
With feet of rings of keys and Java sparrows drinking
My wife with a neck of unpearled barley
My wife with a throat of the valley of gold
Of a tryst in the very bed of the torrent
With breasts of night
My wife with breasts of a marine molehill
My wife with breasts of the ruby's crucible
With breasts of the rose's spectre beneath the dew
My wife with the belly of an unfolding of the fan of days
With the belly of a gigantic claw
My wife with the back of a bird fleeing vertically
With a back of quicksilver
With a back of light
With a nape of rolled stone and wet chalk
And of the drop of a glass where one has just been drinking
My wife with hips of a skiff
With hips of a chandelier and of arrow-feathers

And of shafts of white peacock plumes
Of an insensible pendulum
My wife with buttocks of sandstone and asbestos
My wife with buttocks of swans' backs
My wife with buttocks of spring
With the sex of an iris
My wife with the sex of a mining-placer and of a platypus
My wife with a sex of seaweed and ancient sweetmeat
My wife with a sex of mirror
My wife with eyes full of tears
With eyes of purple panoply and of a magnetic needle
My wife with savanna eyes
My wife with eyes of water to he drunk in prison
My wife with eyes of wood always under the axe
My wife with eyes of water-level of level of air earth and fire

Counter Case 2: Mirabeau Bridge, Guillaume Apollinaire *Translated*
Guillaume Apollinaire (1880–1918) was a French poet, playwright, and art critic, widely considered one of the most influential literary figures of the early 20th century. "Mirabeau Bridge" or "Le Pont Mirabeau" is a famous poem by Guillaume Apollinaire, first published in 1913 in his collection "Alcools." The poem is a melancholic meditation on the passage of time and lost love, set against the backdrop of the Mirabeau Bridge in Paris, which spans the Seine River. Apollinaire uses the flow of the river as a metaphor for the relentless flow of time, conveying a sense of longing and impermanence. The poem is celebrated for its lyrical beauty, emotional depth, and innovative use of form, embodying the themes of modernity, memory, and the transient nature of human experience.

Under the Mirabeau bridge flows the Seine
And our loves
He has to remind me of that
Joy always came after pain.
Vienna the night strikes the hour
The days go away I remain
Hands in hands let's stay face to face
While under
The bridge of our arms passes
Eternal gazes the wave so weary
Vienna the night strikes the hour
The days go away I remain
Love goes away like this running water
Love flies away
how slow life is
And how violent Hope is
Vienna the night strikes the hour
The days go away I remain
The days pass and the weeks pass
Nor time spent
Neither loves return
Under the Mirabeau bridge flows the Seine.

Counter Case 3: Yvan Goll
Yvan Goll (1891–1950) was a versatile poet and writer of German-French descent, known for his significant contributions to both expressionist and surrealist movements. Goll's literary career traversed multiple languages and countries, reflecting his multicultural background. He wrote poetry, plays, and prose in both French and German, embodying themes of existential angst, love, and pacifism. These poems explore complex themes of human experience through rich, dense imagery.

Café
All the town's other people
Were just dusty, pale lanterns
Profiteering from others' light. –

Only here did I find friends,
Still true forests, thorny and deep,
Or plains
With wind–pure feeling.
Here was beautiful animal instinct,
Hands had the gesture
Of budding roses.
Like music
Hovered what they said
Over the roar of Cyclops City.

"Café," contrasts the genuine warmth and authenticity found within the café's visitors against the superficial existence of the town's other inhabitants, described as "dusty, pale lanterns" profiteering from others' light. The café is depicted as a haven of true, unrefined emotion, akin to thorny, deep forests or plains with pure, wind–swept feelings. This authenticity is further emphasized through natural imagery, such as hands gesturing like budding roses and beautiful animal instincts, underscoring the sincerity and depth found in human connections amidst the impersonal chaos of "Cyclops City."

The Salt Sea
Like a winter animal the moon licks the salt of your hands,
Yet your hair foams violet like a lilac bush
Where the experienced owlet calls.
There the sought dream–city stands for us constructed,
Its streets all black and white.
You walk in the glitter snow of promise,
For me the tracks of dark reason have been laid.
The houses have been sketched against the sky with chalk,
Their doors forged of lead;
Only up under gables yellow candles grow
Like nails for numberless coffins.
But soon we get out to the salt sea.
There, lying in wait for us, the long–beaked ice–birds
I fight the whole night with bare hands
Before their warm down becomes our bed.

"The Salt Sea," the moon's intimate yet harsh act of licking salt from hands introduces a surreal, almost magical setting. The violet foaming hair and the calling of the experienced owlet create an ethereal atmosphere. The dream–city, with its stark black and white streets, symbolizes an idealized yet elusive reality. This poem navigates the tension between hope and harsh truth, depicted through the contrast of the glittering snow of promise and the dark tracks of reason. As they move towards the salt sea and grapple with long–beaked ice–birds, the struggle emerges as a transformative passage, blending struggle with an eventual semblance of warmth and comfort.

Morgue
In the ice of sleep
Liberated from roots
Wanders the dreamer
Wanders to never
Return
To the inn of earth
But in the abyss of his flesh
An old fire, tree–born,
Ripens calmly on.

"Morgue" delves into existential themes through stark, contrasting imagery. The "ice of sleep" suggests a detached, almost death–like state, while being "liberated from roots" implies a disconnection from foundational elements. The dreamer's journey away from the "inn of earth" signifies a transcendence or break from earthly existence, highlighting the tension between a cold, detached exterior and an enduring, vital essence within, represented as an "old fire, tree–born," ripening calmly. This juxtaposition of sleep,a metaphor for death, with inner fire underscores a dynamic interplay between stillness and inner vitality, offering a meditation on mortality and existence.

Collectively, these poems paint a nuanced picture of the human condition, emphasizing the tension between authenticity and superficiality, the coexistence of dreams and harsh reality, and the interplay of life and death.

Counter Case 4: Harry Potter Books 5–7

Exploring the latter half of the Harry Potter series, Books 5–7, through a surrealist lens focusing on the conflict between good and evil highlights the underlying complexities and abstract notions woven into J.K. Rowling's narrative. When applied to these books, surrealism unveils deeper, often hidden layers of the story, decoding the tangled dance of good and evil. These books hen perceived through a surrealist lens, unravel the intricate, subconscious entanglements of good and evil. It delves into the surreal boundaries of reality, memory, and identity, presenting an abstract, multifaceted view of the eternal conflict within and beyond human experience. Here, the vixen of good and evil is not merely an external battle but an internal odyssey through the surreal mist of human consciousness and moral ambiguity.

"Harry Potter and the Order of the Phoenix"

In this phase, Harry's struggle epitomizes the dream-like confrontation with an omnipresent, unseen evil—Lord Voldemort. The Ministry of Magic's denial of Voldemort's return echoes surrealist notions of a distorted reality, where truth is obfuscated and fragmented. The nightmarish maze of the Ministry, replete with shifting rooms and inscrutable motives, reflects an unsettling, Kafkaesque landscape where reason itself is unreliable. The very architecture of the Ministry becomes a labyrinth of perception and deception, complicating the demarcations of good and evil. Harry's own mind serves as a battleground, invaded by Voldemort in his dreams and visions. This intrusion symbolizes the porous boundaries between self and other, reality and illusion. Occlumency lessons with Snape, which blur into invasive forays into Harry's memory, unveil the surrealistic interplay of power and vulnerability. The death of Sirius Black in the Department of Mysteries, an environment where space and time feel disjointed, serves as a stark reminder of the fragile, ephemeral boundary between life and death—a common surrealist theme.

"Harry Potter and the Half-Blood Prince"

The surrealist narrative in this installment is heightened by Dumbledore's exploration of Voldemort's past. These journeys through memories, encapsulated in the Pensieve, resemble a descent into the subconscious, where the line between reality and recollection blurs. The distorted, fragmented visions of Tom Riddle's transformation into Voldemort present an eerie, surreal mosaic of a fractured soul dedicated to the pursuit of immortality—a grotesque parody of creation. The dark absurdity of Horcruxes, objects housing fragments of Voldemort's soul, reflects a surrealist fascination with the physical manifestation of psychological horrors. The fluid boundaries between animate and inanimate, life and death, suggest an almost Dali-esque displacement of conventional reality. Dumbledore's deteriorating health as he and Harry unravel these enigmas underscores the escalating toll of confronting such unfathomable darkness, echoing the surrealist preoccupation with the destructive nature of obsession and the irreversible impact of deep-seated traumas.

"Harry Potter and the Deathly Hallows"

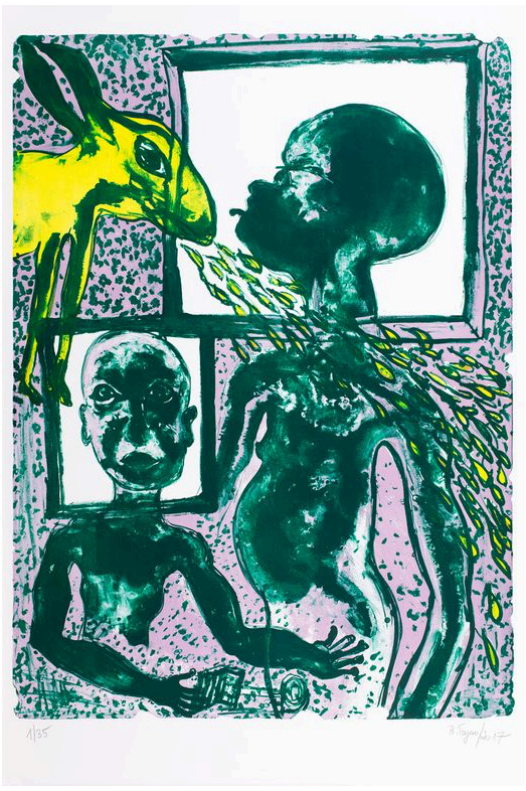
In the closing chapter, the surrealist dichotomy reaches its crescendo. The hallows and Horcruxes represent the duality of power—life and death, creation and destruction, intertwined in an otherworldly symbiosis. Harry's quest for understanding leads him to the Forest of Dean, an environment that feels dislocated in time and space, integrating natural beauty with a pervasive sense of foreboding. The dream-like vision Harry experiences after being struck by Voldemort involves an ethereal, limbo-like King's Cross Station, populated by spectral projections of past allies and adversaries. This interlude showcases the permeable boundaries between life, death, and the hereafter—where abstract notions of good and evil dissolve into personal choices and sacrificial love. Dumbledore surfaces with an awe inspiring line. When Harry asks if this limbo state was real or all in his head, Dumbledore response of course it's all in your, why should that make it any less real." This in addition to the final battle at Hogwarts that encapsulates a apocalyptic vista where the clash of various magical entities and elements are at a peak. Statues spring to life, time fluctuates, and reality shifts—transcendent moments of heroism are juxtaposed against abysmal depths of cruelty. The denouement, with Harry's sacrificial death and rebirth, aligns with the surrealist motif of transformation, where dissolution precedes reconstruction, emphasizing the fluid, subjective nature of reality.

Visual Arts Case Study

These case studies should offer a deep dive into the unique characteristics of surrealist visual art, exploring the subtle and glaring visual techniques employed by surrealist visual artists to evoke the unconscious mind, challenge rational thought, and subvert traditional narrative structures. Engage with seminal Surrealist content, examining how artists utilized space in relation to time to rupture the boundary between reality and imagination or to highlight absurdities in inhumane or seemingly unreal existence. This section highlights artists who push the boundaries of visual expression.

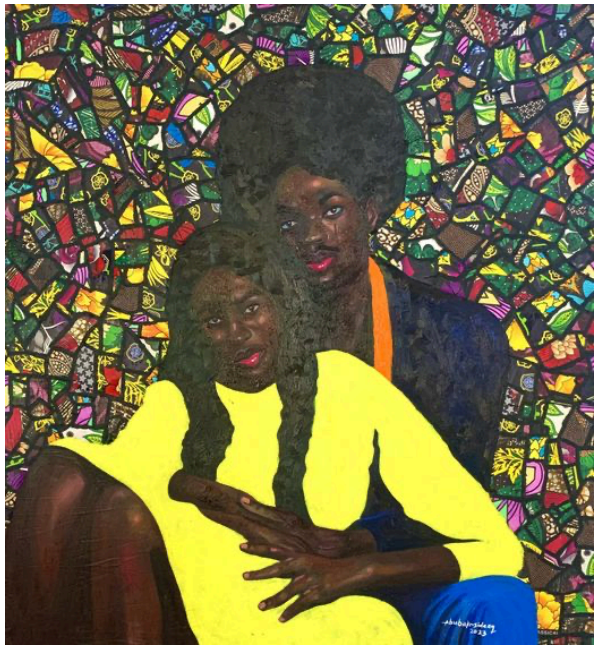
Still Life
Cases of Artsper Paintings and Stills for Sale

Case 1:'Power Black Excellence'

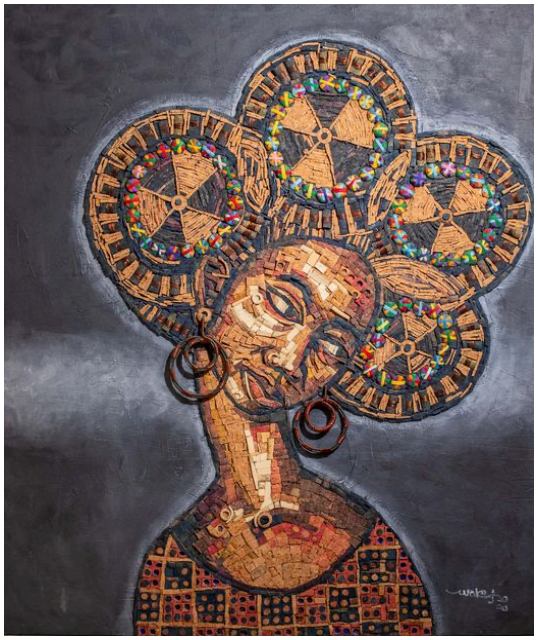


Case 2: 'Supernatural'

Case 3: 'Looking Beyond'



Case 4: 'Shades of Love'



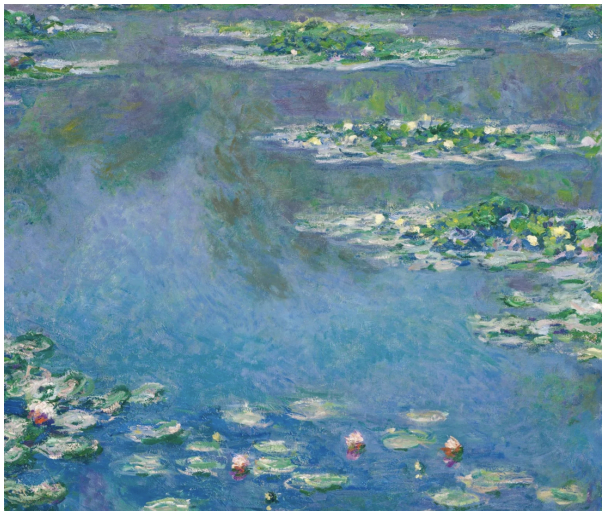
Case 5: 'Headload II'

Case 6: 'Ghetto Paradise'

Case 7: 'Introspect'

Case 8: 'The Drummer'

Counter Cases
Case 1 Monet



Case 2 Picasso

Exhibitions

Case 1: ARTECHOUSE New York, Ase: Afro Frequencies by Vince Fraiser and Ursela Rucker & Timeless Butterflies

Aṣẹ: Afro Frequencies is an immersive and interactive digital art exhibit developed by ARTECHOUSE in collaboration with Vince Fraser, a London-based Afrosurrealist digital artist and illustrator. Inspired by Aṣẹ, a West African concept related to our power to effect change, this exhibit celebrates the historical, social, and cultural dimensions of the Black experience. It presents reimagined realities, inviting viewers to perceive the world through Fraser's unique cultural lens, complemented by the evocative words of poet Ursula Rucker. This multi-sensory exhibition merges Fraser's distinct style with ARTECHOUSE's technological prowess to re-envision historical imagery and familiar scenes, blending the real and digital with a contemporary perspective. Ursula Rucker's poignant words, "Vision is the art of seeing what is impossible to others," and "It is important to know our stories, to learn our stories, to love our stories," underscore the exhibit's mission. Vince Fraser, an Afro-surrealist artist, seeks to inspire and empower with positive, potent imagery of the African diaspora. He considers himself part of a new breed of artists in the digital age, combining film and motion with a meticulous eye for detail and playful visual experimentation. The centerpiece of the exhibition, titled "Vision of the Black Experience," guides visitors through a four-part journey exploring resilience, cultural celebration, and future possibilities. Fraser's designs and Rucker's poetry reflect on the present zeitgeist, mystical aspects of African culture that have significantly influenced global popular culture, and a hopeful vision for the future. Visitors are enveloped in powerful imagery of Blackness, where kings and queens rotate through space, accompanied by rhythmic drums and narrated poetry that speaks to themes of empowerment, ancestry, and social justice. In addition to the cinematic main show, surrounding galleries enhance the ambiance, contributing to a fully immersive experience.

The Timeless Butterflies exhibition by AFROTECHOUSE is a mesmerizing digital art experience that explores themes of transformation, resilience, and cultural heritage through the symbolic and poetic imagery of butterflies. Drawing inspiration from the enduring symbolism of butterflies in African and African diasporic traditions, the exhibit reflects on personal and collective journeys of metamorphosis and self-renewal. AFROTECHOUSE has partnered with renowned digital artists and technologists to blend art, culture, and technology, creating a sensory journey that stimulates sight, sound, and touch. Key highlights include immersive installations with digital butterflies, interactive transformation chambers using VR, cultural narratives that highlight the significance of butterflies in African cultures, and workshops that explore the intersection of technology and traditional art forms. Poetry and musical compositions inspired by transformation themes enrich the exhibit's ambiance, while advanced technology integration, such

as AR mobile apps and QR codes, enhances the visitor experience. Committed to environmental conservation, the exhibition donates a portion of its proceeds to butterfly habitat preservation and uses eco-friendly materials. Timeless Butterflies ultimately stands as a fusion of art, technology, and cultural heritage, inviting visitors to contemplate their own journeys of transformation and renewal while celebrating the beauty and significance of butterflies.

Case 2: Before Yesterday We Could Fly, Metropolitan Museum of Art

The Metropolitan Museum of Art's latest innovative exhibition, *Before Yesterday We Could Fly: An Afrofuturist Period Room*, ventures into the realm of Afrofuturism by reimagining the past with an immersive experience. This space conjures the home of an African American family in Seneca Village—a vibrant community founded in the early 1820s by African American families and immigrant groups from Germany and Ireland—tragically razed in 1857 to make way for Central Park. Seneca Village was a beacon of resilience and community spirit, providing a sanctuary and stability for its residents, allowing them to build a future. The forced expropriation for Central Park's development fragmented this tight-knit community, embedding a historical narrative of dispossession and loss. Against this backdrop, the Afrofuturist period room not only honors the past but envisions a more just alternative future. The MET's approach challenges conventional museum narratives by intertwining historical context with imaginative speculation. Departing from traditional period rooms—typically recreating documented historical interiors—this space transcends such conventions, merging the historical with the fantastical to envision how African American life in Seneca Village might have evolved without displacement. The title Before Yesterday We Could Fly draws inspiration from African American folklore, particularly Virginia Hamilton's retellings of tales where slaves escape captivity by flying—metaphorically embodying freedom and resistance. The creation of this space involved meticulous, interdisciplinary collaboration among curators, decorators, scenographers, and historians. Their combined efforts ensure that the room honors Seneca Village's cultural and historical contexts while resonating with the visionary landscapes of Afrofuturism. By integrating heritage with futuristic aesthetics, the room offers an evolving narrative about reclaiming cultural memory and envisioning new possibilities. Afrofuturism, merging African diasporic culture with technology and speculative fiction, serves as a tool for rewriting history within the period room. It opens a dialogue between what was, what is, and what could be. This dialogue is deeply informed by scholars like Fred Moten and Saidiya Hartman, whose work on fugitivity—aesthetic of constant movement and resistance—provides a philosophical framework for the room. This evokes strategies of escape and resistance seen throughout the African-American experience. The room's design evokes flight and liberation depicted in traditional African American tales. Hamilton's cipher of slaves who could fly embodies themes of transcendence and resilience, echoing the room's ambition to transcend historical injustices by imagining a more equitable and liberated future. This conceptual framework allows visitors to not only engage with Seneca Village's history but to envision a world where African-American cultures and futures are vibrantly alive and full of potential. Thus, Before Yesterday We Could Fly transcends being just an exhibition space; it stands as an artistic endeavor that reclaims historical narratives through an Afrofuturist lens. It poignantly reminds us of a community's destruction while celebrating its enduring spirit and resilience. This period room exemplifies the power of imagination and creativity in reopening historical dialogues and inspires future generations to dream beyond present constraints. Through this innovative presentation, the Metropolitan Museum of Art reaffirms its commitment to showcasing diverse perspectives and acknowledging the rich, albeit often overlooked, cultural histories shaping our world today.

Case 3: Frist Art Museum

Sicasso. *Calm Before The Storm*, 2023. Courtesy of the artist. © Sicasso

Sicasso. *The Crew*, 2023. Courtesy of the artist. © Sicasso

Sicasso. *Promise Land*, 2023. Courtesy of the artist. © Sicasso

The Frist Art Museum presented "Afrofuturistic Visions: Dreamscapes of Sicasso," an installation that celebrates the beauty, culture, and history of African American people. The artist, Sicasso, invites viewers to dive into dreamlike spaces through her work. This installation, located in the Grand Lobby elevator at the east end of the museum, features five vinyl prints showcasing Sicasso's art. Visitors are taken on a visual journey through portrayals of African American figures embodying power, resilience, and grace. In this retro-futuristic realm, powerful Black characters stand out, symbolizing strength, resilience, and creativity, while radiating confidence and elegance. Each character is meticulously crafted, inspired by the vibrant 1970s, to honor the rich history and diverse heritage of Black culture. The installation pays tribute to icons like Angela Davis and envisions a future flourishing with Black excellence. The surreal dreamscapes blend fantasy with reality, created using the AI image generator Midjourney via Discord. Sicasso inputs descriptive phrases such as "'70s African American couple in a groovy rainbow room," producing psychedelic AI art that she merges with Afrofuturist elements to craft a sensory-stimulating, otherworldly experience. Curated by student curator Samaria Jones, "Afrofuturistic Visions" is the second installment of Project Uplift. This initiative offers HBCU students or recent graduates the chance to curate, design, develop, and market a micro-exhibition featuring a local BIPOC artist.

Counter Case 1: Atelier Des Lumieres Van Gohn & Japanese Dream

The Atelier des Lumières in Paris is a sanctuary of digital artistry, where the incandescent genius of Vincent van Gogh and the serene elegance of Japanese art converge in an enthralling symphony of sight and sound. In the Van Gogh, Starry Night exhibition, the

brilliant whirlwind of his masterpieces sweeps you off your feet. Stepping into a boundless realm where his iconic works are projected on immense walls, floors, and ceilings, you find yourself enveloped in the swirling blues of "Starry Night" and the vivid yellows of "Sunflowers." Entering the eerie showroom, completely darkened and extremely polarized to the sunshine from outside the exhibition, one finds a surrealist wonderland of art displayed through light. For a one hour show, complete with reflections of Van Gohn impressionist paintings and Japanese inspired scenes and illuminating music to match the tone and communicate a holistic message, one can experience the feeling of being inside a work of art itself. Every corner of the walls, and at times, floors are draped in imagery that allows the viewer to traverse into a deep state of observation. Peace and tranquility encases the space entirely. Amplified by a hauntingly beautiful musical score, the vibrant textures and luminous colors pulsate with van Gogh's emotional fervor, creating a transcendent experience that chronicles his tumultuous life journey—from the somber hues of his early Dutch paintings to the explosive colors of his final days in Auvers-sur-Oise.

Meanwhile, the Japanese Dream exhibition is a voyage through the ethereal landscapes of Japan's artistic heritage. Here, ancient ukiyo-e woodblock prints by masters like Hokusai and Hiroshige come alive, their intricate details magnified and animated to create a mesmerizing tapestry of Japan's cultural lore. As you wander through immersive projections of traditional screen paintings and scrolls depicting scenes of nature, festivals, and samurai, you are swept into a bygone era where art and life are inextricably entwined. This journey doesn't end with the past; it seamlessly bridges to the present, with digital reinterpretations and animated artworks by contemporary Japanese artists that breathe new life into age-old traditions. The seasonal shifts and natural elements so integral to Japanese art are dynamically represented, echoing the profound connection between Japan and its natural surroundings. The magic of these exhibitions at Atelier des Lumières lies in their ability to transport you into the very heart of the artworks. Here, technology dissolves the barriers between viewer and masterpiece, inviting you not just to see but to feel and live the art. Interactive elements beckon you to influence the visual narrative, while descriptive panels, guided tours, and multimedia enrich your understanding of the intricate stories behind each piece. This multi-sensory journey is a feast for the heart and soul, making it accessible and enchanting for visitors of all ages. Celebrating the incandescent brilliance of Vincent van Gogh and the timeless beauty of Japanese artistry, these exhibitions spark the imagination and linger in the memory, a testament to the transformative power of art in the digital age.

The Japanese Dream exhibition at the Atelier des Lumières transcends mere visual spectacle, offering a poignant and intentional exploration of Japan's rich cultural tapestry. Rooted deeply in tradition, every element of the exhibit reflects the profound philosophical and aesthetic principles that have shaped Japanese art for centuries. As you step into this immersive realm, the ukiyo-e woodblock prints of masters like Hokusai and Hiroshige unfold before you, their intricate lines and vibrant colors not merely enlarged but animated, each motion imbued with life and meaning. These works aren't just beautiful depictions; they are windows into the Japanese worldview, capturing the fleeting nature of existence—a concept known as "mono no aware," the awareness of the impermanence of all things and a gentle sadness at their passing. This cultural touchstone permeates the exhibit, rendering each piece not just a celebration of beauty, but a meditation on mortality and the ephemeral. The exhibition's ability to harmonize classical elements with modern digital interpretations speaks volumes about the Japanese reverence for continuity and adaptation. Traditional screens and scrolls, once used to tell stories of nature, festivals, and heroic battles, now merge seamlessly with contemporary digital art, creating a dialogue between past and present. This interplay underscores the Japanese principle of "wabi-sabi," the acceptance and appreciation of transience and imperfection. By juxtaposing historical and modern elements, the exhibit breathes new life into ancient practices, highlighting their relevance in today's world. Cultural background further enriches the meaning of the art, with each piece serving as a vessel of historical and philosophical significance. Whether it's the serene landscapes that evoke "shizen" (naturalness) or the detailed depictions of samurai that convey ideals of "bushido" (the way of the warrior), the exhibition offers glimpses into the soul of Japan. Seasonal changes portrayed in the art are more than just aesthetic choices; they are reflections of Japan's intrinsic bond with nature, its cycles, and its lessons. Moreover, the exhibition often delves into Japanese mythology and folklore, providing context that enhances the viewer's understanding and emotional connection. Majestic dragons, ethereal spirits, and legendary heroes come alive in the projected animations, each story layered with moral and philosophical teachings that have been passed down through generations.This profound connection to cultural heritage infuses the Japanese Dream exhibition with extraordinary depth. It's an experience designed to make you pause and reflect, to feel the weight of history and the lightness of fleeting moments. It invites you to engage not just with the art, but with the values and philosophies that birthed it—an invitation to find beauty in both the eternal and the ephemeral. By immersing visitors in this rich cultural narrative, the exhibition not only showcases the artistry of Japan but also offers a poignant reflection on life, impermanence, and the enduring beauty of the world's fleeting moments.

Counter Case 2: MAAT Lisbon Ernesto Neto Nosso Barco Tambor Terra

Nosso Barco Tambor Terra, *Our Boat Drum Earth, by* Ernesto Neto is a grand and immersive installation that reflects the dynamic intersection of cultures across continents. Curated by Jacopo Crivelli Visconti, this piece stands as one of Neto's largest sculptures to date, crafted over months of meticulous work and designed in harmony with MAAT's architectural space. It draws from the rich history of its surroundings, once a starting point for the caravels heading to the Americas. The installation utilizes materials and imagery representative of transatlantic voyages, such as sails, canvas, and ropes, to create unprecedented and expansive works that engage with the diverse dimensions of the venue. The primary material, chintz—a vibrantly printed cotton fabric popular in Brazil—was cut into strips and carefully crocheted by Neto's assistants using a refined technique developed in his Rio de Janeiro studio, ateliênave. This process resulted in interconnected cells that form the vast sculpture. The work was developed through freehand planning, various tests, and software-assisted adjustments to achieve a precise and adaptable final creation tailored to the exhibit space. Throughout the exhibition, the sculpture will be periodically activated with a musical program curated by musicians and groups from around the world, emphasizing the rhythms of diasporas. This convergence of rhythms and beats metaphorically counters the diversity of spoken languages, hinting at the potential for shared, non-verbal communication that fosters deeper, more authentic encounters. In line with Neto's vision of a collective and diverse creation, visitors are invited to play various drums embedded within the installation, enhancing the interactive experience. Neto's work transcends the physical, mental, spiritual, and ancestral realms, embracing both transparency and materiality. It fosters diversity through a relational, symbiotic, and mutualistic approach, honoring the tactile wisdom and sensory experience of touch. The installation challenges cultures that consider themselves superior to nature, advocating respect for fragility, acknowledgment of tensions, and recognition of limits. Neto's philosophy emphasizes care, attention, and love in interacting with the world, finding poetry in the silent song of our breath and the peaceful connection between heaven and earth.

The interconnectedness of the piece is particularly striking, with every chintz strip contributing to a larger narrative. Additionally, the cultural significance is notable, as the entire installation is infused with spices, which can be smelled throughout the exhibit, adding another layer of sensory engagement. Contemporary art, as embodied in Neto's work, mirrors the vibrancy of life, incorporating instruments like drums, caxixi, flutes, guitars, and maracas, and celebrating joy as a form of healing. It promotes social equilibrium, reflecting the belief that no entity is greater than nature and no person is superior to another. All contributions are essential to the harmony of Nosso Barco Tambor Terra acknowledging the vital roles of insects, bees, plants, trees, animals, fungi, lichens, and bacteria. Like a batucada ensemble, where each participant's expression adds to the collective rhythm, Neto's installation highlights the importance of unity and mutual respect. It fosters a balance where the collective brilliance and well-being enhance the experience of each participant. Through Nosso Barco Tambor Terra, Neto invites viewers to reconsider cultural intersections and the interwoven nature of our existence, creating an experience that is visually, audibly, and deeply reflective of humanity's and nature's interconnectedness.

Counter Case 3: Luminescence Paris

“Luminescence Paris,” has a dream-like atmosphere that suggests stepping into a parallel universe where familiar elements of the Parisian cityscape intermingle with fantastical features. Floating landmarks, distorted perspectives, and an unrealistically shifting sky contribute to this otherworldly setting. Imagery of light and shadow plays a significant role, with glowing elements and diffuse light imbuing the scene with a mystical glow, hinting at the city's inner life. Metamorphosis and transformation feature prominently, with objects merging human, architectural, and natural forms in unusual ways—street lamps morphing into willowy figures or buildings taking on organic, flowing structures, blurring the lines between the animate and inanimate. Accompanied with a live orchestra that creates sychronicities between the storyline and the light show, it is an incredible experience. Symbolism and subconscious imagery encourage viewers to ponder hidden meanings and the workings of the subconscious mind. Elements within the light show serve as symbols representing themes such as time, memory, desire, and the human psyche. Using light to create complex geometrical structures and through these surrealist techniques, “Luminescence Paris” evokes wonder and introspection, inviting viewers to explore the deeper layers of their consciousness and the mysteries of the world around them. It defines itself as art and technology in the service of heritage.

Film

Motion pictures are a unique form of multimedia. It is a means of portraying a message that provides the viewer with more that one stimulus to accept within their perceptual awareness. The time and detail it takes to string along and provide alignment to those medias should not go unnoticed in a well produced picture. There are several elements at play, the moving pictures themselves. This extends to the angle of direction that provides visual stimulus. The semantics of writing and screenplay that provide semiotic stimulus, the most glaring communication of meaning, though all elements offer meaning, others in far more subtle means. Finally, the backdrop, or in cases, frontal role of a soundtrack, offering subconscious direction for the film and audible stimulus for the audience. For these reasons, it is a powerful means of conveying meaning and a necessary point of study for the quest of understanding Afro Surrealism through
art.

Case 1: Get Out

Get Out is a film written and directed by Jordan Peele released in 2017 which uses common horror tropes to reveal truths about how pernicious racism is in the world. It explores the surrealist nature of eugenics and the interlaced connection between the Black body, mind, and soul as well as the peculiar and historic white interest in the trifectas’ existence. Now that protagonist Chris, played by Daniel Kaluuya, and his girlfriend, Rose have reached the parents milestone of dating, she invites him for a weekend getaway upstate. At first, Chris reads the family's overly accommodating behavior as nervous attempts to deal with their daughter's interracial relationship, but as the weekend progresses, a series of increasingly disturbing discoveries lead him to a eugenic truth that he never could have imagined. The film doesn’t walk back any of its condemnations by inserting a “white savior” or making overtures to pacifism and tolerance. The Armitage family’s use of black brains and bodies for their own eugenic fantasies showcases societies constant exploitation of black people for a white nefarious agenda and how the black community is and has been trapped by this for generations. At root, the Armitage family ritualistically lures black individuals into their property, aiming to make them comfortable until the point where they can trap these individuals and insert the brains of older and ill Armitage members for a longer and more able existence within the armor of a Black bodice. What transfers and remains in regards to the replacing of the brain and its

connections to the mind are revealed in a surreal nature throughout the film. It is clear somewhere underneath the white masters control exists a deeply buried and suffering Black identity. In this film, white society is a conscious purveyor of evil, and Chris, our leading protagonist, must remain alert to its benevolent racism in order to survive. *Get Out* frames violent black resistance as a necessity born of desperation and in doing so provide an array of surrealist content for study.

No, No, No

In the scene 'No No No', an illustrious, thought provoking, and emotionally drawing moment performed by actress Betty Gabriel, her character is one whom from the onset of the picture has experienced Chris' expected fate and undergone the Armitage's eugenics experiment. There is something, or arguably, someone that has infiltrated her body, brain, and mind and has primary cognitive control of her physical actions. This Armitage approaches Chris to smooth over a previous hiccup that, not for the first time, strikes Chris as curious and unusual, undermining his trust and comfort in the space, if there was ever any true comfort. This is polar to the Armitage's plan of making their victim comfortable before striking. The screenplay reads as follows:

GEORGINA
Hello.

CHRIS
Hi.

Georgina's voice is shaky and careful.

GEORGINA
I owe you an apology. I shouldn't be touching
things that don't belong to me.

CHRIS
Oh, no. It's cool. I was just confused.

GEORGINA
I lifted your cellular phone this
morning to wipe down the dresser
and it accidentally came undone,see?

CHRIS
Yeah, I-
GEORGINA
Rather than meddle with it
further, I left it that way. How foolish of me.

CHRIS

It’s fine. I wasn’t trynna snitch.

Georgia offers a confused look.
GORGINA
Snitch?

CHRIS
Rat you out.

GORGINA
Tattletale.

CHRIS
Yeah…

GORGINA
Oh don’t you worry about that. I can assure you
I don’t answer to anyone.

CHRIS
Right… All I know is sometimes if there are
too many white people I get nervous, you know.

Georgina's eyes get lost for a moment. There’s a pain behind her smile. A tear reluctantly falls from her eyes as she laughs.

GEORGINA
Oh no, no, no, no, no, no…
Aren’t you something. That's not my experience.
Not at all. The Armitages are so good to us;
They treat us like family.

Here the viewer sees a noticeable struggle between the original owner of Gorgina’s physical state and the infiltrator. Triggered by Chris' referral to the cultural knowledge and historical truth of the danger of a black person surrounded by whiteness, the original owner knowing what became of her trust and fate, is seemingly fighting to warn Chris about the evils at bay. The infiltrator, however, does their best to remain in control. It's arguable that the ‘No, no, no’, was not directed at Chris at all, rather an effort of the infiltrator to suppress the true spirit, keeping her at bay. This scene suggests many things philosophically and artistically. Philosophically, that once can’t fully remove the truth of a being or a spirit from their physical incarnation. Regardless to what degree a foreign spirit has come to possess one, its true nature is always lying underneath, never fully removed from its physical demeanor. Artistically, it offers a hierarchical perspective of processing the film. One would have to watch until the complete ending, and at least once over again to even catch the inner turmoil and dual energies fighting in one physical manifestation. An extremely surrealist concept to capture visually. Further, the soundtrack in the background of the moment offers another lens to view the foreshadowing horror from, telling the viewer subconsciously of the eerie nature of the science at hand.

Get Out of Here

In this scene, Chris is asked a question on how being African American shaped him in this modern day and age. Untrustigly offering the crowd an I don't know and differing to a fellow black man in the space, Chris asks Andre Logan King, played by LaKeith Stanfield, to speak on the question. Unhappy with a culturally absent response Chris sneakily attempts to grab a picture of this man he is now regarding a fraud. Maybe to send to like minded individuals so he can share in his experience of white suffocated Blackness. Upon taking a flash image of Andre, Chris experiences an outburst of emotion from him. There is an immediate change in Andre's eyes, which become faded, and demeanor, which becomes frozen, then suddenly aware. What at first viewing seems to be an attack, Andre grabs Chris aggressively whilst continually repeating for him to 'Get out of here'. The screenplay goes as follows:

```
                    HIROKI
          Do you find that being African

         American has more advantages or
          disadvantages in the modern world?

Chris pans the crowd who all give him their undivided
attention. The silence is long. Chris sighs. He looks for
Rose. She is off talking to someone.

                    CHRIS
          Yeah, I don't know, man.

They all smile like hungry vampires. Chris is very
uncomfortable with this unprovoked group interrogation. Andre/
Logan and Phil approach.

                    CHRIS (CONT'D)
          That's actually a great question.

         Logan! They were asking me about
          the African American experience.
          Maybe you could take this one.

Andre/Logan is a little caught off guard but dives in.

                    ANDRE/LOGAN
          My life as an African American has

         been, for the most part, very
          good. It's hard to be too specific
          as I haven't much desired to leave
          the house in a while.

The crowd chuckles. Chris takes out his phone.

                    PHIL
```

We've become homebodies...

ANDRE/LOGAN
(To Phil)

But recently, even when you go to the city, I've just had no interest.

(To the group)
The chores are my sanctu--

With the attention on Andre/Logan, Chris subtly backs away from the conversation. He raises his phone toward Andre/Logan and the group and snaps a picture. The FLASH POPS.

CHRIS Shit.
Everyone turns to Chris. Andre/Logan steps forward and looks at Chris oddly; His head cocks a little and his peaceful expression drifts slowly to maddened horror. Some of the party guests gasp.

PHIL Logan?
Andre/Logan drops his glass and stumbles towards Chris. Chris backs up, but Andre is already up in his space.

ANDRE
Get out.

Andre/Logan's voice is higher and scratchy, like it was in the first scene.

CHRIS
Hey, man, I'm sorry, I--

Andre/Logan grabs Chris by the shoulders and screams shrilly. Blood trickles out of his nose.

ANDRE
GET THE FUCK OUT OF HERE!!!!

Phil and Jeremy grab Andre. They have to pry Andre/Logan's grip off of Chris. When they do Andre/Logan screams bloodcurdlingly. It takes all their strength to bring him into the house. Missy and Dean follow.

INT. LIVING ROOM - AFTERNOON

Rose sits on the couch. She's been crying. Chris comforts her but is clearly traumatized. A few other concerned guests mill around. Dean enters everyone gives him their attention.

ROSE
What the Hell was that?

DEAN
It was a seizure.

ROSE
A seizure?

DEAN
Yes. Logan's okay. Missy's with

him now. Are you okay Chris?

CHRIS

Yeah. Why did he come at me like

that?

ROSE
Yeah seizures don't make people

attack people, I'm sorry.

DEAN
It was an abnormal manifestation

but yes, actually, sometimes they do. The flash on your phone must have triggered it.

Andre/Logan enters with stands with Missy and Phil to a smattering of concerned applause.

63.

He addresses a group in his lower pitched "Logan" voice.

ANDRE/LOGAN
Well, I do believe I owe you all

an apology.

The group grumbles.

MISSY
We're just glad you're feeling

yourself again.

ANDRE/LOGAN
Well yes I am. It's quite like

being trapped in a dark room and watching my experiences through a window. Thank God you and Dean were here to calm me down.

DEAN
It's a simple glitch of the brain.

Nothing to be afraid of.

ANDRE/LOGAN
I know I scared you all quite a

bit.. especially you Chris.

CHRIS
No, I'm sorry about the flash. I

didn't know.

ANDRE/LOGAN
Of course. How could you have?

PHIL
(to Andre/Logan)

You shouldn't have been drinking either.

The group chuckles.

ANDRE/LOGAN
As I said I'm feeling much better

now, but you'll all have to
proceed without the aid of my
marvellous wit; the whole thing
has left me a quite a bit
exhausted.

DEAN
Of course.

ANDRE/LOGAN
It was nice meeting you.

CHRIS
Yeah, you too.

Chris is skeptical. Missy shows Phil and Logan out. Andre and Phil leave.

What striking about this scene is this recurring hierarchy of perceptual understanding of the happenstance at hand. It seems to offer an inverted meaning once studied closer. What first seems like an attack on Chris can later be identified as a passionate warning. The dual meaning of 'Get out' here can be misunderstood as a desire for Chris to leave after the offense of the unwanted photograph, or a re-understood notion of the directions to safety. Again, a trigger can be identified with the flash of the camera igniting the true persona of Andre underneath the infiltration of Logan. There is a change within tone and demeanor between the two personas. The surrealist nature of the struggle between identity and the lost reality in the scene is an interesting point of study.

The Sunken Place

After getting acquainted with his girlfriend, Rose's parents, he learns that her mother, Missy, is a hypnosis therapist. Missy notices that Chris is a smoker, and tells him she has the ability to make him quit. One night after sneaking a cigarette outside, Chris is met by Missy when he returns inside who offers him her hypnotic treatment. Initially reluctant, Chris agrees out of curiosity. Missy sits him down and begins stirring her tea, making an oscillating sound with the spoon grazing the rim of the cup over and over again. At the same time, she is digging into Chris' past, particularly his darkest memory: the death of his mother. As she continues to stir, Chris slowly becomes paralyzed, stuck in his seat and uncontrollably crying as he relives his devastating childhood. Just as he realizes he can't move, Missy taps the spoon on the cup which sends Chris into a dark and empty void, the Sunken Place. The screenplay reads as follows:

CHRIS (CONT'D)
So, how does this work? Are you
going to swing a pocket watch in
front of my face?

MISSY
You watch a lot of Television.

Now, you are feeling very sleeepy...

They share a smile.

MISSY (CONT'D)
We do use focal points sometimes,

but just about any object or simple motion can guide someone to a state of heightened suggestibility.

CHRIS
Heightened suggestibility. Okay,

where do we start?

MISSY
Your childhood.

CHRIS
Yeah, my memory sucks.

TING TING. TING TING.

MISSY
Wounds get locked in your heart

and they fester and grow into ugly little things like depression and addiction. But, they are all in there somewhere. All we need to do is find the key.

TING TING. TING TING.
The world around Chris slowly goes out of focus.

CHRIS
I guess if it makes me quit...

Wait... Has it started--?

MISSY
--we're going to go back to a

place that might be uncomfortable for you. Your Mother's death to be specific. Were you there when she was hit?

CHRIS
I was home. I was watching TV.

MISSY
Let's go back there. Hear this

place. Let the vibrations rush run through your body and ears. Hear it... Find it... Tell me when you find it.

The sound of RAIN AGAINST a WINDOW slowly fades up along with the MUFFLED sound of a SITCOM ON TELEVISION.

CHRIS
Okay... Yeah, I found it.

TING TING. TING TING.

MISSY
Good. How did you find out she

died?

CHRIS
I knew it. She was never late

after work. When she didn't come home, I just knew something was wrong.

MISSY
Good. Now touch. Feel your

surroundings. Feel every part of your body and what you touched. Feel it. Find it... Tell me when you find it...

FLASHBACK - INT. SMALL APARTMENT. NIGHT

Close on 11 year old Chris' hands scratches the bed post nervously.

MISSY (V.O.)
Tell me when you find it.

CHRIS (V.O.)
I found it.

His toes brush the carpet as his dangling legs swing off the side of his bed.

38.
TING TING. TING TING.
PRESENT DAY - INT. MISSY'S OFFICE. - NIGHT

Chris' feet try to swing but are too long. He scratches the arm of the chair in Missy's office.

MISSY
You said 'you knew something was

wrong.' What did you do?

CHRIS
Nothing.

MISSY
Nothing?

CHRIS
I just sat there. Watching TV.

MISSY
You didn't call someone? Your Aunt

or the police?

No.
CHRIS

MISSY
Why not?

CHRIS
I don't know. I thought if I did,

it would make it real.

MISSY
Next is smell and taste. Breathe

in and let the scent fill your
nose. Smell that place. Taste it.
Find it.

Chris is getting emotional. He breathes deep through his nose.
FLASH BACK - INT. SMALL APARTMENT KITCHEN - NIGHT
Young Chris finishes inhaling. The rain hits the window sill.

MISSY (V.O.)
Tell me. Tell me when you find it.

Young Chris takes sip of a juice box.
PRESENT DAY - INT. MISSY'S OFFICE. NIGHT
26 year old Chris sips from an invisible straw.

39.

CHRIS
I found it.

TING TING. TING TING.

MISSY
Good. Now lastly, you must see it.

Let the light flood into your
eyes. Every color, every detail.
See it. See it. Find it.

Chris' eyelids flutter. He continues to scratch the armchair.
TING TING. TING TING
FLASHBACK - INT. SMALL APARTMENT - NIGHT

11-year-old Chris scratches through the wood on his bed, splintering the wood. He watches TV from his bed next to some action figures.

MISSY (V.O.)
Tell me when--

11-year-old Chris nods.
TING TING. TING TING.
PRESENT DAY - INT. MISSY'S OFFICE. NIGHT
Chris nods and cries.

CHRIS
--Found it.

MISSY
(realizing)

You think it was your fault.
Chris nods.

TING TING. TING TING.

MISSY (CONT'D)
I want you to feel that fear

again, Chris.

CHRIS
I don't want to.

MISSY
It's okay. I'm here.

Chris trembles anxiously.

40.

MISSY (CONT'D)

Are you afraid now? Paralyzed like

that day?
He nods. Her empathetic expression turns into a sick smile.

MISSY (CONT'D)
Good. Now sink into the floor.

CHRIS Wait--
MISSY
Sink! Now!

TING TING...
Chris' hand has compulsively scratched open the arm of the chair. His hand stops. His mouth drops and eyes open, frozen.

FLASHBACK - INT. SMALL APARTMENT - NIGHT
...TING TING.
Suddenly, 11-year-old Chris falls through the bed and floor.
END FLASHBACK.

INT. DARKNESS

Terror. Chris, 26 again, breathes fast but falls in slow motion though darkness as if through water.

TING TING. TING TING.

He flails towards a pitch black abyss. He's illuminated by the fading blue flicker of a large downward facing TV-like screen. On it Missy sits Speaking to him and clinking her teacup.

Missy's voice is everywhere.

MISSY
Good. Good. Sink. Sink.

PRESENT DAY - INT. MISSY'S OFFICE. NIGHT

Chris' body sits in his chair motionless. He can't move. His eyes are wide open, staring strait at Missy.

41.
INT. DARKNESS

Chris continues to slowly fall backwards. Missy approaches on the screen above him. It shows what his eyes are seeing.

CHRIS
No! NO!!! I'm done! Bring me back!

Please!!!!
There is no response. Chris cries. Eventually he slows down and comes to a stop. He lands feet first on a soft ground. This place sounds like it's crawling with insects. He looks up. He can still see the screen above but it is far away, like the mouth of a deep and expansive well.

CHRIS (CONT'D)
Mrs. Armitage!!!

On the screen, Missy stands. She walks towards Chris' body and looks down at him through his own eyes.

MISSY
Now you are in the Sunken Place.

Missy reaches towards the screen and shuts his eyelids. The abyss goes almost completely dark. Now he's alone in the dark. He cries in terror.

Chris hears a DEEP HULKING BREATHING in the darkness.

CHRIS
(whispering)

Something's down here...
No response.

CHRIS (CONT'D)
(whispering)

Bring me back. Bring me back.
Bring me back. Bring me back...

In the darkness, the SOUND OF HOOVES CRUNCHING ON SOFT GROUND approaches.

THUNK THUNK. THUNK THUNK.

CHRIS (CONT'D)
Bring me back. Bring me back.

Bring me back.
The sounds get louder and louder.

THUNK THUNK. THUNK THUNK.
An antlered thing emerges from the shadow. It's head is that of a deer, but with the flesh stripped off and with mostly its skull exposed.

No!
CHRIS (CONT'D)

Its eyes glow and flicker faint blue in its sockets. It MOANS A WRONG SOUNDING MOAN; in hateful anguish. It charges Chris...

THUNK THUNK. THUNK THUNK. THUNK THUNK.
The bloody deer impales Chris on its antlers. They both MOAN.

INT. ROSE'S BEDROOM - DAWN

Chris wakes up with a start in Rose's bed sweaty and heaving. He's alone and confused. Bad dream? Headache.

The best way to describe this surreal scene is that Chris is sinking into his own mind. His body feels like it is falling without ever reaching a ground surface. But as he looks up, he can see through his eyes still in the outside world, but the image grows smaller and smaller. He has zero control over his body at this point and can only observe what his eyes can see. That is, until Missy closes his eyelids. Then Chris is emerged in utter darkness without the slightest clue of how to get out. At this point, the viewer is able to understand the other side of the coin of awareness that the other infiltrated beings are experiencing. Initially, it appears that the Sunken Place is simply a therapeutic method that allows for the unconscious part of a person's mind to alter certain habits or mental illnesses. This seems evident to Chris because once he wakes up after being in the Sunken Place, he no longer has the urge to smoke. However, it's soon revealed that the Sunken Place is an evil hypnotic trick the Armitage family uses to essentially transfer someone else's consciousness into another body, specifically, into the body of a Black person. This is where Jordan Peele's creativity and cultural theme come into play. Throughout the film, Chris goes back and forth being stuck in the Sunken Place. Ultimately, though, he gets out. However, there are other characters that are stuck in the Sunken Place, before Chris even came into the picture. This scene is one that handles the surrealist aspects of both space and time in regard to consciousness. It opens up the philosophical notion of the immaterial realm in a physical representation. Offering the eerie notion that with enough suppression, training or coding of the mind, one can fall into immaterial stagnation, being trapped in the limitations of a broken spiritual realm to the degree that it affects the actions and consciousness of the waking physical. Pain and suffering, here, are obvious triggers for Chris' descent into the Sunken place, as are false notions of security and belonging on the aggressors part. An easy parallel can be made within this scene and the historic, systemic, generational, and emotional truth of enforced colonization, imperialism, and suffering induced control. Regardless, in the end, Chris manages to escape the chaos, preserve his identity, and once again find asylum within his community,

Counter Case 1: Midsommar

A nice classical surrealist film that could be used as a comparative pair to *Get Out* is *Midsommar*. Directed by Ari Aster, *Midsommar* follows the unsettling journey of Dani, played by Florence Pugh, who doesn't see her boyfriend Christian's toxic behavior until they take a surprise trip to Sweden with friends. Aster's creative vision craftily uses foreshadowing and sharp commentary to build a unique horror movie. He leans heavily into the folk horror genre, which often uses remote settings and old-school, pagan traditions to provoke fear. The monsters here aren't typically supernatural; instead, they're just regular people committing horrifying acts in the name of their beliefs. *Midsommar* is filled with bizarre and inexplicable events, all while touching on the theme of grief. Its real strength lies in how it blends the setting and plot with the much more relatable horror of a toxic relationship. On the surface, it's about Dani trying to cope with her loss on a trip with her boyfriend and his friends. But in reality, it's more about the collapse of their relationship. Instead of supporting each other, Dani and Christian drift apart, highlighted by Christian's failure to be a good partner, culminating in a dramatic and brutal ending. As it turns out, the group, which includes two other travelers, Simon and Connie, unwittingly becomes part of a ritual cleansing of unwanted elements from the commune, leading to their sacrificial deaths. Pelle, who brought them here, had hidden intentions, manipulating them and seducing Dani into the cult. The ritual happens every ninety years and includes horrific acts like stuffing people with straw or burning them alive. The visitors are kept disoriented by drugs in their food and drink and the village's location in the far north, where the sun never sets in the summer, making it hard to keep track of time. Meanwhile, the commune prepares to make Dani the new May Queen, welcoming her as one of their own. This is part of their plan to keep the cult strong by bringing in new members. To fully embrace her new life, Dani must let go of her past, including her toxic relationship with Christian. And so, amid strange ceremonies and perpetual daylight, Dani finds a twisted kind of rebirth and liberation.

ENDING

STEN (CONT'D)
And now, for the ninth offering, it is traditional that our fair Queen shall choose between a pre-selected newblood and a specially ordained Hårgan…

Sten turns to an Elder standing beside a large BALL CAGE (as generally used in bingo) at the end of the platform. The cage holds about a hundred WOODEN BALLS (the size of ping- pong balls) with a different RUNIC NAME carved into each.

The Man rotates the ball cage, which then dispenses a single BALL. The man holds up the ball and reads the name aloud:

BALL MAN
Dag.

STEN
Honorable Dag! Please step forward.

DAG, a man in his late 50s, looks like he just won the lottery. He takes a step forward, beaming with pride.

STEN (CONT'D)
And Christian Hughes.

A Hårgan man now wheels Christian, whose eyes are locked wide, away from the base of the stage. He positions Christian beside Dag to also be facing the stage. Christian is shocked at the sight of Dani.

STEN (CONT'D) (to Dani)
These are your candidates for the ninth and final offering. We patiently await your verdict.

Christian tries to scream, but this only results in muffled moans. His eyes BEG Dani for mercy. *Her* eyes are GLASS.

The community waits as Dani makes her silent deliberation.

Dani's EYES settle fixedly on CHRISTIAN. A wave of intense EMOTION suddenly animates Dani's face. Sadness, anger, love, heartbreak... These feelings are finally wrestled down, and her expression becomes BLANK again. Her EYES, still trained on Christian, have HARDENED. They narrow pointedly to suggest that she's made her decision. Sten understands.

STEN (CONT'D) (to the crowd)
The honor has been bestowed on Christian Hughes, our ninth and most sacred offering!

Christian's muffled screams now become hysterical. He has turned blue in the face. Dani's gaze remains steely and absent.

EXT. FIELD - EVENING

[...]

Peripherally, other bodies are being carted toward the house.

We continue to track ahead, following Mark's cart INTO the SACRED HOUSE...

INT. SACRED HOUSE - CONTINUOUS The interior is completely adorned in greenery. An impossibly lush mausoleum. In the center is a PLATFORM made of hay. Connie's corpse is rested against one wall. Mark's is seated against the opposite wall.

Beyond them, to either side, are the TWO ELDER TREE-CORPSES that were standing upright in the crowd. The male body is surrounded by his most precious belongings (jewelry, books, etc.). The dead female elder is also surrounded by her most prized possessions.

Beyond them, at the far end of the temple, is…

JOSH'S BODY, which is covered in dirt and soil. His eyes and nostrils are clogged with earth. His face is locked into a gagged scream, his mouth utterly stuffed with paper (from the Rubi Radr). Stacks of books rest on his lap (and atop those, his smartphone stands on its side, facing outward). And beside Josh...

SIMON'S CORPSE. He is now in the same dress as the rest of the corpses, but the eyes are still replaced by bright flowers.

EXT. BOOKBINDING HOUSE - SAME TIME

We are PUSHING TOWARD the bookbinding house, whose doors are open. To the side of it, Ulf and Ingemar are being embraced passionately by several members of the community.

INT. BOOK-BINDING ROOM - SAME TIME

A room that is typically used for book-binding. Its walls are lined with collector's editions of books.

A DEAD BEAR (seen earlier, alive and caged) lies on the island table. A deep INCISION has been drawn from the animal's neck to its groin. Two Hårgan Labourers pull out the bear's INNARDS. After scooping out the majority of its guts, they pile the waste into a bucket. Then, with the assistance of two well-built Hårgan men, the Labourers endeavor to lift CHRISTIAN's paralyzed body. Christian is fitted into the bear's hollowed out carcass. They start by inserting his limp legs into the bear's legs.

INT. SACRED HOUSE - MINUTES LATER

Humming and music has started very quietly outside.

Christian has been secured into the giant bear carcass. The incision (from its groin to its neck) has been SEWN UP. The bear's JAW has been removed, creating a gaping HOLE (down to its upper chest) through which Christian's FACE is visible.

Five Hårgan labourers plant the bear carcass in the CENTER of the hay platform. Its back rests against a hay pile. Christian is still unable to move or speak. His muffled screams persist.

A man dressed as "Vi´dorr" (god of vengeance) stands before Christian. He holds the *Rubi Radr* in his hands.

VI´DORR (in Swedish)

Mighty and dreadful beast. With you, we purge our most unholy Affekts. We banish you now to the deepest recesses, where you may reflect on your wickedness.

Ingemar and Ulf are now seated on haystacks. They are also surrounded by their most prized belongings. Mats stands before Ingemar, who smiles widely. He pours a thick, sappy LIQUID into Ingemar's mouth.

MATS (in Swedish)
Drink from the yew tree. Feel no fear.

Mats moves to Ulf. He pours the liquid into his mouth as well.

MATS (CONT'D) (in Swedish)
Drink from the yew tree. Feel no pain.

Mats leaves the house. Now, THREE HÅRGAN MEN enter with FLAMING TORCHES. The music begins to rise outside, including the wordless, microtonal SINGING we've come to recognize. The men approach Christian, whose "screaming" has become horribly frenzied.

The men move to different sides of the hay platform. They form a TRIANGLE. Simultaneously, they touch their torches to the hay - igniting a FIRE.

EXT. FIELD - SAME TIME

The torch-men exit the house. Inside, the fire has begun to spread along the platform.

The music rises as the fire picks up. The SINGING, which wavers in trembling anticipation, has not yet found harmony.

Dani watches this with dissociated eyes. She stands tensely in the field, eyes locked on the fire. Behind her, all of Hårga is enraptured.

INT. SACRED HOUSE - SAME TIME

The fire has grown considerably. Inside the bear, Christian is now being steam-boiled in the animal's fluids. The bear's FUR begins to catch fire. Before long, the whole animal is swallowed in the blaze. Christian's wretched face becomes invisible behind the flames. Ulf and Ingemar (still smiling) watch this with detached fascination.

The fire has now spread to other piles of hay. It has begun to crawl up the walls of the house. Ulf is suddenly consumed by flames. He SCREAMS!

EXT. FIELD - SAME TIME

Ulf's screams are heard from the Sacred House. Suddenly, every member of the Hårgan community (who is *not* singing) begins to SCREAM as well. Feeling Ulf's pain, they emit a horrible chorus of wails. When Ulf's screams die down, so do theirs.

Meanwhile, Ruben has been given paper to PAINT on. Two elders encourage him.

DANI, watching the burning house with fraught eyes, is suddenly met with a wave of conflicting emotions. Her expression curdles into one of sheer HORROR and DISGUST. Then it becomes one of deep SORROW and SHAME. Her eyes well with tears. The singing has now HARMONIZED and has risen to an insane, operatic pitch.

We cut to an immense WIDE. Dani's back is in the f.g. and the burning house is in the b.g. Overcome, Dani buries her face in her hands. Breaking into gentle sobs, she begins to walk aimlessly to the side. We TRACK alongside her, keeping her centered. She is circling the house, pulling at her hair and face in increasing anguish. She is WEEPING now, and the house (ever-present in the b.g.) has become ENGULFED in the raging flames.

Dani begins MOANING and SCREAMING. Her howls almost harmonize with the singing in the b.g. The fire ROARS and CRACKLES in the distance. It's apocalyptic.

Soon it's uncertain whether Dani is crying or LAUGHING. Her legs become weak and she collapses to her knees. Four Hårgans (one of them being Pelle) run into the scene, carrying a LARGE CHAIR - Dani's throne.

The Hårgans lift Dani by the arms and SEAT her in the throne. They then HOIST the chair into the air.

On the upward LIFT, we cut to a tight CLOSE-UP of Dani's face. She is being carried forward. Her expression, which begins as one of great distress, slowly starts to TURN. Her agony subsides into sudden CONFUSION. *What's happening? Where am I? I'm on this chair, being carried!* Her expression goes from FEAR to EXCITEMENT to CONFUSION again. She suddenly lets out an abrupt LAUGH (which we can't hear over the music and the now-deafening FIRE). Dani is now being taken over by an invading sense of pride and contentment. This soon evolves into a manic exhilaration. Dani BEAMS. She has been embraced by a new family. She is Queen. She is not alone.

A SMILE finally breaks onto Dani's face. (For some, this smile might recall the photo of Dani in her parent's bedroom at the beginning of the film.) She has surrendered to a joy known only by the insane. She has lost herself completely, and she is finally free. It is horrible and it is beautiful.
FADE TO BLACK.

If, after reading this scene, one feels confused, don't worry; watching it evokes almost the same level of bewilderment. In the climactic scene of "Midsommar," the film reaches a haunting peak, blending horror with emotional catharsis. The introduction of the ninth offering by Ättestupa cult leader Sten sees Dani faced with choosing between two sacrificial candidates—Christian, her boyfriend, and Dag, an elder Hårgan. This moment is drenched in ritualistic symbolism, with the ball cage functioning as a perverse lottery that selects Dag, underscoring the theme of fate intertwined with the community's traditions. The camera captures Dani's intense emotional storm—love, betrayal, anger, and sorrow—culminating in her choice of Christian. This decisive act marks Christian as the ultimate sacrificial offering, symbolizing Dani's severance from her past. The scene then plunges into a macabre spectacle as Christian, paralyzed and voiceless, is encased within a hollowed-out bear, transforming him into a grotesque sacrificial beast. The bear suit merges pagan symbolism with human brutality, emphasizing the ritual's primal essence. The setting of the sacred house, flush with greenery and adorned corpses, serves as a sanctified space blending life, death, and nature. As torchbearers ignite the hay platform, Christian's muffled screams rise, blending with the communal empathy of the Hårgan community's synchronized wails. This shared anguish highlights the deep bond among cult members—a unity in suffering and ecstasy. Amid this collective catharsis, Dani's emotional turmoil is palpable. Her expressions oscillate between horror and sorrow, gradually transitioning to an eerie acceptance. Her primal wailing merges into inexplicable laughter, culminating in a manic grin of liberation and belonging.

Dani's final transformation is captured as the Hårgans elevate her onto a throne, symbolizing her rise to a position of honor within the community. Her initial grief and isolation give way to a disturbing sense of pride and manic exhilaration. This hauntingly serene acceptance signifies Dani's rebirth, as she fully embraces her new identity within the cult. The final image of Dani's radiant smile, amid the apocalyptic flames, encapsulates the film's paradoxical exploration of belonging, grief, and transformation. This scene evokes both horror and a twisted sense of fulfillment, reflecting the darker facets of human nature and the primal desire for connection. Dani's final smile, amidst a backdrop of apocalyptic fire, captures the scene's paradoxical essence. It's both horrifying and serene, representing her complete immersion into this new, liberated identity—a horrifyingly idyllic form of acceptance and joy. This scene intertwines macabre horror with deep emotional themes, creating a visceral and hauntingly surreal atmosphere. Dani's final acceptance of her role within the Hårgan community encapsulates the film's exploration of belonging, grief, and transformation. The disturbing beauty lies in its ability to evoke both revulsion and an unsettling sense of satisfaction, reflecting the darker aspects of human nature, and the primal need for connection and identity. In this narrative, a person initially lured into an environment that seemed harmless but ultimately revealed its cultish, violent nature finds a way to embrace the chaos and allows it to transform her identity, rather than seeking escape.

Case 2: *Moonlight*

Moonlight is a film directed by Barry Jenkins that explores the complex relationship between black men, culture, and sexuality. Sexuality being a defining factor in identity and subjective reality, it has the opportunity to be a key source of surreal content as it relates to innate vulnerability, desire, and self knowledge. *Moonlight* follows Chiron, played by younger Ashton Sanders and older Trevante Rhodes, an African American living in a rough neighborhood of Miami. Bullied at an early age and seemingly outcast, Chiron had good knowledge that he doesn't fit in because of his sexuality. He hardly spoke to peers or anyone for that matter, has no group of friends, and has a deteriorating home life when his mother descends into intense drug use. Chiron finds refuge in a man named Juan, a drug dealer played incredibly by Mahershala Ali who has profound and lasting effects on the trajectory of this young boy's life. The first section of the film, titled "i. Little", is the strongest part of the film from start to finish. A large part of this is from the performance of drug dealer Juan. Juan is the father figure that Chiron never had. Juan comes from a place of genuinity in regards to Chiron and cares for and looks after the young protagonist, as he and his girlfriend give him a place to sleep at night when circumstances prevent him from going to his real home. He first finds Chiron holed up in an abandoned building, as he had just run away from a group of violent kids. From the moment they meet, Juan is incredibly patient and caring for Chiron. It begs the question, what does Juan see in Chiron? Why is he so determined to look after this kid? Juan at face value is a drug dealer and despite his occupation, he defies the stereotype and image most would hold against him. Within this context, the next surrealist scenes should be regarded.

WRESTLING

Little walking alone along this side street.
Kicking rocks, grabbing the branches of small trees, listless when he hears...

VOICE (O.S.)

Hey Little!

From a ways off that came, Little looking back, into the sun. Can't quite make him out at first but squinting to see him better, a bit of familiarity: it's the kid who just saved his ass.
Little waiting as the kid hurries to catch up. He's a bit fucked up, shirt torn, a scratch along the bridge of his nose.

KID Wassup man.

LITTLE Hey Kevin.

KEVIN (a facsimile of Little but stronger, more broken in).

KEVIN Why'd you leave?

LITTLE I'on't know.

Kevin falls into step, the boys walking together now.

KEVIN

Yeah, it get borin' after a while, I guess.

The boys continue on, Little looking to his new friend every now and then, checking him.

KEVIN(at Little's looks)

What?

Kevin reaches for his own face now, hand to his chin:

KEVIN Is it bleedin'?

Kevin turns his head just so, invites Little to inspect. Little reaches over, touches Kevin gently at the neck, just below his ear.
Little brings this walking, the pavement. Small glances his hand back to himself without a word, just arms swinging, the sound of their feet along
from one to the other.

Kevin smiles:

What?

LITTLE

KEVIN You funny, man.

LITTLE Why you say that?

KEVIN

You just is, that's all.

Again this walking, lack of words, just their arms swinging, movement.
Up ahead, the school they've been walking beside all this time gives way to a field. They're headed right for it.
Kevin taps Little, gestures.
Kevin and Little standing before one another in this clearing, face to face, like ancient samurai before a contest.

KEVIN
Why you always letting people pick on you man.
LITTLE
What you mean?
KEVIN
You always letting 'em pick on you.
LITTLE
So? What I gotta do?
KEVIN
All you gotta do is show these niggas you ain't soft.
LITTLE
But, I *ain't* soft.
KEVIN
I know man, *I* know. But... (pauses for effect)
...don't mean nothin' if *they* don't know.

No response from Little, maybe he gets it, maybe he doesn't. No matter....

KEVIN
Come on....

Kevin grabs him, places one arm across Little's shoulder, the other around his waist, rests his head in Little's chest.

KEVIN
...let's wrestle.

Little limply obliging, visually, physically passive.

KEVIN
Come on man, you want these fools to pick on you every day?

That gets to Little, the boy locking on, muscles tensing: they're wrestling.
This is anthropology, anatomical vignettes, the struggle of these two boys isolated to the simple, incomplete movements of partially glimpsed bodies.
These are children. Sexuality is absent these images and yet, the hints of something sensual, fleeting in its appearances; Kevin's cheek wedged close to Little's neck, blades of grass sticking to their skin.
The boys on the ground, turning and rolling and laughing, huffing through exhausted breaths.
Slowly, their voices going mute, the only sound the movement of their bodies against each other, against the grass.
Physical exhaustion. The boys lie flat.
Beat.
Both Little and Kevin on their backs, looking skyward, chests heaving from the exertion. Kevin pops tall to his feet, fixing his mottled shirt.

KEVIN
See Chiron, I knew you wasn't soft.

Kevin looking back at Little, looking down at him lying there, Little fully returning his gaze, these fourteen pages the first time he's looked at anyone thus.

The wrestling scene is a very beautiful scene to look at, and one that invokes a sense of intimacy and vividness with Chiron's, 'Little's' childhood friend Kevin. There's a conveyed emotion of closeness in the wrestling scene that signifies a deeper sexual awakening. This is very evident in the closeups of Chiron and his friend laying on the ground and looking up at the sky. There are a couple of closeups that focus on their breathing, mimicking movies that depict couples laying in bed. Far from the innocent truth of the boyish personas enjoying a little bit of fun in each other, but tied in the lens of vulnerability, desperateness, and bare truth. Jenkins never hits the audience over the head with these moments, but instead opts for a surreptitious tone. Therein lies the surrealist nature to the film, tied in Afro-American truth and stigmatizations born from the after effects of colonization and imperialism. Acceptance of a suppressed reality and existence in a warped reality outside of personal truth and sexual honesty.

SWIMMING

One of the most important scenes in the film comes when Juan teaches Chiron how to swim. The scene is outstanding visually as it perfectly encapsulates the life that Chiron is about to have. If he doesn't learn how to ride out the incoming waves, it will swallow him up whole and consume him. He must learn how to swim in order to face the waves or challenges that are about to come his way. More importantly, crucial dialogue occurs right after this. Juan turns to Chiron and tells him "at some point you got to decide for yourself who you're going to be". It's a powerful question that helps shape the entire film. Demarking the true nature of the film as an exploration of truth, identity, and the illusions of who one is not. Who is Chiron going to be when he grows up? Will he carve his own path or merely mimic those around him? The screenplay reads as follows:

Juan moving away, heading toward the surf. Little following, hurrying to catch up, literally taking hold of Juan's shirt as they move...
INTO THE OCEAN
...away from shore, slow, awkward steps, feet in sand.
And Little so small, the water rising quickly.
Juan still moving away from shore, notices Little no longer beside him. Looks back, the boy a few meters behind.
Little looking to Juan and back to the shore behind him, gauging the distance between the two.
The look on Juan's face: *Well*?
Little diving into the water before him, face down, arms flailing, fighting the water as much as he's moving *through* it.
Juan steadying himself, buttresses himself against the current as he reels Little in. The boy clings to him, gasping for air, spitting out salt water.
JUAN
Hey hey hey, I got you lil' man, I got you, *calmate, calmate*.
It's movie magic but they're a good ways out now, thirty,forty yards from shore.
The water's not so deep out here, Juan standing. Little is far out beyond his height however, Juan supporting him, holding him out at arms length.
JUAN You alright?
A nod from Little as he wipes saltwater from his eyes.
JUAN
Good, good. Now... you gotta help yourself now, gotta move your legs, keep yourself up.
Juan watching as Little flails his legs beneath the surface. Juan laughs.
JUAN
Nah, not like a chicken, you gotta move 'em side to side like, like you making waves with your feet.
Juan going into a tread, very smooth, like someone raised in the water, born at its edge.
Little taking it to heart, does a passable job of treading.
JUAN Not bad, not bad.
(and)
Bet you ain't know you could float, huh?
Juan taking a hand and placing it under Little's legs, gently gesturing him onto his back:

JUAN
Trust me, I got you.

Little laid flat atop the surface now, bobbing with the waves.

JUAN
Now just relax, alright, *relax.*

Little complying -- Little *floating*, the look on his face pure joy. For once, a kid.

JUAN See?

Juan slowly, gently, easing his grasp, letting Little go

JUAN
Relax now, stay relaxed. See?

Juan circling as Little continues to bob with the surface, swimming around Little for this last part, is circling him.

JUAN
You ready to learn how to swim?

LITTLE
Yeah.

Juan standing again, gets his arms under Little and turns the boy face down in a swimming position.

JUAN
Alright, you saw me swimming,
right?

Nod from Little.

JUAN
Okay, do like I did, don't put your head under water. And your arms, try and do 'em like I did mine.

Little mimicking Juan's swimming as Juan holds him aloft, Juan holding him fully in place for this practice.

JUAN
Smoother, more easy'like.

Little settling noticeably, gradually. It's a stretch but... looks passable, like maybe he *could*.

Juan turning him back upright, Little going back to his awkward treading.

JUAN Alright lil' man.
I think you ready.

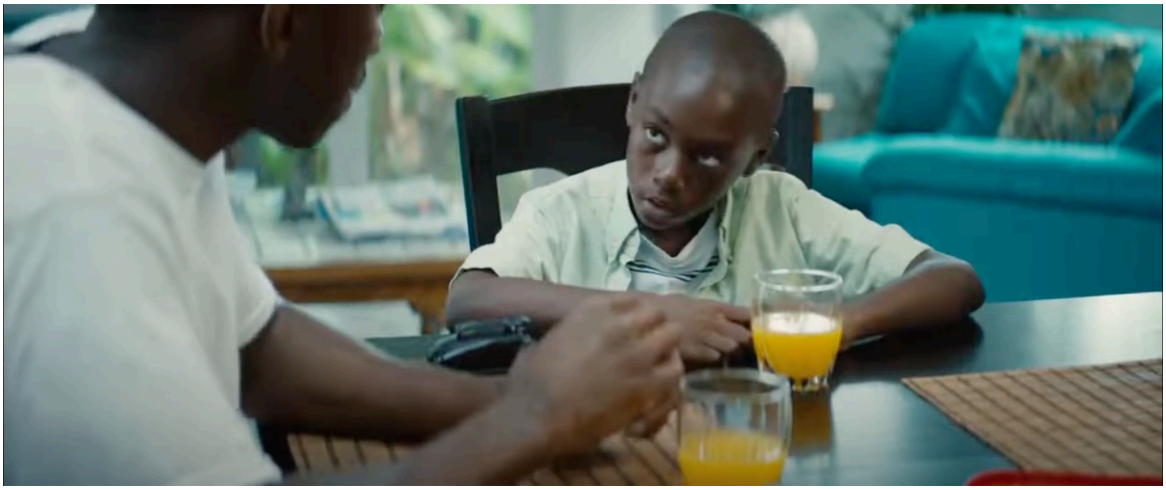
Little considering that, bobbing in the ocean as he treads. His eyes on the water stretching out before him, endless. Even in this dying light, stretching on forever.

Meets Juan's gaze now. Finds compassion, hope there.

Off Juan...

EXT. MIAMI BEACH, SHORE - DAY

CONVERSATIONS OVER JUICE



Teresa stepping in, sets down some kind of juice before them, a glass for Juan, a glass for Little. Juan about to take a sip of his when...

LITTLE
What's a faggot?

Juan... blindsided by that one, unprepared and unequipped to answer that.
Takes a sip of his juice, a deep breath and...

JUAN
A faggot is... a word used to make gay people feel bad.

Little nodding, processing that.

LITTLE Am I a faggot?

JUAN
No.
You're not a faggot.
(and)
You can be *gay*, but... you don't have to let nobody call you a faggot.
(and after a beat) Not unless…

Juan looking to Teresa; Teresa motioning him to quit while he's ahead.
He takes another sip of that juice.

LITTLE How do I know?

Again a look to Teresa, a shrug of the shoulders from her:

JUAN
You... you just do.
(and) I think.

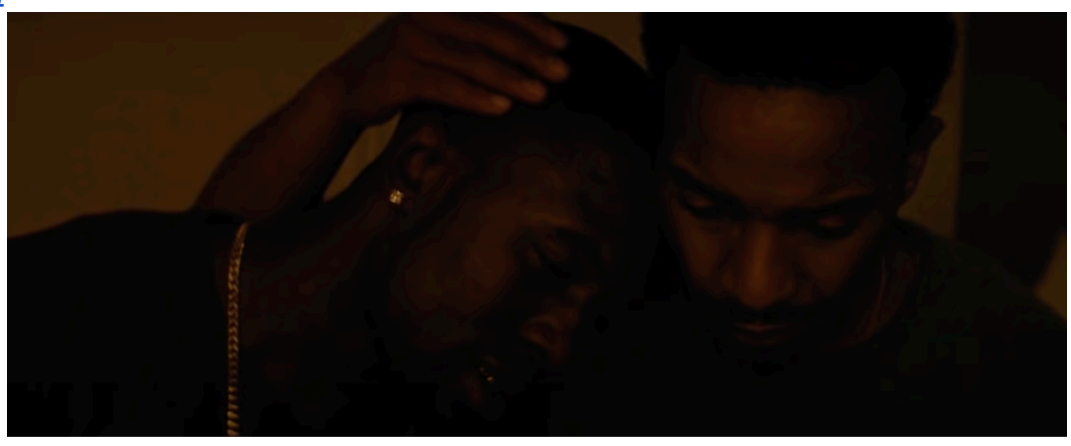
Little with both hands around his juice, all his senses focused there as his mind goes somewhere altogether different, clearly thinking deeply, forthrightly about this.
Juan reaching his cup back to Teresa:

JUAN (sotto)
Gin.
(and to Little)
You don't have to know right now, you feel me?
(and) Not yet.

Little nodding, from his demeanor comforted by this. In this state, so wounded and curious, invites the empathy.
Little's eyes shifting gears. For a considerable beat, is completely to himself, mulling something over. Lifts his eyes.

An equally powerful scene is when Chiron asks Juan "am I a fa**ot?" Right before he responds to him, he fully, Juan shakes his head and says "No··· no···". You expect the next words out of his mouth to be "you're not a fa**ot". Barry Jenkins knows the audience would expect this and sublimely has Juan fire back "you could be gay, but you ain't going to let anyone call you no fa**ot". For all the ill perceived activities that society would slight Juan for, his unquestioned acceptance of Chiron fleshes out the depth of his character. It's revealed during this scene why he's attached himself to Chiron, as his own mother seemingly struggled with drugs and was non-existent in his life. Mahershala Ali's performance absolutely steals the movie for the limited time that he's in it.

ENDING



The final act is fittingly titled "iii. Black," where we witness an adult Chiron, now nearly unrecognizable. This casting choice is brilliant because this version of Chiron feels almost like Juan reincarnated. The fight and subsequent arrest at the end of the second act serve as a pivotal moment, transforming Chiron drastically. Now, he's a drug dealer in Atlanta, a far cry from the Chiron we once knew. The significance of Juan's character, although limited to the first act, is deeply felt in this final chapter. During the entire first act, Chiron speaks only to Juan, maintaining a monk-like silence towards every other adult figure. It's no surprise that in adulthood, Chiron emulates Juan's appearance—wearing a do-rag, sporting similar ear piercings, and adopting Juan's profession. He has essentially followed in the footsteps of the father figure he never had. There are subtle details that beckon memories of his old life in Miami. Chiron still dunks his face in cold water, reminiscent of the day when Kevin beat him up. Speaking of Kevin, his influence on Chiron is palpable, even in Atlanta. Chiron drives a muscle car similar to the one Kevin had, and most significantly, he goes by the name "Black," a nickname Kevin gave him. This name serves a deeper purpose, perhaps reflecting Barry Jenkins' exploration of what it means to be black. Chiron's interpretation of being black is equated to being a hardened drug dealer—a reflection of how society often molds the lives of black men. Jenkins suggests that black men adapt to crime and chaos surrounding them, regardless of the damage it causes to their inner selves. Much of Chiron's current persona is a façade, epitomized by the grill he wears. When he returns to Miami to reconnect with Kevin, Kevin sees through this act immediately. He knows the gold teeth are merely for show, because he understands the true Chiron beneath the exterior. Kevin's demand— "take those damn grills out, that's not who you are"—captures this insight. When offered alcohol by Kevin during dinner, Chiron initially rejects it, saying he "can't really taste it." This rejection can be interpreted in two ways: suppression and isolation. The first interpretation is tied to his suppressed sexuality, suggesting that indulging in alcohol might unearth feelings he has tried to bury. The notion of an ambiguously sexual lifestyle is something he's forsaken, requiring him to suppress any related indulgence. The second interpretation delves into a philosophical realm: isolation. His comment about not tasting the alcohol signifies an inability to enjoy life's pleasures. He tells Kevin that he only drinks water, the purest beverage, which may symbolize his chosen path of emotional isolation in Atlanta. His transformation into a hardened figure is symbolized by his massive body build, a stark contrast to his slender, vulnerable frame from childhood. This physical change is a personal armor, designed so no one would dare question his sexuality. It's a defensive front he has adopted both to protect and isolate himself from the world around him. The ending scene of the formidable movie reads as follows:

Kevin comes back over, settles. Muted music from that kitchen radio. He takes up his glass of water and enjoys another sip.
Black fixes him in his sights, more directly than before:
BLACK
You're the only man who's ever touched me.
The air going out of Kevin's chest, his gaze fixated on Black's lips, anticipating the words falling from there:
BLACK
The only one.
Black's hand is flat atop the table between them. His eyes lower to it.
BLACK
I haven't really touched anyone, since.
INT. KEVIN'S APARTMENT, BEDROOM - NIGHT 98
Black sitting at the foot of the bed, fully clothed, hands clasped between his knees, leaned over slightly.
Kevin standing before him, frozen.
They hold each other's eyes an interminable beat.
Black stands shakily. Kevin watches him as he closes the space between them, drawing right up to him. Kevin takes a hand and lays it flat against Black's chest.
A puzzled look coming over Kevin's face.
KEVIN You shakin'.
BLACK Yeah.
KEVIN Wait.
Kevin crosses the doorway, flips a switch:
TOTAL DARKNESS
...only the soft thudding of feet crossing the floor. Another beat, then, under darkness:
BLACK I'm shakin'.
KEVIN Yeah.
BLACK I'm still shakin'.
KEVIN Yeah.
The SOUND of bodies touching, the beginning of things, then...
...another sound rising -- from afar -- the SOUND of waves crashing, rushing onto shore.

And mingling with that rush of waves, the sound of lips and hands, the joining of bodies, somewhere in this darkness Black and Kevin re-learning one another as we
CUT TO...
EXT. OCEAN - NIGHT 99
Those waves heard crashing moments earlier on full display, rushing ashore at a frothy run. Dark out, extremely dark save for the lights of beach bars a ways down the ocean front. The undulating rhythms of the Atlantic catch the moon, glint it all over.
As we observe this movement of water and dance of light, shoulders appear, bare, gaunt: LITTLE from our opening episode.
Calmly, methodically, Little moves across the sand, approaching the water. A beat more of Little easing up to the surf, then...
...he looks back: his dark skin moistened in the ocean spray, moon catching him same as its catching the surface of the Atlantic.
And those eyes: looking right at us, staring plaintively, plainly, nothing requested, no expectation: just a clear, undisturbed openness.
Hold this gaze, then...
...Little turning from us, his form and movement slowly, steadily melding into the flow of light and waves as we heads out into the ocean and we...
FADE TO BLACK.

The ending of *Moonlight* can leave viewers feeling slightly unfulfilled. Chiron, now known as Black, confesses to Kevin that he is the only person who has ever touched him and that he hasn't had a sexual experience since. Rather than concluding with a sexual encounter, which could have felt disingenuous and cheap, the film opts for a more poignant resolution. The final scene shows Kevin holding Chiron as the screen fades to black, offering a more realistic ending. Chiron has spent most of his life emotionally isolated, and this moment signifies a step toward hope and truth. He has found someone who accepts him as he is and is willing to invest time in him. Discussions about *Moonlight* often center on its exploration of sexuality. While the film certainly addresses this theme, it is reductive to label it as purely a sexual film. *Moonlight* delves deeper into Chiron's journey of self–discovery. It portrays a black man grappling with his sexuality in a society that often challenges and outright rejects him. The film raises questions about masculinity and societal expectations imposed on young black men. *Moonlight* masterfully navigates these complex themes, offering a profound and nuanced narrative. With a vivid use of color, an impressive cinematography and carefully crafted soundtrack were all present within the movie, it is a masterpiece.

Counter Case 2: *Call Me By Your Name*
Call Me By Your Name directed by Luca Guadagnino, is a symphony of dreams rendered on the canvas of Northern Italy's incandescent summer of 1983. The plot traces the evocative, almost surreal romance between 17 year old prodigy Elio Perlman, portrayed by Timothée Chalamet, and the enigmatic graduate student, Oliver, played by Armie Hammer. Upon Oliver's arrival at Elio's family's villa—a setting that feels lifted from a fantastical reverie—time itself seems to lose its linearity, becoming a fluid stream of golden afternoons and starlit nights. The film, much like a surrealist painting, layers its narrative with symbols and dreamlike sequences, blurring the boundary between reality and the ethereal. The characters move through an idyllic Italian landscape as if in a waking dream, with the lush gardens, ancient ruins, and whispering rivers serving as a backdrop for their burgeoning connection. Every glance and touch between Elio and Oliver feels weighted with an almost surreal intensity, capturing the mesmeric and often disorienting nature of first love. The sense of time is elastic, with moments of poignant interaction suspended in the amber glow of memory and desire. The characters' emotions unfurl in a series of poetic, almost hallucinatory scenes that evoke a sense of timelessness and otherworldliness. The film's soundtrack, an evocative blend of classical and contemporary music, amplifies this suspension, enveloping viewers in a cocoon of sensory and emotional overlap. "Call Me By Your Name" transcends mere romance to become a meditation on the surreal and transient nature of human connection, painting a dreamscape where love and longing intermingle in the luminous haze of a summer that seems to exist outside the bounds of ordinary time. The film, unlike *Moonlight* which was only respected and acknowledged for the wonder it was within the Black community, was widely acclaimed and had mainstream appreciation. This suggests its truth of easily consumable content which can be appreciated by a deeply unconscious white populus.

THE KISS

ELIO
I come here to escape the known world.
OLIVER
I like the way you say things. Why
are you always putting yourself down?
ELIO (shrugging)
I don't know. So you won't, I suppose.
OLIVER
Are you so scared of what others
think? Or what I think?

ELIO shakes his head. OLIVER waits for ELIO to say something. He stares at him.
In the silence of the moment, ELIO stares back. It is the first time ELIO has dared to stare back at OLIVER openly.
Before this moment he has always cast a glance, then looked away from Oliver's steely gaze. It is as if, finally, ELIO is saying to Oliver: This is who I am, this is who you are, this is what I want.

OLIVER (CONT'D)
You're making things very difficult for me.

ELIO doesn't back down. Neither does OLIVER.
OLIVER sits down on the grass, then lies down on his back, his arms under his head, staring at the sky. Elio lays down next to him.

ELIO
I love this, Oliver.
OLIVER
What? This? Us, you mean?
ELIO That too.

ELIO doesn't reply. OLIVER moves up close to him. Very close. He stares right in Elio's face, as though he likes Elio's face and wants to study it, linger on it.
OLIVER touches Elio's lower lip with his finger, lets it travel left and right, then right and left again. OLIVER smiles at ELIO as he lies there, and that very smile fills ELIO with a kind of apprehension about what will happen next.
What happens next is that OLIVER brings his lips to Elio's mouth in a warm I'll-meet-you-halfway-but-no-further kiss, a conciliatory kiss. ELIO's return kiss is so famished he loses himself in it.

OLIVER (afterwards)
Better now?

ELIO doesn't answer. He kisses OLIVER again, lifting his face, as if to discover more, know more. Even with their faces touching, their bodies are angles apart. ELIO lifts one knee as if to face OLIVER.

OLIVER (CONT'D) I think we should go.

ELIO Not yet.

OLIVER

We can't do this - I know myself.

So far we've behaved. We've been good. Neither of us has done anything to feel ashamed of. Let's keep it that way. I want to be good.

ELIO reaches for OLIVER in a quick, desperate move, lets his hand rest on Oliver's crotch. OLIVER doesn't move. With total composure, in a gesture that is both gentle and commanding, he brings his own hand there, letting it rest on Elio's for a second. He twines his fingers into Elio's, then lifts his hand. A moment of silence.

ELIO

(suddenly abashed by his

own action) Did I offend you?

OLIVER Just don't.

He gives Elio his hand and helps him stand up. He pulls up his shirt to examine the scrape.

OLIVER (CONT'D)

I should make sure it doesn't get

infected.

ELIO

We can stop by the pharmacist on

the way back.

EXT. ROAD - DAY

While this scene is riddled with surrealist content both visually, with beautiful scenery and the sounds of nature almost silently replacing a backdrop, as well as based in identity. More accurately the denial of identity as the most poignant element of this scene is vulnerability met with shame and false notions of self. Oliver claiming, "I know myself" and "So far we've been well behaved[...] neither of us has done anything to feel ashamed of", but as he claims the latter, his mannerisms and emotive energy claim otherwise. To the point Elio must abashedly ask "Did I offend you?" All in all, the scene portrays the limitations of being sexually homogenous as a white male in a societal structure that they created. It illuminates the double edged nature of a sword designed for external parties harming the oneself.

Analysis

Literary Case Studies

The literary arts cases composed of literary works, poetry, fiction, and idioms each provide a different lens of expressing consciousness, self, identity, and liberation in a surrealist fashion. Writing showcases some of the largest gaps between Afro and classical surrealism. Du Bois and Baldwin speak on a densely true and heavy hearted reality. There writings come from an understanding of darkness and polarization in this reality that the Western art feels far more light in comparison. Which is not so say it is devoid of meaning, but simply to highlight the poignancy of the effect that enduring suffering can have on the mind, soul, and physical over time.

Visual Case Studies

While an analysis on the still life will be omitted as the subjectivity to the pieces are incredibly pronounced, the exhibition and film media have incredible depth. In both the Cases forAfrosurrealism and Counter Cases in classic, or outside Afro, surrealist derivative. Especially within the exhibitions do we see the potential for the multi sensory accessibility to offer a far more universal experience. In Ase: AfroFrequencies we see an illuminating encouragement to remember and preserve a cultural past whilst standing headfast against observation. In Timeless Butterflies we see the cyclical pattern of rebirth while being thrown into nature. Neto's Nosso Barco Tambor Terra highlights a structure of interconnected pieces that create a stronger, interactive, and spicy whole, similar to this universe. At Luminescence, the geometric light figures paired with the live choir created an unbelievably alive environment. These all reflect an artistic showing of universal knowledge natural to the human subconscious and expressed through surrealist efforts. Deeper so when considering the Case Films. Both *Get Out* and *Moonlight* highlight the otherness of experiencing the more traumatic effects of Blackness as a consequence to imperialism. Space and time being incredibly relative, it is unknowable the true impact the mark such deep suffering left on the larger collective. *Get Out* highlighting the mystifying nature of a history of outsourcing Black peoples energies and *Moonlight* shining light on the versatility of intersectionality within Blackness and additional identities.

Results

Ultimately consciousness is a choice. Being aware of that fact is subject to an individual's awakening and previous experiences within suffering and faith, these two will set the precedent on their willingness to accept the meaning of life with an open heart or reject the truth of nature stemming further into the ego and hubris even when exploring spiritual topics. This then reflects onto the nature of surrealist art as it exists that life imitates art imitates life imitates art imitates. So the further expansion of half awakened art will proctor a half awakened collective and further individual. As opposed to a fully awakened culture reflected in the art, spirit, and community. As the art demonstrates, there is profound meaning in the nature of Afrosurreal art that is quite lacking in classical surrealism. There is equally a presence of community, hierarchical structures, as well as spiritual content within AfroSurrealism whereas its adversary, classical surrealism, is rooted in individualism, ego, and single monotheistic structures. This does not hinder from examples of profound surrealism outside the framework of the African natures as seen in MAAT Museum's Ernesto Neto exhibit and the Luminance Museum Paris. Although there exist differences between the two as the former is still deeply rooted in cultural significance whereas the latter is leaning more towards the meaningless end, although a grand showing of hueful existence.

RQ Answers

Q1 No, the origins of surrealism as documented in modern history is another element of existence that has been subjected to gentrification of thought and truth. As the literature review and methodology suggest, surrealist nature was innate to African communities, oral history, and spiritual understanding before explicit definition and before European claims and gentrification.

Q2 The largest difference is consistent with the original thesis of the meaning of life. However, the power of surrealist art is not exclusive to African depictions as other ethnicities who have experienced their share of discrimination, suffering, and faith. These individuals can successfully manage to create a powerful and moving surrealist piece of work.

> SubQ1 These manifestations wharp current concepts on suffering relationship to morphing space and time, identity, and portrayal of art subjective truth as the Black conscious is still carrying the scars from a long lasting and continuous persecution by white hands. This, while creating physical realm based suffering and limitations, provide spiritual strength in overcoming adversity and creating further communal connection that is clearly portrayed within AfroSurrealist Art.
>
> SubQ2 The trigger that results in inter community dissociation is pain and injustice without expression and community healing. This goes for both the African community in obvious ways, but also the white populus as denial of truth, suppression of guilt, and individualistic living has its own wounds and scars held onto the spiritual realm, while presenting as facade-ed strength in the physical. This can be avoided by encouraging the positive triggers that can be leveraged for inter-community healing, such as acknowledgement and rest within truth and absolution of sins with reparations and repertory action.

Framework for Future Studies

It would be wonderful to further explore these themes on a physical, neurological level by way of EEG/MEG studies with participants of all cultures. Visual art stimuli being the basis of study and the outcome possibly varying by background and exposure to faith, suffering, and awareness. Another curious exploration would be the inclusion of audible media. 'Binaural' meaning the ability to hear with both ears, and the concept of Afrosurrealism, that deals with time and experience of black people is an interesting road to go down. From abstraction to isolation, the sounds of Afrosurrealism represent the present day and future-past experiences of black people through the mystical and metaphorical. Music considered Afrosurrealist has nuances between the internal and collective experiences that black people have heard and felt. The term "Binaural-Blackness", would describe the musical aesthetics of afrosurrealism, based on the feelings and experiences the artists have. Afrosurrealist music especially in hip-hop and R&B with dark, atmospheric production is such a wide and expansive field that could work well with this framework of study.

Conclusion

To conclude, as this is an artistic study, subjective to the viewer, the results are parallel. However, this paper draws that being aware of that fact is subject to an individual's awakening and previous experiences within suffering and faith, these two will set the precedent on their willingness to accept the meaning of life with an open heart or reject the truth of nature stemming further into the ego and hubris even when exploring spiritual topics. This then reflects onto the nature of surrealist art as it exists that life imitates art imitates life imitates art imitates. There is equally a presence of community, hierarchical structures, as well as spiritual content within AfroSurrealism whereas its adversary, classical surrealism, is rooted in individualism, ego, and single monotheistic structures. Moreover, it is proven that surrealist art is not exclusive to African depictions as other ethnicities who have experienced their share of discrimination, suffering, and faith

Authors Note
My name is Obiari Ugwu-Uche and as an Igbo born and bred Nigerian woman, exploring these narratives and creating this thesis was as equally healing as it was truly and deeply amusing. I'd like to give thanks to Nnena Ugwu-Uche, my mother. Without her upbringing, I would have never known the deep spiritual power of African culture or half of the proverbs included in this paper.

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